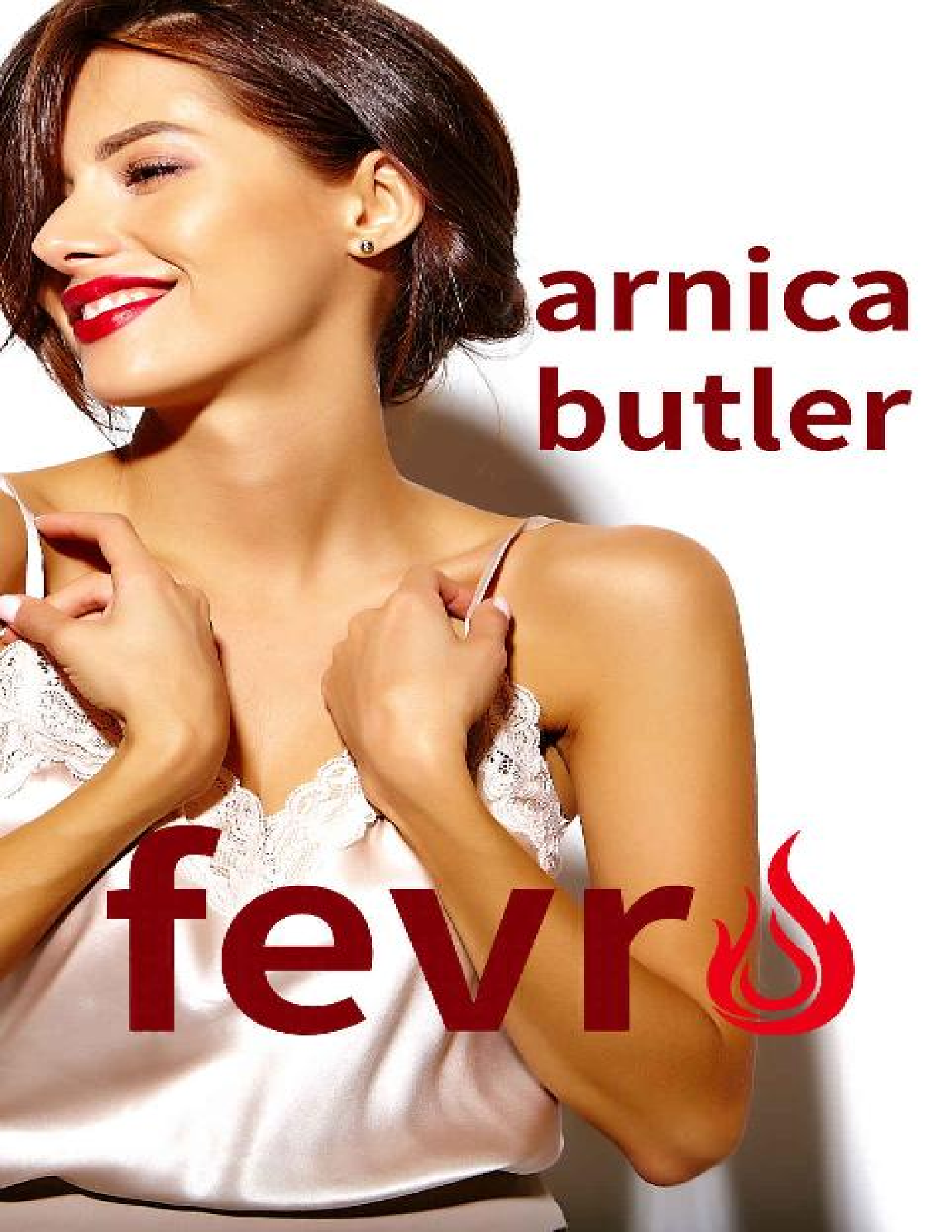




**arnica
butler**

fevr 

FEVR

By Arnica Butler

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CHAPTER 1

Meri dug her fingers into Joel's arm suddenly and ferociously, emitting a theatrical gasp at the same time and bringing her free hand to her chest.

It gave Joel a jolt of adrenaline, even though he was used to his wife being... well, a little theatrical. But for a moment, he was sure she was choking, and someone else at their table did as well. Some dreg from accounting, who had been eyeing Meri all night long and would probably have loved to give her mouth-to-mouth.

Meri's fingers dug in deeper, but by the time Joel turned his head in concern, she was turning hers, her large mouth smiling, her eyes full of mischief. She brought her chest-clutching hand to her mouth to block the rest of the table from lip-reading what she was saying next, an action that was rendered necessary by the fact that Meri had a sexy, gravelly voice that she could not seem to excise completely from her whispers.

"Oh my God," she purred. "I just remembered I have something crazy to tell you. About Lena. Don't let me forget."

Applause had erupted as the president of Joel's company wrapped up a long speech, drowning out Meri's confession, which was a relief to Joel, who didn't need Lena's attention drawn to them. Lena, Joel noted, had drawn Meri's attention (and probably everyone's else's) by rising from her chair before the speech was over and writhing through the tables to reach the bar.

It was doubtful that anyone was troubled by the distraction provided by Lena's voluptuous body, wrapped this evening in a white, gauzy fabric that should have, but somehow did not, reveal whether she was wearing underwear or not. It was a long-standing "mission" among some of the more frat-boyish types at work to settle once and for all the grand question of whether Lena's carpet matched the drapes.

Joel put his hand on Meri's fingers, which she had relaxed. Reddened half-moons pockmarked his forearm. "You want something to drink?" he asked her.

Meri shot a glance at the bar, where Lena was leaning provocatively, her round ass framed nicely in the gauzy fabric, her tanned legs exposed from the very top of her thigh down, silver heels propping the whole business up like a sculpture.

Joel picked up on a certain amount of distrust from Meri toward Lena, but not the usual catty resentment that most of the other wives felt toward her. The clichés manifested themselves every year at the Christmas party and a company barbecue held in July. Most of the staff at TopperRep was male, and spent long hours at work, and some of them had apartments in the city, and then there was Lena: huge tits, nice figure, red hair, and... well, not exactly a passive personality when it came to men. Like all good clichés, Lena was the main secretary. She'd slit your throat if you called her that, though. And then you'd also find out just how bad your life could get if the *office manager* didn't like you for a few days.

The references to *Mad Men* had been made time and again, except they didn't exactly fit, because Lena was married, and as far as Joel knew, she hadn't slept with anyone in the office.

Hence the eternal carpet and drapes question.

But Lena's apparent virtues and commitment to her marriage vows did not endear her to any of the wives, whose sharp glares at Lena's back could have been used in industrial applications normally reserved for diamonds and lasers.

Meri, however, was not a glarer. She actually seemed to admire Lena. Joel thought it was probably because Meri knew who held all the cards in her and Joel's relationship. It was slightly infuriating to him, if he somehow could have been cornered into thinking about it. Meri felt so secure in their marriage – because Meri was young, and beautiful, and Joel was so obviously smitten with her – that she didn't perceive the dual spherical bounties of Lena's chest to be a threat.

"Get me a white wine. No, a beer. Oh I don't know... something fun, surprise me. You meant that kind of drink, right?" Meri bubbled, her eyes following Lena as Lena returned to her table. Meri's mouth was upturned slightly, her brow somewhat furrowed, and her attention so obviously *not* on her drink order that she barely took notice of Joel leaving.

He considered ordering her a Shirley Temple, because that was the sort of joke that Meri would laugh at 95% of the time. Her very large features, a hair short of being cartoonish, would burst open: teeth, red lips, crinkled nose, watering eyes, and she would slap him playfully. She would admit to spacing out, drink her Shirley Temple without complaint, her lips on a straw in a vaguely sexual way. She'd bite into the cherry and enclose it sensually

in her mouth. “Sorry,” she would half-honk, as an apology for not paying attention.

It was a joke, because twelve years ago, when they had met, Meri had been trapped in a section of a party where no alcohol was being served, and Joel had rescued her, and her Shirley Temple. They hadn’t started dating for years – a long story, almost too rom-commy to be believed – largely because Joel was so much older than her that he didn’t ask her out at the time. Now that he was 45, graying, feeling neck pain in the morning from his pillow, his twelve years on Meri seemed like a lifetime, or a generation (technically, they fell in different generations, which made for different jokes that Meri absolutely despised).

But Joel was worried about the 5% of the time that Meri didn’t like Shirley Temple jokes, which only meant that she wouldn’t laugh. Meri not laughing at a joke like that would devastate him more than if she slapped him in the face, because Meri no longer finding him funny was the first step toward Meri realizing that she could do better, the first step on a hypothetical path that could lead, eventually, to her packing up her things to go and find something - or someone - better.

This was, as Meri would often declare imperiously, utter nonsense. Which Joel agreed to for the purposes of ending arguments and saving face. But privately, he let the idea fester.

He sort of enjoyed thinking of Meri leaving him for a younger, hotter, more virile man, although in a very perverse way.

“White wine,” he told her, setting a glass down by her fingers.

Meri squeezed his shoulder conspiratorially and put her mouth close to his left ear. Her breath was hot and sent a shudder straight to his groin as she whispered loudly to him. “Do you want to know what it is?”

He arranged his own drink – whiskey, no ice – neatly on the table and grinned. He didn’t really care what she was about to tell him; he’d almost forgotten Lena completely. But Meri’s lips had grazed his neck, and her long neck was under his nose, her perfume-free scent rising to his nostrils with the heat of her body.

“So, I saw this guy at work, Marvin, you know who that is? He’s like, my age, works in market research, black hair... uh, like maybe my age, maybe older...?”

Joel looked over to Lena, who had slipped her arm around her husband, the kind of guy you could imagine being able to handle a woman

like Lena. He had a neck like a tree trunk and was always smiling, but you got the sense that he'd snapped a few people in half somewhere in his past and wasn't against doing it again, though only because of a court order, or something like that.

Joel smiled, and Meri continued her story, lowering her voice. Joel knew exactly who the character in question was, because he was the only black man at Meri's work and he had the glint of a jackal in his eyes. It was amusing to hear Meri tripping all over herself to avoid using the descriptor "black," which would have solved the problem instantly. He let her ramble on, then nodded, still smiling, wondering what Marvin could have to do with Lena. Arousal was stirring his cock to life.

But it might have been Meri's red dress doing that; the thin straps slipping from her left shoulder, a plunge in her neckline allowing him to look down into the shadowed valley between her milky breasts.

"I know who Marvin is," he finally said, in a low voice. Still smiling. Watching the movement of Meri's lower lip, her slow, steady pulse beneath her skin in the hollow of her collarbone, the form of her body under the red silk that shifted over her curves with each slight movement.

"So Marvin was in the lunch room and he was on Fevr. On his phone, you know? And he set it down for a second and there's a picture of Lena. Right? Right on there, and I know it's her... I mean, she's pretty recognizable..." Meri's voice, growing lower and lower as she talked about Lena, began to become so husky and gravel-like that it was irresistible. More than once, probably even quite often, people had referred to Meri as "the one with the hot voice," or something similar.

She sipped her wine and leaned back to Joel. "So I couldn't help myself, I pick it up and I'm like, 'is this woman on Fevr or what, Marvin?' And he's like, 'yeah, she's hot.' And I look, and sure enough, this is Lena. She used her own name, it's right there, on the screen." Meri sat back, looking at Lena and her husband. She shook her head, brought the wine to her lips, and then leaned forward to speak to Joel "privately" again.

"So I tell Marvin, right... 'dude, I hate to burst your bubble, but I know this woman, she works with my husband. And she is married, last I checked.'"

Meri's eyes blinked slowly, as she focused on Lena's seated figure, but in a dreamlike way, as though Lena's actual physical presence was just a portal to another dimension, and she was looking into it for the first time.

Joel nudged her after an uncomfortably long pause.

“He says,” Meri continued, turning to Joel as though the conversation had never stalled. Her large, wet eyes, which were so big that they gave her a deceptively innocent look and made her appear preserved at the age of 25 for all time, blinked slowly. “He says, ‘I know!’ And I am like, ‘what?’ And he’s just like, ‘Yeah, I know that,’ and gets back to swiping on his phone.”

Meri sat back and sipped her wine, peering at Joel over the rim of the glass as though the story had conclusively concluded, and what-did-he-think-of-that?

“*Lena?*” he said, confused.

Meri returned to “whispering” loudly. “Her name, it was right there, and, I mean... it’s not like some other, hot, married, Lena Stiller with red hair like... like... that,” Meri gesticulated in Lena’s direction, because the brightness of Lena’s wild orange hair was, truthfully, somewhat indescribable. It was an orange shade which was usually ugly on women and hideous on men, but Lena made it work. Wonders. And beyond. “...is going to be, you know... well, exist. It was Lena. Definitely Lena.” She set her glass down after a long swallow. “I mean, how many Lena Stillers do you even think there are in the *world?*”

It was a question, Joel thought nerdily, that could probably be answered by a computer or Google, but he was more interested in something else.

“Why were you looking at Marvin’s Fevr?” he whispered hoarsely. And then, dodging the question: “Did he go *out* with her?”

Meri shook her head solemnly. “I have no idea,” she said, ignoring the first half of his question.

They stared at the back of Lena’s head, a glossy orange bob that was never out of place.

“So you and Marvin,” Joel said in a low voice, grinning. “You have lunch together a lot?”

Meri, ordinarily, would have done one of two things – ignored the comment, or rolled her eyes and said something like, “Oh my God,” before drinking her wine and rolling her eyes some more. Joel hated himself every time he played the jealous husband, because he always made it into a big joke, and he knew that Meri took this for insecurity, which it pretty much was.

But that wasn't why he was angry with himself when he said things like that and Meri rolled her eyes. Because there was also something else - something other than jealousy or insecurity - that Joel felt when he asked Meri questions about other men. Something lurid and desirous, and he had a feeling it was wrong in the same way that watching certain kinds of porn was mildly wrong.

Instead of rolling her eyes, Meri was silent, her mouth open slightly as her eyes jiggled a little. Like she could scan the answer to this question from the thin air.

"Of course not," she said. The words were hurried, almost hysterical. "God. No, no... I just... he was there, and his phone was there, and I just saw it and I saw it was Lena, and so of course I asked him about it." She made a tisking sound, and it ended up sounding a bit like a snort. She reached for her glass, and took a very long sip of wine.

She then began over-explaining, which was interesting, because Meri only ever over-explained when she thought she had done something wrong. "It isn't like I planned to be there. In the break room or anything. God. I don't even know when... Marvin's in a totally different department, I barely know him..."

She seemed to realize she was explaining too much, gave a guilty shrug to stop herself talking, and then, as though she had suddenly remembered an important step in a process, rolled her eyes.

"I just think it's interesting about Lena, is all." She looked back in Lena's direction. "Do you think her husband knows?"

Joel filed Meri's interesting, blabbering reaction to his question about lunch with Marvin under "dark thoughts to savor at another time," and turned his attention to the more immediate, very interesting information about Lena.

They both looked at Lena and her husband. As a couple, they were physically affectionate almost to the point of being obscene, and tonight didn't seem like it would be any different.

"He *can't* know," Meri said, as if Joel had asked her the question. "God."

Joel said nothing.

"Can you imagine?" Meri said.

And when Joel still said nothing, Meri added another comment in a low whisper: "I mean, Marvin said that there are women who just do this.

And -” Meri looked at Joel, and then cut herself off.

An announcement was made that the first round of meals would be served to tables one through ten. Their own table, number nine, stood up to make their way to a buffet line.

“And?” Joel prompted, when Meri remained seated.

Meri had a strange smile forming on her mouth. Her lips twisted, as if she didn’t know what expression she wanted to wear, and she was trying them all on for size. “It’s just...” She laughed, and a blush very briefly burnt her cheeks, before fading to her natural white. She shook her head. “I can’t even say it.”

Joel’s interest was piqued. Meri wasn’t known to be particularly bashful. She was, in fact, very open-minded about almost everything. It didn’t mean she would *do* almost anything – if anything, Meri was frustratingly conservative in her own behavior. But she rarely cared or judged what other people did. This aspect of her personality made people like Meri a lot: she was always interested, never trying to impose her own views on people, not even implicitly. When someone said something outrageous, she usually laughed and made a diplomatic comment.

“You can’t even say it?” Joel said, smiling. “Well, now, you have to.”

Another flash of red stained Meri’s face, this time staying. She wrinkled her nose and rubbed it with the back of her fingers. “No. Yeah. Okay... so, this is just Marvin talking, and he might have been messing with me...” she looked at Joel, her eyes wide, her lips gradually settling on an embarrassed smile. She leaned so close to him their foreheads struck each other, and she reached up to rub her own head before shielding her mouth again, even though no one remained at the opposite side of their table. She gave a quick look behind her, before whispering – this time, actually whispering: “He says she’s the kind of woman who hooks up with...” She paused, gave another sweep of the room with her eyes. “Black guys – just black guys, specifically. To have sex with them.”

It was Joel’s turn to let his eyes get big, though he suspected that his reasons for looking like that were not the same as Meri’s. “No,” he managed to say.

Inwardly, he was becoming concerned that Meri had stumbled onto his porn-watching history, and was now playing some sort of “Gotcha” game.

“I *know!*” Meri proclaimed.

They looked at each other, then at the buffet line.

“I guess we should go get our food,” Joel said, uncertainly. He still couldn't tell if Meri was on a fishing expedition or not.

Meri nodded, the movement a little sloppy. She had probably reached her limit on alcohol, if Joel were to judge based on her physical movements, which were becoming even more exaggerated than usual. Meri was an enthusiastic gesticulator, but if you added alcohol it went slightly out of control. It was an endearing quality to anyone who knew her, but it could cause a lot of damage when she was tipsy.

They stood up, and made their way to the buffet table, saying nothing more about the subject.

Joel tried to keep his eyes trained on the line in front of them. Meri's hair, loosely gathered in a bun at the nape of her neck, shining and glorious, slightly mahogany in color, accented by the lighting in the ballroom. But he stole a few glances at Lena and her husband Chance, each time seeing them entwined or touching, Lena's hand on Chance's chest in a carnal embrace.

Meri seemed to have forgotten all about it, picking over the food and expressing delight at each item. “Oh my God, eggrolls!” she gasped. “And what are these things, some kind of wonton?” She turned to Joel, a fried item in her fingers, and made it hop. “Look how cute.” She looked at it, scrutinizing the outside shell. “I wonder what's in it?” she asked, placing it and three of its cohorts on her plate. “Oh look, soups. Crud, I don't have a bowl.”

It went on like this to the end of the buffet table, as it would, as if everything in Meri's world were just fine. Of course Meri could say something about a married woman like Lena having an affair with a black man, or maybe lots of black men, and then leave that subject to be enthralled by a Chinese buffet.

Not Joel. That was the sort of track he couldn't get his mind off of.

He was building up a sweat between his shoulder blades. A droplet was forming, growing fat enough to start to roll down his spine.

Was she trying to get him to confess to his own dirty thoughts? What if Meri knew, somehow, despite his keeping it locked up inside of him – for reasons of political correctness and moral judgment not to mention a fear of what Meri would think of him if she knew – that he had more than once (*way* more than once) indulged in a fantasy involving his own wife, and black men? What if all Meri wanted right now was to trap him into saying that he had a fantasy like that?

Had she scoured his porn? His mind raced to each time he had indulged in watching porn, beginning with something innocuous but then, each time, ending up in the same place: watching black men pound petite white women, and the more reddish-brown the hair of those women, the better. What if Meri had somehow rifled through his brain and found the dirtiest corners, where he kept the thoughts of his wife and black men locked away in a cage, only to be taken out when he was alone?

If she was, it was a very sophisticated way to go about getting him to admit that he watched a lot of black men screwing white women who looked like his wife.

It wasn't possible, he reminded himself, drawing in a huge breath to chase away a shakiness that was developing in his core. Right? Meri wasn't a mind-reader, and his porn was on lockdown. He used a private browser, he ransacked his history files after the deed and then again the next day just to be sure that all traces of his midnight searches had been cleared from the computer, at least anywhere Meri might know to look.

Meri was looking at him now. "Babe?" she was saying. The only time she called him "babe" was when he didn't answer questions.

He looked at her blankly. His heart was refusing to stop kicking against his chest, and his gut felt like it was being unrolled and then pushed back into his abdomen. He raised his eyebrows.

Meri looked at him, astonished. "Wow," she said. "That really got to you. Sorry. I wouldn't have mentioned it if -"

"No," he said quickly. "No, no, it's not..." he sighed. "I just feel, a little... you know. Sick or something."

"Not because of this," he added hastily.

Meri put a hand on his shoulder and smiled. "You want to go home?" she asked cheerfully.

"I'm *fine*," he said, emphasizing "fine" to comedic effect.

Meri dropped something on his plate. "Oh... kay," she said. "Eat that. It's really tasty."

And she went back to the table.

If most men couldn't avoid looking at Lena, they also couldn't avoid straining their eyes a little to take in a few extra moments of Meri's passing form, as she slipped through the maze of pushed-back chairs to their table.

He often chalked up his thoughts about Meri at moments like this – when men were looking at her lustfully and he got to see their hungry

expressions – as generic male boastfulness. After all, Meri was a stunner. She was young, her hair was a glorious shade of mahogany that had no equivalent in the dye section, leading her to tell him that as soon as she got gray hair, she'd have to change it. She attracted the attention of men like moths to a light, and there were few women who could outshine her. Lena was the only one he knew of, and even compared to Lena, it might have been a draw as to who the men in the office found more attractive. He liked having a wife like Meri, a tangible, moving, talking trophy of a wife.

That he occasionally let his mind wander to darker places was just part of his natural pride and fear of losing her, he had decided. His gut would wrench and grow cold as he pictured Meri across the table from another man, her mouth open wide, her eyes laughing, wine slipping into her bloodstream. For some reason he wanted to go deeper into the fantasy: Meri kissing someone, Meri sitting on someone's lap, Meri with her hand on a big, black cock, eyes wide with amazement at the size of it.

He shook his head to scatter the thoughts away, but as soon as he was seated, Lena rose from her seat with her husband and set his mind wandering again.

Meri seemed to want to say no more about it, yet he had a few questions, especially about Marvin and Meri, and how close *they* were. But he kept them in, and after a few more drinks, the whole party was loose and scattering to different tables, Meri leaning over the back of her chair to talk to the wife of someone in accounting.

At one point in the evening, she turned officiously toward him and placed her hand on his forearm. "That's just between you and me," she said, confiding. "Don't go spreading any rumors."

This was hours after she mentioned Lena's Fevr account. It was typical of Meri to do something like that: drop a bombshell and then, when it fluttered through her mind again, add an important caveat. It was a sign that the news was interesting enough to share, but not interesting enough for her to dwell on.

This was good news, Joel thought.

Wasn't it?

"Of course," he said. "Er... of course not."

And that, as they say in the business, was that. At least for a while.

CHAPTER 2

“Oh,” Meri said, halting her passage through the lunchroom by jutting her butt back towards the door. She was holding a Tupperware full of fish soup in her hands.

Marvin was seated at a table in their lunchroom, which was a gorgeous and expensive area projecting into a raggedy patch of woods behind their office. Floor-to-ceiling windows enclosed three walls of the large room, and light wood floors and wood fixtures finished off the look. Outside the windows, the “forest” looked like it went on forever, unless you looked closely. It gave everyone who worked there the impression that this small slice of the building was actually an expensive cabin in the woods.

“Sorry,” she said. “I didn’t know -”

Marvin looked up from his phone and said nothing. Meri lifted her Tupperware and smiled, acting like a fool and knowing it. “I have fish, is all,” she said.

Why, she wondered silently, did she have to act like such an idiot around Marvin?

He was close to her age, which typically would have disadvantaged him, because Meri was attracted to older guys. She didn’t know or care why, it’s just how it worked.

Also, she was married. Happily married, and in love with her husband.

Marvin was trim and fit, and there was no doubt that very few women would have found him, well, objectionable. It was hard to ignore the shape of his muscles beneath his dress shirts, or the way he filled them out with his solid body. His face was attractive. But something about Marvin rattled her. Her eyes kept wandering to places they shouldn’t.

She chalked it up to Marvin’s cat-like personality. Whenever someone ignored her, she felt attracted to them. And it would be lying to say she wasn’t attracted to Marvin, that she didn’t enjoy any conversation she could get with him. That she had, without permission from her conscience or consciousness, pictured his cock and wondered about the size of it, on more than one occasion.

“It’s the lunch room,” Marvin said, amicably.

Meri stepped in, the door following her until it closed. “I know, it’s just, it’s so fishy.”

Marvin gave her a level look. She forced herself to return his gaze.

“You, uh, Fevring again?” she said, her voice loud. She wanted to change the subject, not that there even was a subject. She wanted to rescue the conversation from being awkward, even though it seemed pointless and impossible.

Marvin smiled and tipped his phone so that the screen faced her, the familiar colors of the encrypted email system visible from where she stood. “Oh,” she said. “Of course.”

She hustled to the microwave.

Marvin was behind her now, tapping on his screen. She could feel his presence, like it was radiating sensuality instead of heat. Her spine felt cooler than the rest of her body, giving her a metallic shiver from her tailbone right up to her neck.

She rolled her eyes at the microwave. Get a grip. She punched some numbers in and faced its glass door with determination while the soup heated.

Somewhere in the middle of the countdown, she lost control of her thoughts, and before she knew it she was wondering if Marvin was looking at her ass, and then, if he liked what he saw. She was wearing a dark suit and high heels, but the skirt was slightly looser than she liked. Black guys, she was thinking, usually liked big butts. She wondered if that was true -

She stopped herself.

God, what was she thinking?

On the other hand... it wasn’t as if she was actually thinking of doing any of the things she imagined. She just wanted Marvin to look at her ass so she would know it was good one.

Not that she didn’t, because it was a compliment she had received more than once.

She turned toward Marvin as the minutes ticked on, and when she found him staring right at her, her heart actually stopped. Her thoughts scattered and took flight, so about a hundred possible comments and actions flew around in her mind just before she blurted, without having thought about it at all:

“So, did you finally end up going on a date with Lena?” she asked.

It was Marvin's turn to have a strange expression on his face. "Lena," he said, as if he had never heard the name.

Meri's heart stopped again. What if she had mis-read his Fevr account, what if it wasn't Lena she had seen?

She waved her hand above her head, and around it. "Bright red hair? The one-"

"Ahhhhhh," Marvin interrupted. "Your hubby's gal, the one from his work," Marvin said. "*Lena*."

He made a sound, one typical to black men, in which he said, "Mmm," quickly, with a slight shake of the head. "Hot."

Meri was staring at him.

Something Meri would have been unable to tell you about herself was that she got away with a lot of impertinent questions because of her personality and her attractiveness, and something about the slightly juvenile quality of her face. Few people ever had disagreements with Meri, because she was pleasant, and because she looked like she might start crying if they did. And because she said things like this, in her breathy, sexy, low voice:

"I had no idea she was living a double life like that," she said, sitting down at Marvin's table. "So she... does her husband know about this?"

Marvin let out a laugh, rubbed his head, shook it, grinned, and looked at his phone. He gave the gadget a few tips back and forth. Meri stared at his arm muscles as they flexed and relaxed with the movement. "You could say so," Marvin said, his smile bigger. His teeth were incredibly white. "You *definitely* could say so."

Meri leaned forward on her arms. Half of her wanted to crawl into a hole and die of embarrassment, but that half of Meri was usually trumped by the curious side of Meri, and today would be no exception. "What does that mean?" she asked impishly.

Marvin's gaze flicked back to hers, and she looked away. "Means... he definitely knows," Marvin said, toneless except for a crack of a smile.

He waited. Meri knew he wanted her to look back at him, to ask more questions, to be interested in what he was saying. She wanted that herself. But she also had an instinct, one that felt very adolescent, to not give Marvin what he wanted.

It bothered her that she felt that way. She was always happy when office functions involved all departments, because she knew Marvin would be there.

She didn't want to fuck him, or have an affair with him.

She just liked the *idea* of all that. She liked flirting. Flirting in a situation where there was no chance of anything happening. Playing hard to get, hoping that it piqued his interest and maybe – the thought made her blush sometimes – that he would feel more attracted to her, or have pangs of unrequited love.

It was all silly, school-girl fantasy material. Nothing serious.

Also, she did not want to look like a total prude. Meri liked to think of herself as incredibly liberal, when in fact many of her personal views came down on a more conservative side.

Her eyes went down to his phone. "So, is this... you know how you were saying, women on there just are up-front about having affairs... is that, like, what you do on there?" she said. "All the time?"

Marvin grinned and leaned back in his chair. He sat with his huge, muscled legs spread wide. He was one of those guys who took up as much space as possible wherever he went. Which Meri found attractive as well, but would never have admitted to.

"I see," Marvin said, as though he really did see something. His eyes were glinting. "Why, you want a piece of this?"

He had his arms out hooked over chairs on either side of him, and he used his pointer fingers to make a trip down his abdomen until he was directing her gaze between his legs.

He was purely kidding, she could tell by his expression, and so she laughed and shook her head. "Pig," she said.

"Don't knock it," Marvin said, standing up to his height of 6 feet three inches, "til you try it. Your fish is done."

He was smiling, putting on his jacket, straightening the fabric around the cuffs. Marvin was a snappy dresser: no khaki Dockers and mild blue shirts for him. Everything he owned looked expensive, shone slightly, and fit him perfectly. His shirts were bold colors: red, deep purple, dark green.

Meri looked up at him. "*Pig*," she repeated, as though she were outraged.

It made him laugh and imitate an "oink." Then he strolled away, fixing his collar. He paused at the door. "It's like I always say, Meri-Meri. You can call me any time."

He was smiling as he pushed through the door. It was a joke. They made it all the time. She was joking, he was joking, there was nothing to it,

and she would never, ever, actually feel his skin against hers because she was *married*.

And that might not matter to Marvin, but it mattered to her.

Her stomach felt like it was filled with flapping fish as she stood up and retrieved her soup.

She took Marvin's answer to mean that he *had* hooked up with Lena. And what about this, "Oh, he knows?" What did that mean? The way Marvin said it, it sounded like he *knew-knew*.

A flash of arousal – the dirtiest, most wrong kind – came over her. She indulged in a moment of fantasy, and then stabbed at a piece of fish. None of this was any of her business, and she shouldn't even be thinking about it.

She ate two bites of salmon, staring at the forest, and midway through the second bite, a plan occurred to her.

The perfection and plausible deniability of it calmed her. It was a devious, self-indulgent plan, the only possible good outcome of which was to satisfy her unhealthy curiosity. But she knew, as she polished off her fish and tapped the Tupperware into place, that she was going to do it anyway.

Besides. It was so late in the season, Lena probably wouldn't make it anyway.

CHAPTER 3

“So?” Meri said, bustling into the kitchen with the empty punch bowl. “It turned out to be a pretty good party *after all*.”

Joel poured himself a glass of whiskey and leaned against the counter. “Yeah,” he said. “It’s great. I’m already looking forward to cleaning it up.”

For whatever reason – and he really couldn’t fathom what it was – Meri had decided that they would have a big New Year’s party that year. He felt that over the years, they had reached a balance between Meri’s love of parties, and his own love of whatever the opposite of parties was.

“I don’t know,” she had explained breathlessly, looking up at him from a big pile of invitations that she had already begun to fill out, without even running the idea past him. “I just thought... if we’re having a *few* people, might as well have a *lot* of people. And, whatever... probably everyone has plans already. But since we’re in such a good place for it, and everyone can get a cab, and your company pays for cabs anyway, I thought... why not? I’m going to get a disco ball.”

Well, there hadn’t been much Joel could say to that, and the party was already underway. They had been planning on having a handful of friends over anyway.

“Fine,” he had agreed. “But let’s make it BYOB.”

Meri had rolled her eyes.

Back in the kitchen, which was now littered with half-empty glasses and plates, Meri slapped him playfully. “Admit it. It’s good.”

It was, in spite of all of his misgivings, a really good party. He had envisioned their friends – Meri’s gluten-free, vegan-hipster, extreme sports friends who didn’t drink but smoked tons of pot, would clash spectacularly with his own friends, who were... well, not vegan hipsters who went skydiving, and would be the first to point out a certain level of hypocrisy there. But then, when Meri had invited people from his work and people from her work, he had felt certain that the whole party would implode, or explode, within a few hours.

Which actually would have been great, because then he would have gotten his wish: everyone going home early, Meri drinking a bottle of wine, and the first sex of the year more or less a few minutes into the year.

Instead, everyone had arrived, found a cross-cultural conversation partner, and gotten along great so far. Someone had selected some dreamy folk music from the seventies that somehow offended no one, and more people had arrived than had been invited – people were actually calling the friends they had planned to meet up with somewhere else later, to invite them here instead.

The kitchen was busy. People were circulating through the swing door like it was a Gordon Ramsey restaurant.

Joel glared out the window to the enclosed, unheated porch, where someone had taken the lid off the hot tub and not put it back on, almost an hour ago when everyone had decided to hop in. For some reason the plan had been abandoned, but Joel was still paying to keep uninsulated water hot.

“I’m going to go put the lid on that,” he told Meri, who was refilling the punch bowl.

Meri didn’t hear him, or seem to, because she started a conversation with someone else and picked up the punch bowl to carry it back to the living room.

“Hey,” Joel heard a male voice say when he entered the porch area. He was startled, giving a little jump, turning toward the sound as he reached for the hot tub lid.

Two heads, tucked away in a corner of the hot tub, floated just above the water. Lena’s orange hair was damp at the very edges, and she had her arms draped over a man in the water, which made it possible for Joel to recognize her husband, Chance.

“Oh,” Joel said, tipping the hot tub lid slightly, half of his mind still on his original task. The other half of his mind was working out how to look through the frothing bubbles discreetly and see what Lena was wearing in his hot tub.

Because from the bareness of her shoulders, and the clothing draped over a chair at the far corner of the room, it seemed to be nothing at all.

Lena Stiller, naked in his hot tub.

Lena gave him a grin and licked her husband’s ear lobe.

“I hope you aren’t packin’ that in, man. We just got out here,” Chance said, barely finishing his sentence before giving Lena’s wandering tongue a lick of his own.

“I thought... no one was out here,” Joel said, letting go of the cover. “But yeah, of course, if you are, then... have fun.”

Lena let out a low laugh, and her hand moved under the foam in such a way that there was almost no chance it wasn't on Chance's cock.

Joel would have loved to stay, but he decided to leave. “Okay. Have fun, you two.”

He walked as slowly as he could back through the kitchen and into the living and dining area, where he looked for Meri.

She was seated on the edge of an armchair, legs draped akimbo like a fashion model, a tiara on her head, a smear of glittery makeup on her cheek. Meri's comparable youth at moments like these made Joel feel proud and inadequate all at once. She glowed like an angel, and she had taken the unusual step of dressing very sexily for this party in a red silk slip of dress that had begun the party as part of an ensemble with a jacket but since been reduced to nothing more than what looked like a nightgown. Very high heels, also red, new and tantalizing, snaked over her feet and ankles. She looked like a high-end ad for booze or jewelry.

He approached her as she turned toward him, her mouth wide in a smile. “Jack just bet Archer twenty bucks that he can win a break dance contest,” she told him with mirth. “And they're actually going to *do* it.”

When Meri found things funny – or, interestingly, foul – she opened her mouth in a large, amazed smile, and made no sound for a few seconds. She did this, and then brought a drink to her lips.

She was obviously getting loaded.

“Lena and Chance are in the hot tub,” Joel said, sitting down next to her. The softness of her skin and the silkiness of her dress were almost too much for him to resist. Maybe he'd still get lucky tonight, if he could get Meri to stop drinking so much that she passed out before everyone went home. He took the drink from her hands, realizing he didn't know where his own whiskey had gone. He took a sip. “What is this?” he asked.

“Are they ne-ked?” Meri asked, merriment in her eyes.

Merriment? Or something else?

Joel put the drink back in her hand. “I don't know,” he said in mock bewilderment. “But at least the hot tub's getting used.”

Meri crinkled her nose, and looked around the room. She didn't seem to find what she was looking for, and her face clouded for a moment.

The moment was brief. “You gonna go hop in?” she asked. “We should have told people to bring their suits. Now it’s going to be...”

She waved a hand to substitute for whatever word she had meant to say, and the music turned off abruptly as someone connected the stereo to their own phone and began to blast some eighties beat boxing music.

Or at least, that’s what Joel figured it was, because it wasn’t like he was so old that he would know.

Meri put a hand on his shoulder. “Aw,” she joked. “This take you back to your high school days?”

It was not a typical Meri joke, and Joel was annoyed by it, but he kept his cool. It barely mattered: the subsequent spectacle of Jack, from Accounting, doing his best to breakdance.

He wasn’t altogether bad, and the crowd loved it. Someone moved a glass table out of the way just in time to make sure it didn’t get kicked, and Meri covered her mouth and squinted her eyes closed just before it happened.

Joel decided to get up and find his drink, perhaps to take a stroll down the hallway and into the study, where the porch could be seen through the window. Just out of curiosity.

Meri stiffened next to him.

It was a small change in her: her muscles tensed, and she tucked a hand under her thigh quickly, looking down at her dress and then up at the room again. She was smiling and her body deliberately relaxed just seconds later, but there was a studiousness to her expression and her body that put Joel on alert.

He scanned the room, and that’s when he put it all together.

Marvin.

There was no mistaking Marvin: he was a huge, well-dressed black guy who wore rich colors and moved with the calm certainty of a man who could kick anyone’s ass. He had come through the door and almost instantly been accosted by several women from Meri’s office, whose hands he kissed in a mixture of real smoothness and jokiness. Like a black George Clooney.

And there was very little chance that Meri hadn’t noticed him come in: she’d noticed everyone come in. It was hard not to: when the door opened, a blast of frigid air cooled the whole place until someone screamed to shut the door.

Marvin turned his charming gaze on the room, glanced momentarily, without changing his expression at the break dancing in the middle of the room, and then, straight at Meri and Joel. Or Meri. Or Joel. It was hard to tell, at this distance, but his gaze was unwavering and intense.

Joel looked away, then felt extra irritated for being intimidated by the man looking at him.

He took Meri's punch glass from her hand and asked her if she wanted some more.

"Huh? Yeah. Oh yeah, sure, um, yeah, I'll actually take a different one, like, something not so sweet. This is giving me sticky throat." She babbled, and then stopped after making this easy mark for innuendo comment. "I, uh, just wine maybe, if there's any dry..."

She then proceeded to look at the break dancers for less than a nanosecond, burst into her very entertained smile, and pretend, quite admiringly, to be absorbed in what they were doing.

Except Joel had seen it: a glance at Marvin, brief as a hummingbird's flap. He followed her eyes and looked away just as quickly, but there was no mistake: Marvin had his hands in his pockets and was still looking calmly in their direction.

Not their general direction. Their direction exactly.

"I think Marvin's here," Joel said flatly to Meri, his stomach turning wildly for a reason – maybe several – he couldn't quite put his finger on.

"He is? Huh? What?" Meri said, talking much too quickly to be doing anything but pretending. Her eyes found Marvin immediately, and she looked away too quickly to have actually seen him. She returned her gaze to Joel and stared at him, too intently to be natural, as she said: "Oh, so he is. I better go... say hello."

Meri then brought her fingers to her teeth and made a face that could best be described as glee, trying hard – and failing – to masquerade it as sudden concern.

"Oh, shit," she said.

Joel was already getting a sense of what was going on, even if he would have had a hard time articulating it, and even if he couldn't quite believe it. He gave his head a little shake and smiled helpfully. "What?" he asked. He felt like he was reading lines from a poorly written script.

Meri chewed on a finger and then put a hand on his leg. Joel noticed that as she did this, she extended her own right leg in a feline stretch,

pulling her left up a little. The motion caused her silky dress to slide down her thigh.

It wasn't obscene, and it probably went unnoticed by everyone but Joel.

But it was definitely deliberate, and definitely because of Marvin.

Joel's abdomen tightened, and in his pants, his cock throbbed.

"It's just... *Lena's* here," Meri said, in a whispery squeak. "With her husband." And then, as if Joel needed an explanation, she confided, looking at the wall as though it were a secret she couldn't bear to divulge: "Lena's the one he hooked up with, from Fevr." She paused for a moment, her features expressed concern, but her eyes gleamed with mischief.

"Shit," she repeated, for effect.

She turned her wide eyes on Joel. "I guess... I'll go and talk to him, say hello," she said. "And then... what should we do? Oh man. I didn't *even* think this through."

It was so completely, thoroughly, and titillatingly obvious that Meri was full of shit at that moment that Joel almost laughed out loud. She had so *clearly* thought this through, and hoped for a moment like this one, that she could barely restrain herself from giving herself a pat on the back.

Joel played dumb, wondering as he did whether Meri knew *he* was acting deliberately, or if she even cared. "Think what through?" he pondered aloud.

Meri turned to him excitedly. She was still making an effort at looking concerned, but less of one, and so she looked, instead, remorseless. "Remember how I told you Lena has a Fevr account? And you wanted to know if they hooked up? Well..." she returned her gaze to Marvin, who had taken a drink from a blond and begun talking to her. As if he could hear their every word and thought, Marvin gave a quick glance back in Meri's direction. This caused her to turn suddenly and noticeably to Joel. "They *did*," she whispered loudly.

Joel took her glass and stood up.

"What are you doing?" Meri asked.

He didn't know. He knew he *wasn't* headed to the hot tub to tell Lena that her hookup from Fevr was here. He knew he didn't want a fight in his house, but he did want to see what Meri had hoped to accomplish here.

So, he went to the kitchen to make himself another drink.

*

When she first saw Marvin there, standing in her living room, looking hot as always in a crimson shirt with no tie, the top button of the shirt undone and revealing his perfectly smooth chocolate skin beneath it, Meri had a jolt of erotic adrenaline (no other real expression for it). He met her eyes and she was pretty sure she melted right through the middle of her body and spilled into her panties.

Joel was sitting right next to her, and she had reasons to be grateful for that, as well as reasons to not. Guilt draped itself around her because she was undeniably attracted to Marvin, but she could reassure herself that nothing would ever come of it, because her husband was right here.

Then, when Joel left for the kitchen, plans undisclosed, the full realization of what she had wrought came over her.

She jumped to her feet and walked toward Marvin, who was watching the break dancing and not her. He *had* been watching her before: a few quick glances had determined that for a fact. As wrong as it was, she was a little annoyed that he had since looked away.

But back to the problem at hand.

“Hey,” she said, giving him a light punch on the shoulder. “I didn’t think you’d make it.”

Marvin grinned at the bad dancing, and then, as though it were an afterthought, turned to Meri. “Yeah well,” he said indifferently. “My plans fell through.”

“Bad date?” Meri asked. She was glad Marvin’s eyes had traveled up and down her body.

“Nice dress,” he told her, ignoring her question. “Silk?”

Meri looked down at herself. She hid her pleasure the best she could and was toying with the idea of saying something like, “Oh this old thing?” - but hopefully less clichéd. Marvin didn’t give her a chance. “Not every lady can wear silk, you know? But you look good.”

Marvin had a way of saying “good” that wreaked havoc with her blood pressure, which dropped and then rose. She put a hand on the back of her neck to stop a creep of tingling crimson skin from spreading to her face.

But back to the problem at hand.

“Hey, Marvin... I just want to tell you that, uh... Lena is here. With her husband. I’m sorry, I probably should have -”

“Oh yeah?” Marvin said, looking through the crowd and around the room. “Where they at?” he asked, dropping, Meri suspected very naturally, into a black vernacular he had never used around her before.

Meri’s eyes went wide. It was not a reaction she had anticipated.

Disappointment crept into her chest, but in some other corner of her mind, a spark of excitement ignited. She could feel her face getting out of control. Meri had big emotions, and big features that broadcast them, and when she was emotionally confused, she looked it.

She was also very aware of this fact, which only exaggerated the problem. “I think – I don’t... so you’re like... it’s not going to be a problem, is it? I think they may be outside,” she babbled.

Marvin looked down at her hands. “Where’s your drink?” he asked her. Looking up, he smiled his usual, maddeningly charming smile. “Where *the* drinks?” he asked, in black English again.

Meri jerked her head toward the kitchen. “Kitchen,” she said hoarsely, trying to think of something else to say.

“I’ll get you one.”

She moved her hand toward the kitchen and pointed, still trying to think of something clever to say. Instead, she said, “The kitchen’s there. But, oh – be careful, I think they’re... you know what? I’ll go with you. This way.”

As she stepped to the right to get ahead of Marvin and lead him to the kitchen, Archer, who had taken up the breakdancing gambit only to reveal that he had been bluffing, and was an awful dancer, spun into the back of her leg and her knees gave out, causing her to fall directly into Marvin’s arms.

Her face smashed toward his collar and neck, because she was in very high heels, and she caught a whiff of his masculine smell before his hands were on her elbows and steadying her with an unnerving ease and strength. She leaned all her weight on her elbows, and her feet struggled to find purchase, but Marvin held her easily and didn’t let go until she was steady. “Watch it man,” Marvin said to Archer, who continued to spin.

“You okay?” he asked Meri.

She knew it was wrong, but her insides felt like they had been melted down. She smiled for him, lingering close for a moment too long, and knew she would probably replay this entire moment in lurid detail for herself later.

So wrong.

She grimaced.

“Oh no,” she said, reaching for Marvin’s collar. “I got lipstick on your collar.”

Marvin looked at her, pressed his lips together, gave a funny kind of nod and grinned. It was the look of a man who didn’t make the joke that occurred to him.

“I’m gonna go get that drink,” he repeated. “You good here?”

The scent of Marvin’s skin, and the musky, clean soap he used, had lodged in Meri’s consciousness so deep that she forgot that she’d intended to go with him, in order to act as a buffer for his first contact with Lena. Or as a witness, which was a better description of what she really wanted to do. Meri teetered on her heels and nodded, and Marvin was through the kitchen door before she managed to collect her thoughts.

Archer popped up next to her, sweating. He brushed a loose lock of his unkempt hair from his face. “Sorry about that,” he breathed.

Meri shrugged and walked carefully to a chair to collapse in it. She felt empty-handed, adrift at her own party. What she really wanted to be doing was observing the interactions between Marvin, Lena, and Chance – but she didn’t want to be obvious about it.

God, what was wrong with her?

She twisted her foot nervously for a few moments, and then got up to insert herself into a conversation with Jen and Brian from her work, two people she rarely talked to. She turned her back deliberately on the dancing, and Marvin, smiling vacantly at whatever it was they were talking about, but her attention was elsewhere. Luckily they didn’t notice.

When she excused herself to go to the kitchen, Marvin was gone.

*

The kitchen was littered with dirty glasses and empty bottles, and Joel was the only inhabitant when she walked in. He was standing with his back to her, mixing something in the ice shaker. Meri froze, scanning the kitchen for Marvin, and a guest crashed into her coming from the living room.

Joel turned around at the noise, and looked Meri up and down as she teetered on her heels and apologized to the guest. It was a guy she didn’t

know, somebody's date. Joel raised his eyebrows and turned back to two martini glasses. "I'm making you a cosmopolitan," he told her.

Meri practically ran to him, her heels tack-tacking on the floor. She gripped his arm. "Where did Marvin go?" she whispered hoarsely.

Joel looked up at her with an innocent blink that she knew was almost sarcastic. "I think he went out to the porch," he told Meri, pointing in the general direction of the hot tub.

Meri's head jerked toward the porch. "Shit," she said.

Turning back to Joel, she asked: "What happened?"

"When?"

She smacked him playfully, but with enough force to make a loud noise through his heavy shirt. "When he went out there?"

"He just went."

Meri, who was already very fair, turned pale. Her head jerked to the left and then back at Joel. "And?"

Joel shrugged. He had a smile on his lips that Meri didn't like. Or maybe she found confusing. He took a sip of his martini. "He said, 'hey, man.'"

Meri blinked at him. "'Hey man?'" She stared at her husband. "Who? Chance? Or Marvin?"

Joel turned toward her, martini glass in each hand. He brought the rim of his own glass to his lips and spoke over the clear liquid as he handed Meri her pink drink. "Why?"

Meri leaned toward the counter and set her drink down. Looking down at the tabletop she whispered in her husband's direction. "It matters who said it, dummy. And what -"

She was cut off by, and jumped a little at, the sound of Lena's laughter, followed by a low round of chuckles from more than one male voice.

"Is someone else out there?" Meri demanded of Joel, in her super-not-secretive whisper.

Joel shrugged. "Why?"

Making a noise with her nose that Joel likened to the sound of a teeny, tiny freight train, and which expressed exasperation, Meri spun on her heels and strode to the porch door, which she threw open and then stepped timidly through.

"Oh, hi," she said, almost as soon as she entered, because it seemed like something needed to be said.

Lena was naked – or at least topless - in the hot tub. That was one thing. Her enormous breasts were afloat, the pink-brown hue of her aureole, but not her nipples, peeking out from the surface. There was no indication that beneath the surface of the water there was any clothing covering her skin, which seemed to be everywhere. Foam swirled tantalizingly over her legs, offering just a glimpse of what was beneath the water, but never enough to ascertain for certain if she was totally naked. She made no effort to hide this – not from Meri, or Marvin.

Meri's eyes were drawn to Lena's breasts, and then she made a quick sweep of the men in the room. Chance was slightly behind Lena, indicating she was floating or sitting on his lap. Marvin was standing, relaxed, with a beer in his hand, having just taken a drink of it. He looked like a man who had just passed a neighbor's house and begun a chat about the weather.

No one appeared uncomfortable, except for Meri.

She took the scene in quickly, but caught important details in those few moments: the trajectory of Lena's arm, twisted behind her so that it was obvious to anyone but an idiot that her hand was on her husband's cock. Chance's unforced smile. The tail end of something said by Lena in a low voice.

Then, they all looked at Meri, who looked from each face to the next. Marvin was grinning.

"Do you guys... know each other?" Meri said, to fill up the silence.

Lena gave a throaty laugh and looked impishly at her husband, whose eyes became fixated on her and retreated inside his mind. It was as sure a sign as possible that Lena's hand was rubbing his cock beneath the water.

"We've met," Marvin said.

"All of you?" Meri said, in disbelief. The indiscretion of what she had just said made her heart stop in her chest.

"Oh, yeah," Lena purred. She looked back at Meri. "Marvin's a friend of ours," she told Meri. "Don't tell me he's a friend of *yours*."

Meri could pick up on the existence of some kind of innuendo, but she couldn't piece together what it might have meant. "Uh..." she said, to Lena's expectant expression. "Marvin's a... coworker."

Lena's face broke into an enormous smile and she let out a peal of laughter. "No shit," she said.

Chance was paying no attention to this conversation. He was looking at Lena's neck, absorbed in her every movement.

“You coming in?” Lena asked. She was looking at Meri when she said this, but switched to Marvin mid-question, so it was impossible to know who she was asking.

“Uh,” Meri said. “Maybe... later.”

“In a bit,” Marvin said smoothly, at the same time.

Lena and Marvin exchanged a look that would have turned anything between them into plasma, while Chance shifted under the water, eyes on Lena.

Meri was mortified: the situation was so uncomfortable that she wanted to flee. But at the same time, it was turning her on, and she couldn’t easily tear her eyes away from it.

The awkward, sexually-charged silence went on long enough that Meri decided to turn and leave. She stumbled through the door, clumsily enough that Joel turned to give her an amused look.

Her mouth fell open and her face was frozen in an exaggerated expression of horror as she walked briskly toward the kitchen door leading to the hallway.

Joel knew he was expected to follow her, so he took a sip of his martini and did so.

Meri walked like a woman on a mission through the party, ignoring everyone, straight to a hallway that led to the guest bedroom and staircase. Ensconced in the hallway, near the door to the guest room, which was tucked behind the stairway and seductively close to the window that let out on the porch, she spun around.

Her face was still loudly expressing shock.

“What?” Joel asked.

Meri shook her head, and raised a finger to point it vaguely behind her, in the direction of the hot tub. “So I went out there,” she began, her voice a full octave higher than usual, “because, you know, *Marvin*. And I was thinking it was going to be a shit-show -”

“Hmm,” Joel interrupted. He brought his martini to his lips. “I sort of thought you were *hoping* for a shit-show,” he commented after taking a sip.

Meri glared at him, closed her mouth, mounted fury behind her eyes, and then continued as if Joel had never spoken. “And do you know what? I go out there, and, and...and...”

Joel raised his eyebrows.

“They all *know* each other,” Meri whispered loudly.

“Okay,” Joel said.

Meri’s eyebrows shot to the sky. “I mean, like, Chance knows Marvin and Marvin knows Chance.”

Joel cocked his head.

A tremor traveled through Meri, and she clenched her fists. “So, it’s almost like...” she looked at the ceiling as if what she intended to say were on a cue card there.

“They know each other,” Joel finished for her.

Meri’s eyes snapped back to his face. He felt certain he was about to get an earful, and to be fair, he was messing with her just a little.

Instead, she brought her hand to her mouth and covered it. “I think Lena was giving Chance a handjob,” she blurted in her whisper-yell.

“When?” Joel asked, his interest in the conversation changing course dramatically.

“Then!” Meri practically shouted, then lowered her voice. “Out there. When I was out there. And Marvin was out there.”

Joel blinked.

“It’s like... they weren’t even... trying to *hide* it.”

Joel wasn’t sure what to do. He gave a glance back at the party, and Meri kept talking.

“I mean, it’s... Marvin told me that Chance knew she was on Fevr, but he didn’t say...”

“Maybe they have an open relationship,” Joel suggested.

“People don’t actually do that,” Meri snapped. Then she raised her eyebrows and looked behind her, as if she could see through the door and out the window. “Do they?” she asked rhetorically.

She looked back at Joel, who was smiling thoughtfully. She smacked him with the back of her hand, a typical gesture of Meri’s. “Stop it,” she said. “There’s no way...”

She trailed off, and looked at Joel like she wanted him to finish the sentence.

“So, what are you saying?” she asked in a whisper. “That Lena and Chance just like, are swingers or something?”

“Maybe,” Joel said. “Maybe something else.”

“What else is there?” Meri screeched.

Joel held up a finger to his lips.

“You don’t think they’re like... doing it? In the hot tub? Right now?”

Joel smiled. "We could check."

They could check. The window to the porch was behind Meri, blinds drawn: all they had to do was open the door, sneak inside quietly, and peek.

Meri stared at Joel, and he stared right back. Unfolding before his eyes was the stuff of his fantasies, and he was half-convinced this was a dream. He didn't want to disturb anything in case it was reality, and he didn't want to think too much about it being a dream and wake up.

"Whoa," a voice said behind them, followed by a thump as a guy, the significant other of one of Joel's coworkers, lightly collided with the wall. "Looking for the bathroom," he told them.

Meri pointed, sending him back down the hallway.

Then she looked behind her, again as if she could see through the door. "They wouldn't," she whispered.

Joel shrugged. He wanted to say, "Let's go see," but didn't want to make any waves in this delicate fabric of his fantasy-come-partially-true.

"I don't want this party turning into an... orgy," Meri exclaimed. Her hand had dropped to the handle of the door. "What do we do, if, you know...?"

Joel stepped forward, close to Meri, her breasts brushing against his chest, and pushed the handle slowly down. "Let's just see what's going on," he suggested.

Meri let the door swing open, as if she were letting Joel into the room but not going herself. Joel walked into the channel of light made by the open door, straight to the window. The door closed behind him, but he heard Meri breathing, so he knew she was there.

It was pitch-black, except for the outlines of light around the edges of the blinds, and a blue light from the desktop computer.

Meri was still by the door.

He set his martini glass where he thought the desk was, and it fell to the carpet on the floor with a thump, which he ignored. Using one finger, he lifted the wood slat of the blinds less than a centimeter, and peered into the porch area through the small space.

Behind him, Meri breathed loudly. He heard her pad slowly toward him on the carpet. "What are they doing?" she whispered.

Joel said nothing, so she edged up behind him. He was surprised when she slipped her arms around his waist. Her hot breath was against his spine, just between his shoulder blades. "What? What are they doing?"

He stepped back, lowering the blind carefully, and pulled her in front of him, positioning her facing the blinds. He put one hand on her right shoulder, and used his free hand to raise the slat of a blind at her eye level. Slowly.

He heard Meri's breath leave her, a single huff. He could smell her hair and the unique scent of her neck. His cock was hard, pulsing against her lower back.

Meri stared through the slats, unable to speak – even to say, “Oh my God,” like she would about just about anything.

The situation on the porch had changed considerably. Marvin was standing next to the hot tub, still clothed, Lena's foot in his hands. His dark fingers curled around the shape of her foot, massaging it lewdly, his eyes locked with Lena's. Lena was lying against her husband's chest, her presence only alluded to by the strands of orange-red hair that clung to Chance's shoulders.

And her body, skimming the surface of the water, just beneath Chance's massaging hands.

Meri watched the scene, transfixed. She could feel Joel's cock thickening behind her, against her, and the soles of her own feet experienced a phantom pleasure, as if Marvin were rubbing his thumb along the center of her foot from heel to toe, as he was with Lena's now.

Her lips parted.

Marvin was talking, Chance was rolling Lena's nipples between his fingers. Marvin paused, looking at Lena, and then began to lower his head.

When he sucked Lena's toe into his mouth, it was too much for Meri. She gasped, jumping back, pushing Joel with her and causing him to drop the blind with little finesse.

Meri's hair was in his mouth, and clung to his lips as she pushed herself out of his embrace and whipped around to face him. “He just... did you see that?”

Joel's mouth was very close to Meri's, so he pushed her head closer to his and rubbed his lips over hers lightly. He felt a shudder through her body. “See what?” he asked. “I couldn't see -”

“It's... it's...” Meri began. “He put her... *toe!* In his *mouth.*”

Meri, of course, would have had no way of knowing that Joel would have the immediate and visceral reaction to this news that he did. His cock

throbbed painfully, and he reached for her lower back to pull her closer to him.

An old girlfriend had given him a “toe job” once, and while nothing in the world could truly compare to the feel of a woman's mouth around his cock, a woman's mouth around his toe had been the closest anything had ever gotten.

Also, he had a big thing about feet.

He put his hands in Meri's hair, and then kissed her. She melted against him, and they parted, staring into the darkness just inches from each other, their breath mingling, raking over each other's lips.

Joel felt Meri's lips moving, less than an inch away from his, even though they didn't touch him. “Do you think they're going to... have sex? In our hot tub?”

Joel ran his fingers through her hair. He was on such a high that he was worried he'd do something stupid. He knew Meri wanted an answer, but he had other things on his mind, and he was mostly interested in getting as much as he could from this scenario before Meri lost it and marched out to the porch to kick everyone out of her hot tub.

He moved in to kiss her.

“I should go stop them,” she whispered.

“Nope,” Joel growled, but his own words were cut off by his mouth meeting Meri's. He took her in both hands by the shoulders and pushed her onto the pull-out sofa against the side wall in the cramped room.

His body on top of hers, he kissed her until he felt her mouth rising up to meet his, resistance leaking out of her, her preoccupations fading. His fingers traveled along her inner thigh, under her dress, and paused when he encountered her damp thighs, and even wetter lace thong.

He sat up, grinning, because he knew Meri couldn't see him very well in the dark.

“What are you...?” Meri asked, as he lifted her left leg up into the air, running his hands from her lower thigh to her calf, following with his tongue along the back of her leg.

He stopped at the back of her knee, sucking her taut skin between his lips and then making a slow and feathery swirl that gave her a jolt and cut off her voice.

He surprised her, he was sure, by bending her knee and lifting her foot to his shoulder. The heel of her sexy shoes stabbed painfully into his chest

and collar bone, which he enjoyed immensely. Propping her foot there, he untied the straps of her shoe and pulled on the ribbon binding her foot sensually and slowly.

“Joel -”

“Sssshhhh,” he murmured, slipping her foot from the shoe and letting it drop on the floor. “I’m going to give you a toe job.”

He didn’t give Meri time to protest or pull her foot away. Half of the word “What?” left her lips, but it was snuffed out immediately by the feel of his mouth on her big toe.

“Oh my -” Meri gasped.

Her leg stiffened, and she squirmed in his hands, but he held her calf in a vice-like grip no matter how she moved. She lifted her upper body toward him, then collapsed back as he made a swirl around her toe with his tongue.

Whatever Meri was trying to say, it began as a pant and finished as a moan. Her body writhed in the darkness, only the movement of her muscles giving Joel any indication what she was doing.

He closed his eyes, and pictured Marvin in his hot tub, sucking on a toe – but not Lena’s, Meri’s. And when Meri mewled, he squeezed his eyes to imagine that inside her mind, she was also working on a picture of Marvin sucking on her toe as well.

“Holy shit,” Meri moaned, almost complaining. Her foot was stiff, she was trying to pull away. “That feels so good,” she panted. “I can’t, I can’t... you have to stop.”

Joel let her toe leave his mouth, while he massaged the bottom of her foot with his thumb, much like he had seen Marvin do.

Then he took her toe into his mouth again.

Meri whimpered in excessive pleasure and pulled on her foot. He let her escape, but mostly so that he could take up his tasting of her at her knee. She writhed on the couch, half-finishes sentences like, “Joel, we shouldn’t...” and “Oh my God, that feels so good but...”

He pushed her leg open and slipped his fingers beneath her soaked thong. The toe job had made her pussy hotter and wetter than he had felt in a long time. With his other hand he tried to free himself from his jeans.

He jerked her thong to the side and fell on top of her with only his cock out, shoved over his boxers, dangerously close to the metal teeth of his zipper, and sank into his wife’s flesh like they were teenagers hiding in a janitor closet.

Meri came almost immediately – a rarity, and something that pushed Joel over the edge. Her pussy squeezed around his cock, piping hot and sloppy wet, sucking at him with its spasms so that he could only resist coming for a few more hard thrusts.

As he fucked his cum into his wife, he made his orgasm soar to new heights by thinking to himself that Meri might just be lying there, shuddering, thinking about Marvin's mouth on her toes. Or his cock in her mouth.

Or his cum filling her pussy, instead of Joel's.

*

Meri was dizzy when she left the office. Her panties had been twisted into a useless mess, and she was sure her hair and makeup told the full story of what she had been doing with Joel in the office. She opened the door a crack and scurried out into the hallway, toward the living room, passing someone who sent shame crawling up her spine with a knowing look, and shot up the stairs to their bedroom.

She shut the door and leaned against it. Her legs felt wobbly, and her heart was pounding.

"Okay," she told herself, and crossed the room to her dresser, jerking open the drawer where she kept her panties.

Toe jobs, she thought, making herself smile, were surprisingly hot.

Surprisingly, surprisingly hot.

She wondered if that was anything like what men felt when women sucked their cocks, and then shook her head as she dug through the drawer, because of course it was. Probably even more intense.

She looked up at the small mirror over her dresser when she found a pair of panties. She didn't look too bad: her hair was falling out of her messy bun, but it looked sort of hot. She wiped the smeared lipstick from just below her lower lip.

A stab of guilt sliced through her as she thought of the lipstick stain she'd left on Marvin's collar.

Don't be stupid, she told herself. It wasn't like she had left it there because she had actually *done* anything with Marvin.

Anything like the things she had thought about doing with Marvin while her own husband sucked on her toe.

She bent over, pulling her ruined, twisted underwear away with a jerk and tossed them toward the clothes hamper, which she missed. She stepped into the new pair and pulled them up.

She had discarded her complicated shoes in the office. It had seemed too hard to put them back on, and she was drunk, and her head was still spinning from the wild orgasm Joel had just given her.

She flung open her closet door, trying to banish the simmering thoughts of Marvin from her head as she sought a pair of pumps that would look good with her dress and not call attention to the change of footwear.

She gave herself a final glance in the mirror, before hurrying to the bathroom to pee and hopefully stop the trickle of hot cum that was snaking down her thighs. Downstairs, the music pounded. She caught her breath, and smoothed her hair, and then, feeling like she was wearing some sort of slut sign, walked calmly down the stairs.

CHAPTER 4

The party was disintegrating when Meri headed out to the living room, and Meri couldn't help but feel like she had something to do with it. A lot of her co-workers or their spouses— and unlikely suspects, to boot — had become excessively drunk, and their better halves seemed annoyed. Snippets of conversations she overheard mostly consisted of someone telling someone else it was time to go.

The dancing had stopped, and no one had bothered to change the music back to the earlier good-vibe tunes.

“Meri,” Archer said, approaching her out of nowhere. He was good and drunk. “I hate to do this when it’s so close to twelve, but I think we have to go home.”

He was looking at her strangely, she was sure of it. Sure that he knew what she had been doing — not just that she had been having sex with her husband in the bedroom office, but also sure that he could read her mind: that he knew she had gone into the office to satisfy a desire to see Marvin, Lena, and Chance together, that he knew the thoughts she had entertained while she had sex with Joel. She could feel heat creeping across her face, spreading over her cheeks.

“Uh,” she said, not really able to concentrate on what she was saying, feeling guilty for what had transpired but not really sure why, wondering if Marvin, Lena, and Chance were up to anything still in the hot tub, vaguely worried that they might have heard her and Joel through the window. “Yeah, okay. Well, if you have to go...”

She was distracted, and she felt like Archer knew it. A few other guests were leaving, and it was almost impossible for her not to feel like they all knew about the impropriety that had taken place in the hot tub, in the office, and in her own mind. She gave people hugs, goodbyes, distracted advice about driving safely or taking a cab. But inside, she was burning with a single question that held all of her attention: were those three still here? And what were they doing, if they were?

Joel was nowhere to be found in the living room, and she was almost *afraid* to go into the kitchen, so close to the door to the hot tub. She was equally worried that the party would empty out, and she would be left in her living room with a pair of people — right now it was looking like mostly

Joel's coworkers, definitely people she didn't know well – all while *something* brewed in the kitchen and enclosed porch. What would she do? Just sit here and wait for them to come out?

She sat on the armrest of a chair, disoriented, and picked up a half-empty bottle of beer, just to have something in her hands. She was almost ready to go to the kitchen and face the music, when the door swung open and Lena, Chance, and Marvin – clothed, she noted with relief – stumbled out into the living room, arms linked, clothing loose and hastily put on, skin still glistening here and there from a failure to towel off completely.

Meri felt frozen to the chair, her hand in midair. Her heart rate was accelerating, and her chest felt a little tight. She hadn't felt like that since... what? It was a sensation from another time, maybe high school, a combination between standing up in front of an audience to give a presentation, and passing some cute boy she had a crush on in the hallway.

She wrinkled her nose. She was *not* experiencing that sensation, she told herself. She was embarrassed, that was all: and more embarrassed by her and Joel's co-workers' lewd behavior than anything else. If *anyone* should be having heart palpitations right now, it was them.

They had so obviously had sex – a threesome – in her hot tub.

She stood up, having worked herself into a state of semi-indignation.

But Lena caught her eye, and smiled – a sexual smile, a smile that cut right through Meri's manufactured indignation and seemed to see inside of her. It was the kind of smile that was at once inviting and admonishing. Inviting, luring Meri to be part of Lena's sensuality, her obvious lack of shame, and her freedom. Admonishing, because it broadcasted, very directly, that Lena seemed to know Meri's inner thoughts.

Cool down, the smile seemed to say.

You know you're just jealous.

"Meri," Lena purred, releasing herself from their entangled limbs and walking toward her. "We're leaving now." She finished this sentence with a kind of haughty laugh, as if to say: *of course we're leaving, and we're leaving together*. "But thanks for the really great party. I had no *idea* you worked with Marvin."

Another laugh left Lena's mouth, throaty and sexual, and as Meri stared at her in what she would hope later was not prudish-looking shock, Lena *winked*.

Then she turned, her body like liquid, her dress clinging to the damp skin against the back of her thigh, making the material ride high and reveal almost all of her sculpted, thick legs. She looked a little bit like a sexy female animation in a game like *Grand Theft Auto*, which was the sort of thought that Meri didn't even know where it came from.

Marvin sucked on his lower lip as Lena turned back toward her two men, put her arms on each of their shoulders, and said something in a low voice.

Marvin leaned close to Lena's ear, and said something that made her almost growl.

But Chance was looking right at Meri. It would be a lie to say she had never paid any attention to Chance: he was striking enough that every woman at least *remembered* meeting him. He was tall, broad-shouldered, and had a square jaw that exuded masculinity. Now he was looking at her with brown eyes, slightly narrowed, and his generous mouth was set in a straight line that hinted, around the corners, at a grin.

Meri held his gaze, though she wanted to look away, because the look was hungry, devouring, and somehow inappropriate. Seconds passed, stretched out for what seemed like an eternity. And Meri felt like a cold, thrilling sword of ice was being slowly pushed from her lips to the center of her body, and then down, between her legs, where it melted, and made her quiver.

"Okay," she said stupidly, breaking her gaze with Chance, her skin tingling. "Well, bye, guys. Glad you guys all... met up." She could hear her voice, and she sounded ridiculous, and there was little doubt that she looked ridiculous, as well. She was casting her eyes about to keep from meeting Chance's stare again – what the hell was the look he was giving her? - and to also avoid staring, or appearing to stare at, or even notice, that Lena and Marvin were touching each other like *they* were the couple, while Chance stared at Meri, one hand loosely on Lena's waist.

As if he didn't even *care* that his wife's hand was slipping unapologetically between the legs of a black man, standing right next to him.

Marvin pulled his phone out of his pocket. "That's us," he said, his voice still smooth and unruffled, as if this sort of thing, whatever *this* was, was something he did every day of the week. He held a hand up, looked

toward Meri but so briefly she was sure he hadn't even seen her, and his goodbye was swallowed by Lena's mouth.

Meri held up her own hand. "Okay," she said faintly. "Bye."

Chance was still looking at her, she could feel it, and his stare penetrated her, cool through her chest and hot between her legs, but she refused to look back at him.

She looked down at the beer in her hand, which she didn't want to drink, but it seemed like a good prop, so she brought it to her lips and sipped.

The trio left, all damp skin and hands and Lena's tinkling laughter. They didn't even manage to close the door all the way: it hit the frame and then began to swing back open, emitting a slow creak and the cold air from outside.

Meri waited, looking into the beer, until she was sure that she heard car doors slam and that they were gone. Then, because no one else was going to do it, she hustled to shut the door.

The last glimpse she had of them was all three in the back of the Uber, the cab light still on, Lena's hair splayed against Chance's shoulder, and Marvin's strong black fingers tracing a line from her neck, down her collar bone, and lower.

She shut the door, inhaling sharply. She could almost feel Marvin's fingers on her own collarbone.

*

Only a handful of people made it to twelve, and they were gone shortly afterward, which seemed to be fine with Joel, who was ushering people out like they had come by to sell knife sets and he was only finally getting them to leave. When the last group of people were closed behind the front door, the final "good party" muffled as Joel shut the door slowly on them, Meri was in the kitchen, bustling around with some bottles and glasses.

She heard Joel enter the kitchen but didn't look behind her. The backs of her arms, and her neck, seemed to have an envelope of static electricity clinging to them.

Joel approached his wife and slid his hands over her waist, pulling her close to him. The party had dragged out, longer than he wanted it to, and he couldn't get people out of his house fast enough so that he could take

advantage of Meri's unusual mood. He had his sights set on having sex twice tonight, and his thoughts were foggy from alcohol, but sexual, and way outside of the boundaries that he normally confined his hopes to.

Meri was warm, goosebumps peppered her arms and her shoulder. He placed his lips on the skin of her neck, and brushed them down to her shoulder, then back, inhaling the scent of her. His hands, meanwhile, slipped down to the hem of her dress, pulling the fabric up as he moved, revealing more and more of her thigh. Her skin was hot, slightly damp, and when he delved to the hottest center part of her, he could feel that her panties were still wet.

"Hmm," he murmured into her neck.

Meri's hand came up behind his head, her fingers playing with his hair. But she leaned forward, away from his lips, almost as soon as she had pulled on his head.

"That was a *crazy* party," she said.

Joel traced his fingers along the dip in the back of her dress, pleased as his touch ignited fresh goosebumps between her shoulder blades, and maybe – if he heard it correctly – a sharp little inhale.

The truth about sex with Meri is that lately it had become dull, and he couldn't put his finger on why, or bring himself to talk to her about it. He would drape his arm over her in the morning, and she would lie still, her breathing giving away her wakefulness. And then, he would either feel her soften against him, and he could move his hands beneath her panties and find her clit, stroking it until her pussy blossomed open, grew damp, and she rolled over to face him.

Or, she would remain stiff and he would give up.

They rarely had sex any other time of day, and he had ventured to ask her if their sex life was okay, and Meri had said "of course it is," but he knew better. And he suspected it was his own fault, but didn't know where to start in livening things up.

But now, Meri was still sticky between the folds of her pussy with his cum, and he could almost feel her writhing beneath him again. He didn't know exactly what had gotten her so worked up – the idea that it was Marvin was almost too good, too pat with his fantasies, to even contemplate – but in that moment he also didn't care.

Did any man care why his wife wanted to fuck him?

He leaned in to nuzzle the back of her neck, pushing aside some of her loose hair to get at the salty-sweet skin, so rich with her specific smell, at the center. "It was good," he murmured.

Meri spun around so quickly he didn't have time to stop her, and she almost took out his jaw with her head. "I can't believe *Marvin*," she said, bringing her hand to her mouth. "And *Lena*."

Joel smiled, and pulled her hips to get her back closer to him. "Different strokes for different folks," he commented, not really thinking. And, because his mind was on a more carnal version of whatever Meri was thinking, he continued to speak thoughtlessly, pushing a strand of her hair from her forehead and saying something like: "*You* seemed to like it."

It was the wrong thing, and Meri's face changed in increments as he realized what he had said, and that it was probably stupid.

Meri's brow furrowed a little.

"You couldn't do that, could you?" she asked, her eyes almost accusatory. "Share me? With just any old guy?"

Joel wasn't sure what answer she wanted. Just a day ago, he would have bet all the money in the world that she wanted a hard "no, way!" And that's what he would have given her, without a second thought.

But after what had happened, after Meri's obvious thrill, he couldn't help feeling like taking a risk. After all, what would Meri do if he said yes? That he could not only share her, he would do so enthusiastically? That this was actually the fantasy he had been waiting for?

Inside of him, the part of him that wanted to be a manly man was screaming at him to take this bull by the horns. Just say what he felt, and deal with the consequences later. What would Meri do, divorce him, if he told the truth and it turned out it wasn't actually what she wanted?

Do it, his voices were screaming.

He kissed her on the forehead, and a bizarre kind of self-loathing crept over him as he heard himself say:

"Of course not." He leaned back from her to smile, trying to gauge her reaction.

She looked – and this was terrible news for him – worried. Worried that he would want to share her with a man like Marvin? Worried that her husband was the kind of man who wanted to see his wife defiled by a man who had no other real characteristic except that he was black? *Could* Meri see into his mind like that?

But even thinking, guiltily, about how terrible it would be if Meri *was* worried about that particular thing made his cock throb against her thigh. Her expression changed to confusion, and there was a moment when Joel believed all was lost, when he could feel his wife's body, the promise of her hot pussy, slipping through his fingers and the whole evening somehow ending in a silent fight.

But Meri surprised him, kissing him suddenly and almost viciously on the mouth. It was a hungry kiss, and for a moment they were fumbling with each other in the kitchen, making out like they were a new couple, hands moving to places they didn't usually, out of their usual sequence, unknowns between them that only made Meri's lips more savory.

He edged her over to the counter, her teeth sinking softly into his lower lip. Her eyes were closed; his were open, trying to read her face or her thoughts, to know what was behind her feverish hands, which were working to free his cock from his pants.

He lifted her onto the counter, pulling her panties with him as he moved his hands down her thighs. When he slipped his hand between her legs – which she spread eagerly – he brushed against a slick wetness that must have been dragged across her skin by her soaked panties. He could smell her tangy pussy everywhere. She grasped his cock in her hand, and her eyes fluttered open.

She looked as though she might say something: the promise of a rare, dirty sentence from Meri's lips lingered in the air for a moment. But she seemed to think better of it, and her lips parted to let only a hot breath of air glide over his lips and his chin as she pulled herself closer to him and sheathed his cock in her soft, wet center.

Her legs crossed at the small of his back and he heard a heel fall to the floor. His right hand was sliding up her back, supporting her, his fingers against the wet hair at the nape of her neck. She bit into his shoulder through his shirt, her legs clamping down on his hips and squeezing him tightly, her pussy sloshing as he fucked her hard. She pushed up on her hands to lift her weight and ground against him, and they were both careening toward an orgasm just as quickly as in the bedroom office, earlier that night.

He could see their reflection in the window, just the back of his wife, her hair shaking with each of his thrusts. Her gasps in his ear, the feel of her pussy on his cock.

And there, at just the right angle for the light, his skin looked dark, and it took only the slightest amount of imagination to see the reflection as his fantasy: a thick, black forearm pushing against his wife's back, her hair swinging as she bounced on the cock of another man. A dark man. A man like Marvin.

"Oh, oh, oh my God!" Meri screamed. "Oh, I'm going to come!"

Joel gritted his teeth, trying not to explode as Meri ground harder against his pelvis, her feet digging into his lower back, her arms strained as she pushed herself up to bounce against his cock. All the while, in his mind, he could see it as clearly as the reflection in front of him:

Meri, letting her head fall back and her throat squeeze out a strangled moan of ecstasy, a scream, and an incomprehensible stream of ohs!... as she impaled her sweet pussy on a thicker, longer, black cock.

"Fffffff -" he started to say, but his orgasm hit him so hard that his voice was cut off mid-expletive, and his temples pounded, his hearing went temporarily muffled by the heavy blood that rushed to his head. His mouth fell open, and he stared at Meri, who was leaning back now, her eyes wide, her body squeezing him from every possible angle.

One last glance in the window, at their reflection, and he looked like himself.

But the memory of the illusion was enough to make his cock twitch violently inside of his wife.

CHAPTER 5

Meri stood by the coffee maker, cup in hand, staring out at the back porch, where the hot tub cover was still askew.

She shifted her weight from one foot to the other, feeling a good soreness inside of her pussy, and shifted again, savoring the sensation for a moment before feeling a wave of guilt wash over her.

She poured some coffee and shook her head, as if she could shake the feeling that was creeping around in her.

She took a sip of the bitter liquid: Joel liked his coffee very bitter, very strong, almost to the point that she had to pour a half-mug of hot water into it to enjoy it. But her thoughts were so far away from the kitchen she was standing in, that she didn't even notice the taste.

She didn't, after all, have anything to feel guilty about. She had sex with her own husband three times last night, and it was better sex than they had had in years. He was happy with it, she was happy with it, it beat the boring sex they'd been having lately, which she had almost – *almost* – come to think of as a chore.

So there was no reason to feel this hot itch on the back of her neck. No reason to feel troubled, or guilty.

After all, there was absolutely no way for Joel to know that her thoughts had been... well, what they were. Joel had no way of knowing that as they fucked on the counter, she had been thinking about another man, or that this morning, when he worked his fingers into her panties like he always did when he wanted to have sex, she had already been wet because she had been replaying the scenes from the night before, over and over again.

Not scenes with him.

Scenes with Marvin, and Chance. Embellishing them as she lay next to him, she had gotten herself worked up, writing alternate endings to Chance's impossibly sexy stare. Taking herself out of the office and into the hot tub instead of Lena. Wondering what it would be like to lean against her husband's chest in the back seat of a car, while another man's fingers traveled down her collar.

Wondering what it felt like to have a dark man like Marvin between her legs.

She sighed, trying to expel some of the guilt she was feeling. What did it matter what she was thinking about, if her husband wasn't any wiser and it made their sex life better?

She picked up the coffee cup and gave another look at the hot tub. The lid, slightly off, was driving her bonkers. But the hot tub itself had an allure that she didn't want to confront, or avoid, or deal with in any way.

"God," she said, setting the mug down definitively. She marched to the back porch like a woman on a mission, stomped over to the lid, and gave it such a tug to straighten it that it went too far, slid over the edge, and then started to fall over the side with its own weight. It folded in half and hung, half-on, half-off, slightly off-kilter.

She stared at the hot tub. Then she reached for the lid, and gave it a heave, knocking the lid against the controls and turning the bubbles on.

The lid slid back to its half-on position, and the salty spray of the hot tub crinkled in the air.

Meri exhaled, unable to actually believe the inclination she was having.

Joel had gone to work: one of his clients had gone a little too wild the night before and now needed a massive PR intervention, which was something that had happened, if Meri remembered correctly, almost every New Year's since Joel had become a manager.

She had the day off, because credentialing was the sort of job that always had holidays off.

She was alone. She had nothing to do. Her pussy ached from the sex they'd had last night, but there was an additional throb inside of her, a craving, a desire to do something that seemed absolutely fucking ridiculous.

Which she wasn't going to do.

She reached her arm out to the side to pull on the cover, and she'd be hard-pressed to say with a straight face that there hadn't been a tiny bit of intent, and maybe quite a bit of subconscious intent, behind the way that she did it, which sent the lid careening to the floor and backward, snapping closed next to the tub.

She looked around. The windows of the enclosed porch were open, but that was because no one could see in through the cedars and tall fence in their backyard. And anyway, it was daytime, and she knew she was deep enough in the darkness of the house that no one would see her anyway.

And she felt like a hot soak.

So what?

She hesitated only a few moments more, before peeling off the oversized shirt she was wearing and letting it fall to the floor. The air outside was frigid, and she only noticed it then, as the shirt brushed over her hardened nipples and her skin flared with goosebumps. She gave her panties a quick glance, then peeled them from her body, and climbed quickly into the steaming hot water, floating across the tub to turn the jacuzzi fully on.

She floated to rest on the bench on the opposite side, where Lena had been, in whatever state of nakedness she had been in. Sitting on Chance's lap – Chance's sizzling, wolf-like stare flashed through her mind – and where Lena had been as she lifted her foot for Marvin to massage.

Meri could almost feel strong fingers on the insole of her foot, and her eyelids fell half-closed with guilty pleasure. The memory of Joel's mouth on her toes, so unexpectedly sensual – so erotic, in fact, it had almost shocked her – sent another ripple of pleasure through her body.

She'd been with Joel since she was very young, and she had been very certain, and very adamant, that she had all the sexual encounters she needed or wanted to have in her life. He'd *asked* her about it, and she had always answered that she was perfectly content. She had meant that, she really had.

She was content.

But that didn't mean that her mind never wandered to possibilities... just not like this. Not as viscerally, not the kinds of fantasies where the men in them had actual faces and names. And not these kind of fantasies, the kinds of fantasies that were urging her to push up on her hands, letting her bottom float and her leg slide along the side of the hot tub, up into the cold air... making her extend her foot toward the empty space on the other side of the tub, close her eyes, and think of a man's mouth closing around her toe, his hand sliding along her calf, down to her thigh.

She hardly remembered having moved herself closer to the water jet, guiding her body so that the forceful stream of water kneaded her inner thigh, and then her outer pussy lips, and then struck her clit and sent a jolt through her. Too hard. She moved her hips, edged her body carefully into the stream, found a place where the water was throbbing against the ridge of her clit, almost too pleurably to stand it.

And then, her head tipped back, and she pictured a mouth closing on her toes, while hands behind her held her legs open for the pulse of water

that was very quickly, along with her imagination, burning from the inside out...

“Ah!” she screamed, jerking her leg and pulling away from the jet stream, which became too intense to bear the moment she tipped over the edge of a violent orgasm. Her pussy throbbed, and she craved just a little more, so she edged herself into the sides of the stream to wring out the last waves of the sharp, intense, climax.

When she let her foot drop from the side, her thighs were shaking, and her ears rang. The interior of her pussy pulsed, the soreness of all her lovemaking with Joel tenderly aching. The lips and center of her flower were almost numb.

The water around her sounded like perpetual static, the leftover electricity in an old TV, the static in flannel sheets, but endless. Her vision swam for a moment. And then she exhaled, not realizing her breath had been caught in her throat, stagnant, since she had come.

She leaned her head back against the side of the tub, her legs floating back to a seated position. Her eyes darted around to the windows, the window to the kitchen, the corners of the porch where someone, somehow, might be watching her, knowing the interior of her mind, and all the dark and unfaithful thoughts it contained.

There was nothing but silence, though.

Her face was hot, as much from the water as from what she'd just done.

And she didn't even have a towel.

*

“So,” Joel heard Lena's sexy voice purr, as a large envelope fell into his inbox and a puff of air caressed his face. “Nice party, I forgot to say. On New Year's. I can't remember if I told you thanks.”

Joel lifted his gaze to see Lena's bounty of curves, mildly sheathed by a heavy gray wool dress that somehow looked like a skintight party dress, and her mouth curved into a sensual, inappropriate, seductive smile. Her bob of bright red hair was gloriously shiny, and curled today for some reason, making her look, if it was possible, like more of a pinup girl than she usually did.

“Your wife had a good time?” Lena continued to purr, reminding Joel vaguely of a cat, about to tip over a cup of coffee on your computer.

Joel was one of the few men in the office who didn’t usually find himself flummoxed by Lena’s presence. It wasn’t that he didn’t find Lena attractive as hell: he did. All men did. It was just that Joel’s priority in life was Meri, and Meri took up enough space in his mind and his libido to keep him from making an idiot of himself around Lena.

Today, however, he felt like someone was crushing his chest, and made several false starts before babbling: “Uh, yeah, she did, I mean...” he cleared his throat and did the sort of fake cough men used to give themselves a few seconds to think ahead, “she, uh, yeah, it was good. A good party.”

Lena blinked slowly, the bedroomy lids of her eyes rising only halfway when she opened them. A smile twitched at the corners of her sensual mouth.

And then, inexplicably, and disturbingly – for Joel, anyway – she just stood there. She seemed to be waiting for something.

Joel waited through the silence, which was as charged as a high-voltage line – as long as he could stand it, before he began babbling again. “She was, actually, a little, um, worried, about the uh, guy from her work that she invited, and that -”

“Marvin,” Lena said simply. The word left her mouth covered in a kind of sexually furriness.

“... yeah, him. That, uh, something – well, she had, I guess, seen that you, uh, had a Fevr account or something, and Marvin was, you know... you were on it. He wasn’t going to come. But then he did. So. She was happy that everything, you know. Worked out with that.”

Joel managed, with great difficulty, to rein in his runaway mouth. It was the verbal equivalent of stopping a team of spooked horses, and he expelled a sharp puff of breath from the effort.

Lena had, during this time, gotten some Outbox papers into her hands, and was caressing them thoughtfully along the edges, which Joel couldn’t help but notice and get a subtle, sexual thrill that was laced with a slight bit of horror, due to the ease with which she could give herself a paper cut. Her eyes went skyward, and she looked thoughtful for a moment, the smile deepening on her lips.

“Huh,” she said.

Another silence hung around electrified in the room while Lena's mouth, stained by something that made her look as if she had just eaten a watermelon and had someone else lick it from everywhere but her juicy, wet lips, shifted and moved seductively.

"So Meri knew about me and Marvin?" she mused.

Joel was now looking at his computer screen and clicking. He felt sure that he could see the exact expression on his face: tight lips, rigid jaw. "Uh, yeah, well... I mean, she knew but she wasn't like, it wasn't like it was intentional that she, uh... invited all of you, it just happened to be a strange coincidence, and then she was worried because she didn't want a, um, confrontation."

Lena was smiling when Joel looked up at her. The sort of smile it was very difficult to define: like she was winning at Monopoly or listening to a toddler. "Huh," she said dreamily.

"Uh...what?" Joel babbled. It was *only* at this point in the conversation that he realized it was a conversation he wanted to prolong.

Lena shrugged. "Nothing.. just, I didn't have your wife down for that kind of... mischief-maker."

"Oh, she's not," Joel said quickly. "She is, um... very conservative, actually. I mean, she doesn't *care* what other people are doing, she just sometimes can't *believe* that other people are doing things that she wouldn't do. Like, open relationships and stuff like that. Is all."

Another breathe left his chest like it was fleeing a sinking ship.

"I see," Lena purred. "Well. Chance and I don't have any secrets, so, you know, if she has another *party* and she's worried, tell her not to be." Lena took an enormous bite of her watermelon-colored lower lip, and Joel half-expected it to start dribbling sweet juice.

Joel scratched his head. "So... like, everything is cool with that, with you two?"

Lena released her lip and smiled. "Why? Do you want to take Lena for a spin?"

A very short time must have transpired between Lena saying this and Lena laughing, but in that small time frame, Joel's heart dropped through his chest and his jaw went slack. "I – no, God. No. Just, uh -"

"Curious," Lena finished for him.

Joel was unable to say anything for a moment.

"Ohhhh," Lena said. "I get it."

Joel shook his head. “What? Get what?”

Lena just winked at him. “I get it. Listen, any time you want to know more,” she leaned over, taking a pen from a container on his desk and sliding a piece of paper closer to her hand, “just call me. Or... give Meri my number.”

The phone number written, in an unsurprisingly large, curved, and somehow sharp scrawl, Lena slid it toward Joel. “I’m pretty sure that she’d be up for a drink sometime.”

Then, she spun on her heels, and sauntered from the office.

Joel was sweating on the back of his neck.

He looked down at Lena’s number. Then he shook his head. *Yeah, okay, Lena*, he told himself, and smiled. Then, mouse in hand, he proceeded to look at his computer screen and see nothing, for at least half an hour, heart beating rapidly enough in his chest to make him feel ill.

*

The temptation was there, even if he ultimately found it comical, and believed it would end as it probably would: with Meri laughing nervously, rolling her eyes, scrunching her nose, and saying the idea was silly.

Or maybe, she would go with Lena for a drink, just to be polite, because Meri was the kind of person who didn’t like rejecting offers from people.

And so... if she *did* do that, and Joel perhaps framed Lena’s number a little differently than how she had actually given it to him, and then Meri *went* for a drink with Lena...

Meri would come back horrified.

Of course she would.

Not *horrified*. Just, eyes wide and mouth open, telling him that Lena had told her some crazy stories, and then maybe she would repeat them, or allude to them... there was always hope, right?

The idea of Lena sitting next to Meri in a bar, telling her how she fucked other men – especially men like Marvin – made his cock hard. The idea of Meri imagining Lena’s details, getting wet and horny listening to them (even though, of course, this would never happen), made his dick throb almost painfully.

On the drive home he savored his fantasy, then dismissed it, then savored it again.

It was utterly ridiculous, he told himself.

Men, though, all have one thing in common, and that is that they are hopelessly optimistic about anything to do with sex. So, while it surprised him a little bit that he did what he did next, it was also only to be expected.

After all, opportunity doesn't come knocking every day.

*

"So, I talked to Lena today," Joel said, as Meri shook the wok she was trying to reheat Chinese takeout in. Meri loathed the microwave for anything but coffee.

The pan dropped from her hand, which could have been anything: it was heavy, and she often dropped it like that. "Oh," she said, and then began shaking the wok rapidly, staring at the vegetables.

"She said thanks for the party."

"That's nice," Meri said. Then she cast a glance at Joel. "I'm soooo glad she had a good time. And that, uh... everything worked out." Meri laughed, a very fake laugh that even she decided to give up on at the end.

"She'd like to go out for drinks sometime." He pulled the scrap he'd torn from the paper Lena had written on, which had ended up being an important document he had needed to send out for signatures again. "She gave me her number."

Meri was shaking the wok. She looked over at the table furtively. "Uh-oh," she laughed.

Then, after shaking a few times, she said: "She specifically said, she wanted to go out for a drink sometime? Yeesh. That sounds sketchy."

Joel couldn't help but feeling supremely impressed with himself for anticipating how this conversation would go. Smugly, he smoothed his tie and dipped a wonton into some sauce. "Why?"

Meri looked at him and rolled her eyes, then snapped off the gas on the stove. "Why," she said. "Because she's a *swinger*, that's why. You didn't say yes, I hope?"

Joel was chewing his wonton, secretly horrified by himself and also proud of his ability to predict his wife's behavior.

At least, for now.

“Oh,” he said, chewing on the wonton. He gulped. “No, I meant... she gave me her number to give to you. She wants to go out for drinks with *you* sometime.”

He was also pleased that Meri at least thought he was attractive enough that Lena would try to put the moves on him.

Meri spun around. Her eyes glimmered with something he didn’t see often in her expression. “What?”

Joel shrugged. A very important piece of this – very slight – deception was to act like it was no big deal. Inside, his pulse was racing, he had almost an adrenaline rush going, and his cock was *pounding*, cartoonishly virile, against his zipper, to the point it almost hurt.

It was - as he had suspected it would be if he ever got so close to anything like this, which he had always assumed he would not – a fucking rush.

Meri picked up the number and looked at it. “She did *not* say that,” she said.

Joel shrugged again. “I think she had a good time at the party, she likes you. Anyway, she specifically asked me to give you her number and have you call her, maybe go out for drinks.”

It wasn’t *entirely* untrue.

Meri was looking at the paper.

She set it down quickly and spun around to deal with her reheating food. “Weird,” she said.

Just like that, Joel’s wild ride came to a crashing halt. Meri said it so dismissively, and appeared to never want to return to the subject, that he was sure he had shot and missed. Now the deer were running away, and it was over.

Still, it had been worth a try.

“You want hot sauce on this?” Meri said, her back to him.

There were ways to keep talking about it, of course.

But he didn’t want to look pathetic. Maybe someday he could finagle a drink date that looked like happenstance. Or he could just put this in his bank of fantasies, because that was probably where it belonged all along.

“Nuh,” he said, through a mouthful of wonton.

Meri left the paper on the counter, and so did he. And nothing more was said about it that evening.

*

The paper with Lena's number on it was still on the counter later that night. This was after they drank too many glasses of wine: three each were required to break the uneasy quiet between them. Not that either of them noticed it, necessarily: Joel was lost in his own thoughts, and Meri was lost in hers. Thoughts that kept returning to Lena, and via Lena, to Marvin, and from there to a whole glittering world of very naughty scenarios.

It was just escapism, she told herself.

And then, a little bleary-eyed, she had lifted her foot and placed it on Joel's leg. She was excited to find his cock beneath her toes, already hard. She played with it a little, enjoying how it made him freeze, drink in mid-air. She felt him pulse under the ball of her foot.

"Let's go in the hot tub," she said.

From there, she had kind of chickened out: she would have liked to reenact the toe job, maybe even the jet stream against her clit at the same time, and then, after she had come violently – because a toe job and a jet stream, plus the naughty factor of imagining Marvin somewhere in there would definitely result in a wild ride – she could lean over the back of the hot tub and let her husband fuck her until her pussy was sore.

As it turned out, the jet stream and the toe job didn't have time to happen, because they skipped right to the bent-over sex, and she had mostly been thinking of Joel that whole time.

Joel was notoriously bad at staying awake after that much wine and hot tub action, so she was not surprised that he began to nod off and she had to send him to bed. Then she had come back to the kitchen to tidy up. And there it was.

She picked the paper up and looked at it. Lena's handwriting looked like you'd expect it to: curvy and yet somehow hard-edged.

Why would Lena, of all people, want to have a drink with *her*?

She gave her head a shake, and tucked the paper into the pocket of her bathrobe. It was crazy. Lena was crazy. All of this was absolutely crazy.

It was fun to think about, fun to masturbate to, fun to have as a secret in her own mind.

But that's all it was, and she was sure of one thing: she was not going to call Lena.

That was just inviting... something.

CHAPTER 6

Hey Lena. It's Meri, Joel's wife. He gave me your number, said you wanted to maybe get together for a drink? I'd be up for that, if you are.

Meri stared at the text message she had been typing and re-typing for the past half hour. She frowned at the latest version. Something about it sounded... too puppy-dog like, which was not really the impression she wanted to give Lena. She also didn't want to sound bitchy, which one text had come across as. Or aloof, or too interested, or like she actually felt, which was a little bit giddy, like an adolescent watching a dirty video for the first time.

She deleted a few things.

Hey Lena. It's Meri. Joel gave me your number, said you wanted to maybe get together for a drink.

There. Simple. Confident. Just an ordinary response to an ordinary request.

Did it sound too aloof? Lena seemed kind of aloof; in fact, she intimidated Meri with so much raw sexual energy and then, with her sophisticated and sinful open relationship that she played so cool at, Lena was in the stratosphere of coolness for Meri.

Not that she cared, or wanted to be there... just, she didn't want to make a fool of herself.

Her first messages had been too long:

I would so love to hang out, I don't really have any girlfriends around town and the people at my work are all... well, co-workers...

Blah.

Blah.

Blah.

No, this last message was good.

Meri's finger hovered over the "Send" icon, and the cool sword cut through her again, she almost deleted the message, and then, in a rare

impulse-move, she tapped her thumb on the screen, and it was gone.

She set her phone down.

Then she rolled her eyes at herself. That was so much drama about something so -

The phone rumbled on the table, and Meri almost jumped.

Hey Meri. Meet me at The Foundry after work?

Meri blinked at the message.

So typically Lena, she thought, even though she barely knew Lena. She couldn't help feeling a little bit cool that Lena had gotten back to her so soon, and a little bit put-out that Lena could have the nerve to ask-tell her to meet tonight, "after work," which was no specific time, and at The Foundry, which Meri had never even heard of.

But something about Lena put a little taste of danger in the air. Something about just diving in, to see what Lena wanted, pulled at Meri. And something about doing it without telling Joel was seductive.

She lifted the phone, and rather than sorting any of the questions she had out, she typed a response and sent it, before thinking about it too much.

K.

Everything else she needed to know could be gleaned from the internet. And Joel was taking a client to dinner with some of the other managers, so there wouldn't even be a need to clear it with him ahead of time, or even tell him about it.

She wasn't sure why she wanted to keep this apart from her husband, but she did.

She pulled up a new browser on her phone. Time to find out where The Foundry was, and when Lena got off work, so she wouldn't be late or sitting there forever by herself.

*

The Foundry, it turned out, was well-known to the office intern, who had glanced at Meri's phone while collecting a pile of envelopes, and half-snorted, half smiled. "You going to The Foundry?" she had asked.

Meri had looked up at her, alarmed by her tone. “Uh... well, a friend told me to meet her there,” she said hesitantly. “Why?”

The intern shrugged. “It’s just it’s a little... you know... like, not a place where people usually meet for *drinks*. Like, friends.”

Meri made a face like she was very confused.

“It’s a cool place,” the girl added quickly. “I just thought...”

Meri looked at her blankly.

“Well, you’re like, married, right?”

Kyla thought anyone over the age of twenty-three was old. Meri had heard this for herself, when Kyla had been munching on chia seeds and yogurt, explaining to another impossibly young woman that she really liked this guy she’d met, but then she’d seen his Driver’s License, and it had turned out he was like, *old*. Like, twenty-five.

Meri hadn’t known then, and she didn’t know now, how to respond.

“I mean,” Kyla said, shifting from one foot to the other uncomfortably. “It’s fine, you know. I just thought you might be a little, like, surprised, if you go there, because it’s sort of a meat market.”

“Aha,” Meri said. She closed her phone application and shrugged. “It’s my friend’s idea,” she said. “So... and I can’t really change it.” She softened her face and smiled at Kyla. “So, you’re saying you think I should wear something else?”

Kyla looked horrified and shook her head quickly. “No, no, not if you don’t want to hook up with someone. I would, like, totally wear *that*.”

“Am I going to be the only person over thirty there?” Meri asked, growing nervous but acting nonchalant.

Kyla scratched her head. “I mean, I’ve only been there like twice, and there are some older -”

Meri smiled.

“Sorry. Just, uh, I don’t really know, it’s just, it has a kind of a, like, reputation, you know? That it’s a meat market. I’d go to Berlin, if I were you.”

Meri smiled at the earnest Kyla. Here was a person who thought her twenty-five-year-old boyfriend was old. “Thanks, Kyla,” she said cheerfully. “I’ll see if maybe my friend wants to change plans.”

Kyla left, and Meri brought up a spreadsheet she’d needed to work on all week.

It was Wednesday night. The photos of The Foundry made it look pretty young, pretty fun, pretty glittery, and pretty cool. If that was even something you could say anymore.

Just the sort of place she hadn't been to for ages, the kind of place that she told herself she didn't miss, because she never cared about that kind of thing, anyway.

The kind of place that Joel would probably prefer she didn't go to.

That would be the right thing to do. Or at the very least, she knew she should probably call him and run all of this past him. After all, she wasn't doing anything *bad*, so there was no reason not to share it with her husband.

Right?

She looked down at her white blouse and black skirt – a very sensible, very pretty combo. Very workday chic. Very: “I work in an office and I’m thirty-three.”

It was not going to fit in at The Foundry.

Meri felt the all-too-familiar sensation of very mild guilt fill her veins. Deep down inside, she knew where it came from, and why it was bubbling to the surface, and it didn't really have to do with going to The Foundry or not telling Joel what she was doing. It had to do with the flashes of fantasy that were playing in her subconscious, flashes where Lena would show up with a dark and handsome stranger, or maybe invite Marvin, or maybe run into Marvin, or someone like him...

Meri didn't let these fantasies get past the “flash” stage, but even that was enough to infuse her with a tiny bit of guilt.

Quickly, she looked around for something to take her mind off things, found the spreadsheet, and set the data prominently on her desk.

She started typing.

*

The inside of The Foundry was almost exactly like the pictures on the website, including the clientele, who were definitely on the market for something. Meri noted with relief that there were a few men with the beginnings of gray hair, though to be honest they seemed a little seedy. And there were definitely a *few* women Meri's age, but to be honest, they looked a little seedy, too.

All the women were wearing short skirts or sleeveless blouses, which made her feel out of place. Her stomach churned a little, and a wave of heat rose to her cheeks as she snaked through the crowded aisle of chairs and tables to the bar, where thankfully, she found a tall stool and one to reserve for Lena.

She met her own eyes in the mirrored splashboard behind the bar, and was pleased with her reflection. Sure, she didn't look *twenty*, but her hair, which she had let loose and scrunched a little with water to make it wavy and carefree, looked stunning as always. And the blouse was not too bad: she had undone an extra button and had to be careful not to lean over too far, but the dip between her breasts was sufficiently sexy to make her not seem overly out of place.

Not that it mattered, she reminded herself. She was married, happily married, and just meeting Lena for fun, and only because Lena had asked her to call.

The bartender was hustling, but he appeared within half a minute in front of her. "What can I get you?" he asked, and Meri was a little astonished when his eyes dropped to the revealing dip in her blouse, and lingered, before looking back up at her.

She felt her mouth becoming bigger, because this was her natural reaction to anything that made her uncomfortable or nervous, as well as genuinely pleased, or afraid, or shocked, or interested. She could see her lips in the mirror, at the corners of her vision: her mouth was large, and attractive, and her smile was a little crazy. "Uh, I'll have a..."

She realized, upon beginning the sentence, that she hadn't ordered a drink in a bar in forever, not by herself, that she usually let Joel pick for her, and now, alone, she had no idea what she wanted to say.

"...gin and tonic," she said, trying to be smooth, giving the bartender a closed-lipped smile that most men found incredibly attractive and which had a tendency to disintegrate quite easily into a sort of whispery, mid-sentence laugh.

The bartender pointed at her, his eyes crinkled up in a half-wink. "You're a Bombay girl, I can tell."

Meri's guilt skyrocketed as she elected to give him the hesitant smile, and bite into her lower lip, rather than answer. It was only when he turned to make the drink that her brain caught up with what he had said, and she remembered Bombay was a type of gin.

Surveying the gin brands, she supposed she would be a “Bombay girl,” if she was going off the packaging.

Honestly, she didn’t even like gin and tonic.

She took her phone out to check the time. She hadn’t wanted to be uncool and text Lena about the time and the place and whether or not she was coming, and it made Meri feel pretty adolescent to think of Lena as “too cool” to confirm plans with, but that wasn’t reason enough to make her change her behavior.

The bartender returned with a drink, and Meri handed over her debit card. “Keep it open?” the bartender asked.

“Uh, sure,” Meri said awkwardly.

Taking a sip of her gin and tonic – which was actually pretty good – she rolled her eyes at herself in the mirror. *Uh, sure*. How long had it been since she had been in a bar by herself? She was acting like an idiot.

A few moments passed, while Meri turned toward the bar and tried to scan the room using the mirror, while inside she felt a brew of anxiety and excitement.

A hand – hard, a little bit rough - was on her shoulder in a moment that she looked to her right. The movement might have made her jump, except that there wasn’t any time.

“You saving this seat?” a male voice said.

“Oh,” Meri said, looking at the purse she’d plunked into the chair she was saving for Lena. The bar was filling up rapidly: “after work” evidently meant right now, in this part of the city where people evidently went straight to a bar after work, even on Wednesdays. “I was,” she said, feeling her crazy smile moving all over the lower half of her face, “but I uh, have no idea when she’s getting here.”

The words had all been chosen carefully: *she’s* getting here, *I was*. They had been selected from all the possibilities that Meri could have produced, from a curt “yes,” to “yeah, for *someone*,” but Meri had chosen to specify that it was a woman she was waiting for, and leave the door open to the man standing next to her to sit down there, however temporarily.

And why? He wasn’t even good-looking, really.

“We’re in kind of the same boat,” the man said. “Mind if I sit here until your friend or my friend shows up?”

Meri lifted her purse out of the chair. “No problem.”

The guy was definitely flirting with her. But weren't all guys ultimately sort of flirting with *any* woman? Joel had told her that once, and she figured he was pretty much right.

"It's about leaving the door open," he had explained.

"For what?"

"For the possibility that the world might end and the last woman on Earth will be that one, and you'll have to repopulate the planet, and you don't want to start from scratch."

"That's the dumbest thing I've ever heard."

"Men. Are. Dumb."

So it wasn't like this guy was specifically flirting, with her, it was just a bar and that's what people did. So she wasn't doing anything wrong by sitting here and chatting with him.

Anyway. She had a wedding ring on.

She resisted the urge to twist it with her finger.

"You work around here?" he asked, taking a seat.

He wasn't actually *that* bad-looking. He had some sandy stubble on his jaw, wide-set eyes, the potential to be good-looking in the right context -

Meri cut her train of thought off. Jeez, what was wrong with her.

"No, actually," Meri said. "I work in the Tech Center."

The man appraised this information by taking a huge sip of whiskey that had been delivered to him without the bartender saying anything. "No good bars out there," he commented. His eyes took a leisurely walk all over Meri's body before dropping to the remainder of his whiskey.

Meri gave her head a slight toss, to get a lock of her hair to swing out of her face. She tucked it behind an ear, and started to open her mouth -

"You have really, really gorgeous hair," the guy said suddenly, staring at her neck, her ear, and the stray lock of hair.

Meri felt like someone had poured a bucket of cold paint down her back. She wasn't even particularly attracted to this guy – and anyway, she was *definitely* married – and also, he was being ever-so-slightly too forward and skeezy. He had leaned in a little closer than whatever was appropriate, and he was really staring at her earlobe and her neckline more than her hair.

Still, something about it was alluring. Or fun.

A fun game.

So for that reason, and to her own astonishment, Meri found herself taking a bit of the lime in her drink and saying, "Thanks. Your hair is

pretty... average.”

This made him laugh, and she had known that it would, because she delivered it with a crinkled nose and a too-large smile, which always made men laugh, no matter what she said.

And so, *she* was flirting, and she was slightly tipsy, because she'd slammed her gin and tonic, and it seemed to have had a lot of gin in it.

She was also turning, legs crossed, toward the man.

Hopefully Lena would be here soon, because she really didn't have any idea what she was starting or why. She really, really didn't have any idea *why*.

He raised his eyebrows as she turned. “Want another drink?”

She really shouldn't, because if she stopped drinking this moment, she still might have to take a cab to get home. One more and she would be toast. Her tongue touched the nub at the center of her gums, ready to say, *no thank you*, but somehow her lips and teeth changed direction, and she found herself saying, “Sure. Gin and tonic. Bombay.”

The bartender gave them the sort of look that bartenders everywhere reserve for patrons who are mismatched, when they begin flirting with each other. Meri didn't notice it: she hadn't been on the receiving end of that sort of expression for such a long time that she didn't know what it meant.

The man next to her, who turned out to be younger than her and was named Aaron, did not recognize this expression because he was the sort of person who always tried to hit above his weight.

Now that she had begun a conversation with him, and let him buy her a drink, Meri sat wondering how she would get rid of him. He talked about himself a lot, which she found annoying, and his monologue gave her time to appraise the fact that he looked older than her, even though he wasn't: his hair was thinning a little, his stomach getting a little paunchy. He wasn't as funny as he had seemed at first, and something about his mannerisms: the way he picked up a glass, or wiped things with a napkin, gave her a bad impression. She wondered why she was sitting there with him, why she had flirted with him.

When Lena would get there.

Half an hour ticked by, and Meri ordered her own next drink, another gin and tonic. She was sure that if she slipped off the stool and tried to walk, she would stumble, so she remained where she was and kept an eye out for Lena, while contributing occasionally to the conversation with

Aaron. The bar was getting louder, it seemed to her like the bartender was flirting with her, and the effect of the three drinks and the attention from another man - even a semi-dud like Aaron - was giving her a nice high.

And then, very suddenly, the enormous curves of Lena's tits floated between the two of them, encased in a tight black blouse, and her sultry voice was ordering a vodka martini. She cast her eyes down at Meri: her lids were heavily powdered with gray shadow, her eyelashes impossibly long and black. Her red hair was, as always, perfectly coiffed. Her lips were bare but shiny with gloss. She looked like an enormous, sexier, redheaded Brigitte Bardot.

"How long have you been here?" she asked Meri. Then she turned to Aaron. "Sweetheart, could you be a doll, and let me sit down here?"

Lena was already sitting, so if Aaron had not been already blubbering incoherently and scrambling from the seat, Lena looked as though she might have simply sat on him and given it no more thought.

Meri stared at her.

It was actually downright *brutal*.

"I'm Aaron," Aaron told Lena, who chose that particular moment to accept her martini from the bartender with two hands.

"That's Lena," Meri said, feeling a bit sorry for him, even if she was relieved that Lena was there and really didn't mind if Aaron left.

Lena's blouse was a clingy and expensive black material with a plain front, probably something she could wear under a jacket at work, but the back was a series of criss-crossed straps that revealed large swathes of smooth skin, and the fact that she was in extremely good shape.

Lena spun on the stool and looked at Aaron. "Aaron. Honey. I'm so sorry. But I really have to talk business with this one." She took a sip of her martini and looked at Aaron pointedly through her sexy black lashes.

He gave a hopeful glance at Meri, but already seemed to have resigned himself to his fate of banishment, because it didn't last long. "Of course, yeah. Sure. Nice meeting you, Meri." He started to walk away, then lurched to a stop and dipped into his pocket. "Here's, uh, my card."

Meri took it, her mouth open to say something apologetic, like tell him she was married, but Lena was giving her head a very firm, very obvious shake and mouthing the word "No," so Meri said nothing.

Lena watched Aaron go. "What the hell," she commented, "are you doing with that guy?"

Meri held up her gin and tonic and placed the cocktail straw to her lips. She shook her head while she sucked up some of the drink. "I don't... I wasn't..."

Lena was already grinning to herself. She snatched the card from Meri's fingers and slipped it toward the bartender over the bar. The two exchanged some kind of shared humor, and then Lena shook her hair and propped herself up on an elbow to look at Meri. "I'm glad you wanted to come out. Chance is *such* a homebody, I swear, we'd end up watching hockey and eating nachos every night of the week if he had his choice about it."

"Really?" Meri said, almost automatically. "That isn't my..." her voice trailed off, and she stabbed at the ice in her drink with her straw. "I just wouldn't have thought that about him."

She was yelling. Now that she finally had to speak, instead of pretending to listen to Aaron, she was aware that she was pretty tipsy.

Lena gave her a strange smile. "You've never spent any time with him," she said. For a second, Meri thought Lena was admonishing her, for making a comment about someone she didn't know well enough to say anything about. But Lena was smiling, and she rolled her eyes. "He can be so boring it makes my teeth hurt."

Meri blinked slowly. She could feel what she was about to say elbowing its way to the opening of her mouth, and she wanted to stop herself, but she was powerless to do so.

"Is that why you guys have an open relationship?"

The words left her mouth much louder than she expected, and she was almost horrified that she had asked the question. It was so abrupt, and Lena had barely had anything to drink.

But Lena was sipping her martini calmly, looking at the contents of the glass skeptically, like she was more interested in whatever she was tasting in her martini than what Meri had just asked. She shrugged, her brow furrowing slightly. "Not really," she said calmly. Turning to the bartender, she called out to him. "Rick. Hey. You put any juice in this?"

Rick the bartender was returning, having dropped whomever he was talking to like an old rag to approach Lena. He took her glass with a knowing grin and leaned over to her. "I'm sorry about that Lena."

"You know I like it dirty," Lena purred.

The line was so clichéd that Meri was almost embarrassed for herself for feeling a sexual thrill when Lena said it.

Luckily, Lena leaned in and shockingly kissed Rick on the mouth, which made Meri forget pretty much everything she had been thinking before that.

When Lena turned back to her, Meri averted her eyes, as if she had just walked in on someone changing clothes in the wrong changing room. She put her hand to her mouth and tapped on her lips, a gesture she did when she wanted to look thoughtful but was actually unable to think of anything.

She could sense Lena's smile to her left, burning with sexuality. "How long have you been here?" Lena asked.

Meri was happy for the change in subject. Or focus. Or whatever you wanted to call it. "Uh, I don't know," she lied. "A little while."

Lena spun with her new martini, which Rick dropped off with a wickedly sexual leer, and surveyed the bar. "Anything good out there?"

Meri couldn't help but let a silly snort escape her nose, which she slapped a hand to, as if it could be contained. "I don't... I am, not, well, like... I don't *know*," she said.

Lena twisted a toothpick with an olive between her fingers and looked at Meri. "Sure," she said, after a while, seemingly agreeing to ignore the word salad that Meri had just dribbled from her mouth. "But it isn't like you never *look*."

Meri smiled, and nodded, and took another drink. "I think that Aaron guy hogged most of my time," she said.

Lena rolled her eyes. "That guy is not even worth your time," she said solemnly, with the air of a dating game show host.

Meri shook her head. "It doesn't... I mean, matter," she laughed. She held up her ring finger and wiggled it.

Lena shifted her jaw and then smiled. "Oh yeah. That'll keep 'em away," she said sarcastically. Then she wiggled her own finger. "I think," she told Meri confidently, "I get *more* guys when I'm wearing this, than when I'm not."

"You can't be serious," Meri said. Her drink was empty. She crunched on some ice.

Lena shrugged. She was sweeping her eyes around the bar, taking stock of the men that surrounded her. It was so obvious from her body

language that that was what she was doing, that Meri felt both awe and a quiet discomfort. She watched Lena, transfixed.

"So do you like, just... go out with whoever you want?" Meri erupted, in a whisper.

Lena grinned. "Pretty much."

"And you're on Fevr?"

Lena smiled at her and ordered two more drinks.

"Okay," Meri said. "I'm really, just... like, not judgmentally or anything, but just out of curiosity, curious: how does that work?"

Lena took a sip of her martini, grinning. "How does Fevr work?" she purred.

"No - well, yeah, actually, but, no, I was thinking more like, how does that work with your marriage?"

Lena's heavily made-up lids fluttered sexily over her martini glass, and she rubbed her lips together before setting the drink down. "Not sure what you're asking," she said.

Meri was gesticulating wildly, which was partially because she was drunk, and partially because she was jittery for reasons she couldn't put her finger on. She almost knocked Lena's drink over as she flung her hands in front of her to chirp: "I mean... I'm sorry, I'm sort of drunk, but I'm like, *fascinated* by it, because you're the first actual person I've ever met who is actually in an open relationship and just like: 'oh, yeah, I'm on Fevr...' so, yeah... I guess I just want to know, is it just you, or Chance too, is *he* on Fevr? Or what?"

Lena grinned and bit into an olive. She shook her head. "It's just me," she said.

"Really?" Meri exclaimed. "It's just *you*?"

Lena gave her sidelong glance, a disbelieving glimmer in her eye. "Yeah. I'm a hotwife," she said.

Meri shook her head rapidly, to indicate she didn't know what that was, and that she almost felt squeamish delving into it.

Lena tipped her head back and bit into a second olive, looking at Meri as if she were appraising her. "Oh," she declared. "Really. You don't know anything about this, do you?"

"Should I?" Meri asked. She took a sip of her fourth drink. She was good and drunk now, but she was happy, because the conversation was

slowly moving in the direction she was only just now realizing she had wanted it to go.

Lena sank her teeth into her olive, slowly and seductively, while she considered this question. Abruptly, she lifted one side of her purse to slip her phone from inside, and her fingers began flying on her phone.

She flipped the phone around to show Meri the results of her searching, which happened to be a porn site with 3,156 videos tagged "hotwife."

The phone moaned loudly, and Meri went pale as she realized that the first video was playing.

Lena did not seem to notice and held the phone steady. "See? It's not like, anal or something, but there're a lot of people into it..."

She retracted the phone and started sweeping her fingers over the screen.

Meri had gone into one of her silent laughs, with her mouth open, and brought one hand up to her mouth to cover it while extending her palm face-forward to stop Lena from playing the video.

"Are you guys watching *porn*?" a male voice behind Lena said, dripping with interest.

Meri looked over Lena's shoulder, and saw that a good-looking man with black hair and a large build was peering at Lena's screen. He was with a group of well-dressed guys, all of them young and as good-looking as him, who were turning their heads and leaning out to see what was going on. Meri felt tears of either hilarity or deep embarrassment welling up in her eyes, so she squeezed them to stop her eyes from watering.

"Yes," Lena said dismissively.

And then, before Meri could do anything about it, the huddle of men was moving toward them, circling in like hawks.

Lena set her phone down and swung her stool around to look at the guys, who were moving their drinks and themselves into Meri and Lena's space at the bar. Lena gave the black-haired man an up-and-down appraisal, then smiled with a throaty laugh.

"I'm not," Meri said quickly, waving her hands in a motion that meant "Cancel." She hit her own glass with the side of her palm, and one of the guys reached for it and caught it before it toppled over onto the bar.

"Let me see that," the black-haired guy said, reaching for Lena's phone.

"Thanks," Meri told the guy who'd rescued her drink, as a stab of definite guilt went through her. The situation was moving quickly out of her control: it was exhilarating, in one way, but she had a sense that it was completely inappropriate, and was torn between wanting to see what would happen next and wanting to escape. "*I'm* not," she clarified to her drink savior.

Lena slid her fingers nimbly onto her phone and pulled it from the guy's fingers, tucking it into her purse. "Uh-uh," she said with a grin.

"I think any women who are watching porn at a bar deserve a free drink," the guy next to Meri declared.

"This is *not* what it looks like," Meri said helplessly.

"It's not?" Lena joked, smiling at Meri. "I'll have a vodka martini, dirty," she told Meri's drink rescuer, who nodded and looked at Meri.

"Oh, my God," Meri half-whispered. "I'm not..."

Lena was smiling to herself. "Boys," she told them, waving her hand. "Let me finish my conversation with my friend here."

She turned to the dark-haired man, and the two exchanged a sizzling moment of tension, before he said, "Whatever the lady wants," and jerked his head to recall the other two men. "We'll get back to you," he said, in a low voice next to Lena's ear.

Lena grinned and turned her attention back to Meri, as if nothing of import had just transpired.

"Oh my God," Meri repeated.

Lena rolled her eyes. "*Those* guys are a little more our speed," she told Meri.

Meri shook her head rapidly again. "Um, Lena..."

But she found it hard to finish the sentence.

Lena was looking at her, as if she'd just figured something out. "Why did you text me?" she asked bluntly.

"Huh?" Meri said. Her mind was still on the guys behind Lena, who were casting lusty glances in their direction and speaking quietly to themselves behind Lena's exposed back. Her cheeks felt hot, and she wasn't sure at all what to do.

Lena was still looking at her, smiling.

"I just... well, Joel gave me your number, said you wanted to go out for a... drink... sometime."

Lena was nodding, reaching into the recently arrived martini for a toothpick-impaled olive, smiling as if she *had* figured something out. Her expression sent strange butterflies through Meri's abdomen. "I see," Lena said.

As if she did see, but saw something else entirely.

The bartender was standing in front of them, looking like he was watching a TV show. "Another drink?" he asked Meri, when he caught her eye.

"Yeah," Meri said. Probably, she shouldn't, because in the back of her mind the problem of getting home, and then getting her car the next day, was brewing. There wouldn't be any way to explain to Joel what had happened without... *explaining* to Joel what had happened, and she really didn't feel like doing that. Largely because she couldn't even explain to herself what was happening.

"So," Meri heard herself saying with urgency. "Back to you and Chance... I still don't get it." She leaned forward to speak quietly, which was not possible when she was this drunk or with a voice like hers. Her whisper was loud and throaty, and the guys behind Meri were definitely trying to eavesdrop. "What's a... what did you call it? Hotwife."

Lena gave a glance behind her shoulder and murmured, "Simmer down, boys," which made them smile, and, if the gleam in their eyes was any indication, only more interested in whatever Lena was about to say.

Lena did not lean in or lower her voice. She sucked an olive from the toothpick and grinned. "I sleep with other men," she said simply. "And Chance watches. Sometimes. Sometimes I just tell him about it." She laughed, lightheartedly. "Sometimes I forget."

Meri's eyes had grown so wide and unblinking that they were starting to sting.

"No way," she said, shaking her head. "He doesn't get, like... jealous?"

Lena was pulling a second olive from the stick, almost pornographically wrapping her pink tongue around it. Her head was turned slightly, like she was giving the - now very interested - guys behind her a show. "That's sort of the fun of it," she said. "It's a game."

"Oh my God," Meri giggled, bringing her hand to her mouth again. The bartender winked as he set her drink down in front of her.

Meri vowed not to actually drink it, only to stir it. She gave it a swirl as if to prove the point to herself. "So you just... go out and hit on guys-"

"Guys hit on *me*," Lena corrected, confidently.

Meri nodded. "And then... what?"

"Well," Lena said loudly, "If they meet my standards, then I take them home. Or sometimes I don't."

Meri's chest felt tight, but she was having a hard time gathering her thoughts to say why. Rationally speaking, she wanted to think that it was because Lena's sex life was so wild, and her manners so.. so... *lewd*, that she was too astonished to feel anything but a tightness in her chest. Her heart was banging away right through her ribs.

However beneath any rational thought, there was excitement brewing. She still couldn't quite believe that anyone had a real open relationship like the one Lena was describing, or that a woman could actually behave like Lena, wearing a wedding ring and insinuating to real guys behind her in a bar that she would take one of them home and sleep with them.

Lena leaned toward Meri, who leaned toward her. As she did, Lena gave her eyes a quick jerk back, to indicate the guys behind her. Meri looked quickly, and then away: they were now fully involved in her and Lena's conversation, and they weren't even trying to hide it. "I like the guy with the black hair," she said, in a very low voice, putting her arm over Meri's shoulder and pulling her in toward her. She laughed, and her hot breath tickled Meri's ear, unexpectedly sexual, unexpectedly pleasing. "But I have to check on Fevr to see if there's anything better out there." She leaned back slightly, revealing that her phone was in her lap. "And by better, I mean blacker."

Meri's hand flew to her mouth again, and she bit on the ends of her ring and middle finger with her wide smile activated, a gesture she saw pleased the group of guys behind Lena. She hadn't expected that to happen, and it gave her a rush, but the rush was quickly followed by a wave of untraceable guilt.

After all: *she* wasn't doing anything. It was all Lena.

"Isn't that a little... um. I don't know...?"

Lena looked up briefly from her phone. "Are you about to say racist?" she asked casually. She shrugged, swiping through photos on her screen. They were still huddled together, head almost touching, and Meri was getting a strange thrill watching the photos sweep by at incredible speed on Lena's phone: all of the photos dark.

Marvin-dark.

She could feel the tightness in her chest squeezing her, turning her insides all around. She felt short of breath, unable to take her eyes away from the screen, the attention of the men behind Lena brewing dangerously and attractively.

She craned her neck a little to get a better look at Lena's screen. "So are you just... only looking for black men?" Meri whispered hoarsely. "Seriously?"

Lena put her tongue between her teeth and grinned. "You are like, fresh off the boat," she said absent-mindedly. "It's a filter. It's not like *these* guys aren't looking for the same thing."

"They know you're married," Meri stated flatly, almost disbelieving.

"Of course they do. And they know I'm white. And as soon as I tell them..." Lena paused on a picture and made a low growling sound, before continuing her search, "they know that Chance might be watching. So." She looked up at Meri. "It's just a *thing*, Meri. Don't do it if you don't want to, but..." she turned the phone toward Meri, showing a picture of Marvin. "Don't knock it 'til you've tried it."

She started typing.

Meri stared at her. "Are you going out with Marvin?"

Lena nodded. "Later," she said, after a few seconds.

Meri stared, mouth slightly open. "He is *hot*," she confided. "And his dick is like..." Lena pulled her hands apart by about two feet, which Meri sincerely hoped was not the actual length of Marvin's dick, but which made her have a very filthy image float through her head.

"And," Lena said imperiously. "He knows how to use it. He really, *really* knows."

Lena caught Meri's stare as she was typing and arched her right eyebrow. Then she tucked her phone into her purse and leaned toward Meri confidentially, tucking a strand of her shiny bob behind her ear. "Tell me something," she said, as if she were sincerely interested in it. "When did you get married?"

Meri felt like she was on an out-of-control carousel. "*What?*"

Lena stirred her last olive in her drink, and like anything she did, it was vaguely arousing to even Meri, who didn't have - at least she thought - any interest in women. "How old were you when you got married? Just out of curiosity. Joel seems... you know. Kind of older."

Meri's mouth snapped closed, and she felt another, curious burn on the back of her neck. Why would this question fluster her, she wondered? "Uh, I was, um, twenty."

Lena's mouth moved as though she were going to give off a sharp laugh, but she didn't make a sound. She drew the final olive lazily up to her mouth, and bit into it. Juicily. "So how many guys did you sleep with, before you married Joel?"

Meri was actually taken aback - she sat up straight, almost indignant. "I don't..." She was going to say something like, *I don't have to answer that question*, but something inside of her wanted to see where the conversation was going.

"You don't know?" Lena said playfully. "Or you don't...?"

Meri sighed, almost exasperated. Lena was looking at her with unbridled curiosity, and something about her sexiness gave Meri a thrill, though she couldn't put her finger on why. It was like having a cool girl in high school suddenly take you into her confidence, which was adolescent at best, but she couldn't help feeling a certain allure because of it.

Meri turned toward the bar and put her elbow on the bar, lifting the remnants of her drink. She cracked up before it reached her lips. "Only like four. Well... four, if you include, like, drunk, you know..."

Lena leaned in, her eyes burning, like she really wanted to hear the answer.

"Oral sex," Meri said very quietly, aware that her voice, which she never really had under control, was much louder and sillier than she had intended.

Lena didn't really react at first. She gave a final bite to the olive, and twisted the stick in her drink, with the same casual sexiness that she had been doing everything that night. "You don't. Count that, I mean. So... don't you ever get curious?" she purred.

The flush that traveled over Meri's face was red-hot, and instant. It was the result of what Lena said hitting the nail completely on the head: she *was* curious, and that was the reason she was there. But it was a curiosity she didn't want to admit to, even to herself.

Meri snorted, and brought the drink to her lips. She found herself in the strange position of not wanting to look uncool to Lena, and not wanting to say what was really on her mind. "I... no. I mean, not curious-curious."

"What does *that* mean?" Lena asked, smiling.

Meri cast a glance over Lena's shoulders, where the trio of good-looking men were doing a terrible job of looking like they weren't interested or eavesdropping. Lena saw the look, grinned, and turned on her stool, letting it roll around slowly, like the olives in her mouth. "Guys," Meri heard her say. And then she must have lured them closer to her with a hooked finger, because they leaned in, amused. Lena's head leaned in toward them, and she said something that Meri couldn't hear. She did, however, notice that one of their eyebrows arched, another one looked quickly at Meri, and the third guy's mouth fell open slightly.

As Lena turned her stool slowly back to Meri, a triumphant expression her face, the three guys gathered their drinks and edged away from them, down the bar.

Meri scrunched her nose, and smiled, feeling like her face was out of control. "What did you *say* to them?"

Lena made a low sound, that came out as "huh," and took a sip of her martini, which Meri supposed was shorthand for: *never you mind*.

"Rick," Lena called. "Get us two more drinks."

Rick the bartender was only too happy to do just that. Meri had her hand up to indicate that she didn't need another one, but Lena was already turning to her, her big, beautiful eyes bedroommy and gleaming with interest. "I just mean, if you slept with all these guys before you got married, then I assume they were kind of young, and... aren't you curious?"

"About?"

"Other men. Other sex. Other *dicks*."

Meri laughed again, her hand flying up to her huge smile. She could feel the glances of the three guys Lena had shooed away as though there was electricity in the air, radiating to the left side of her body. "No," she said quickly.

Then she shook her head for emphasis.

"No," Lena repeated. She slid her new drink toward herself on the counter. "So why are you here?"

The question had a chilling effect on Meri.

Why *was* she here?

She was drunk, though, and she could feel the effects of all of her drinks rising up inside of her, making her say: "Okay. Actually. Yeah. I am a little bit curious. But not, like, personally. Just... um... voyeuristically."

This piqued Lena's interest greatly. "Voyeuristically, mmm," she murmured.

"Oh God. Oh no, not like, actually voyeuristically," Meri added quickly. "No, I think I meant, what's the word?" But she couldn't think of it, and Lena was drawing a fresh olive into her mouth, watching her with amused interest. Meri felt like she was sitting next to a furnace, including a facial flush. She was sweating at the back of her neck.

"Platonically... no..." she stumbled. "Vicariously." That was it.

"Vicariously," Lena repeated. She dipped the remaining olives back into her drink, smiling.

"What?" Meri said. "Okay. I have to tell you something."

It was well-known to Meri, and to Joel, that Meri had a tendency to get confessional when she was this drunk, which didn't happen very often, precisely because of this particular habit of hers. She leaned toward Lena anyway, even though something inside of her told her to stop. "I saw you, with Marvin," she whispered.

Lena smiled and brought her old martini to her lips to finish it in one gulp, but she never stopped smiling, even as she drank. "Where?"

"In the hot tub, at my party," Meri said.

Lena looked skyward, as if she had to think about it, and then, as if she couldn't be bothered with finding the answer. "Oh, yeah," she said, in a tone that prompted Meri to continue.

"And... well, then Joel said you gave me your number, and... I don't know, I just couldn't get it out of my head that you, like, hooked up with my coworker, and you're married, and your husband didn't even *care*..."

Lena was stirring her new drink now. "Did you invite me and Marvin to the party on purpose?" she asked casually. "To see what would happen?"

Meri put her fingertips on her temples and sucked her breath in with her lower lip under her top teeth. "Yes," she admitted.

Lena leaned toward Meri, one elbow on the bar. Her legs were crossed, she was perched on the edge of the chair, looking like she was about to be photographed in a magazine spread. Her right foot made a slow, sexy circle, and Meri noticed her incredibly high heels, expensive footwear, and wondered momentarily if Lena wore those things to work.

"In my book, that means you're curious."

Meri chewed on her finger again, smiling. She was way past having any sense of propriety, she could feel it. "I'm mostly curious - and again,

this is vicariously - about your Fevr account." She looked over Lena's shoulder. "The natives are getting restless."

Lena waved them away absent-mindedly and pulled her phone out of her bag. "Who cares about them," she said dismissively. "What do you want to see?"

Meri still had a pinky finger between her teeth, and she was smiling like an idiot. She glanced down at Lena's phone, where Marvin's profile picture - Marvin with no shirt, well-muscled, serious - was staring up at her. She felt her pussy contract, a wetness pooling in her panties, and a much different heat spreading through her lower abdomen than she had felt in a long time.

"Um," she croaked, in a vocal-fry she used for embarrassing occasions. "I don't know. Just, like... how does it work?"

"Oh my God," Lena said. She moved her fingers over the screen. "So, you see this guy here?"

Meri nodded, her lips wet with a sip of her drink. She was going to have a huge hangover, but she was on a train of slightly-evil-doing now, and it had been so long since she'd done anything like this that she didn't feel like getting off. The guy on the screen was *hot*: light black skin, tattoos across his bare chest, a trim goatee.

"You like him?" Lena asked.

"Me?" Meri said, too quickly. "No, I mean... I don't..."

"You like him," Lena purred knowledgeably. "Of course you do. He's hot as fuck." She swiped the screen to the right, and the man disappeared replaced by another. "What about this guy?"

"Wait," Meri said. "So... what happened to that guy?"

"Nothing. If he likes me, then we can message, and if we message, we can hook up. Simple."

"But what -"

"You like this guy or not?" Lena asked. Meri looked down. The man on the screen was good-looking, but wearing a slightly dorky shirt, and he looked like he worked in an office.

"No, right?" Lena said, swiping left.

Meri was silent-laughing again. "But what, what about like... where's all the information like, about their..."

Lena smiled, swiping left again. "Personality? Income? Whether they like dogs? I'm not looking to marry these guys, I'm looking for sex," she

said plainly. "But it's here, at the bottom, if they put it."

"Oh my God," Meri murmured, flushed. She took a huge sip of her drink. Lena had her tongue between her teeth and was smiling again.

"What about him?" she turned her screen toward Meri again.

Meri gulped. "That's the guy behind you," she said.

Lena looked again. "Oh," she said. "So it is. Hey, he's not too bad without his shirt off."

Meri shook her head. "Oh my God," she repeated.

Lena was swiping at her phone. "Okay, so then, see... this guy here? Damien? He's a match, which means he liked my profile. So now, I can message him, and we can hook up, or not, or whatever."

Meri was bringing the small drink straw to her lips and missed her mouth. Annoyed, she grabbed it and brought it between her lips. She was pretty wrecked, so there was no point turning back now. "So, what do you do next?" she asked. "Just say, hey, want to meet up and have sex while my husband watches?"

Lena shrugged. "Yeah, pretty much."

Meri set her drink down. "I can't *believe* that," she said.

"Most of these guys end up being duds," Lena said, slipping her phone into her purse. "I usually meet them for a drink, and then, you know, you get the vibe off of them."

"Oh my God," Meri said, for what seemed like the twentieth time to her. Her eyes wandered to Lena's phone, and Lena's gaze followed with interest.

"How many guys do you, like, 'like' in say, like, on any given day?"

Lena slipped the phone back onto the counter. "Why? Do you want to look at more?"

Meri had the straw between her teeth again, and she was shaking her head "no," but her hand was pulling the phone toward herself, and she was looking at Lena mischievously.

"You do," Lena said. "Tell you what. Go nuts. Just... don't toss out any good-looking guys." She put her hand to the side of her mouth while rising, turning, and picking up her drink with her other hand. She didn't do a very good job of blocking what she was saying from anyone except the bartender. "As in, don't toss out the hot black guys. I'm going for a pee."

"Oh my God," Meri said again, as Lena strolled past her.

But the allure of Fevr was too much for her. So much, in fact, that she forgot where she was: drunk off her head at a downtown meat-market bar, with no ride home, on a Wednesday night, with three guys staring at her lasciviously, and Lena's phone in her hand, full of hot black guys.

So she started to swipe.

*

Lena was gone a long time, which Meri only realized when she came back and sat down next to her, reaching for her phone. "Jesus," she commented. "Take it easy, I have like twenty messages here. *Don't*," she added, pointing a finger at Meri, "Say 'oh my God.'"

"Oh my God," Meri said. "What time is it?"

Lena grinned. "Look, I already told Marvin I'd meet up with him later, so I have to get going. You live out by Hillcrest, right? Want to share an Uber?"

Meri looked at her own phone. There were two text messages from Joel, both of which she could see were boring by their previews (*Don't forget to pick up the....* and *Probably going to be late if you...*), and it was nine-thirty.

"Yeah," she said. She dug into her purse to find her wallet. "I just... I don't use Uber, so..."

Lena smiled. "Already done. Tab's paid, too."

"Huh?"

Lena was standing, looking as refreshed as if she'd just stepped out of a spa. Her makeup was perfect, her hair was perfect, and she had her hands in the pockets of a light jacket that matched her dress, which she appeared to have produced from nowhere. She jerked her head very slightly behind her. "Tab's paid up," she said, with a grin. She pointed in Meri's direction. "That way."

Meri started to say something, but Lena pressed her extended finger against her lips, and somehow, Meri managed to stay upright exiting through the bar, which dropped off into another open, larger room, and had an exit around the corner from where she'd come in.

Lena had called an Uber. Meri followed her without knowing what to say, climbing into the car. Lena chatted with the driver, and then the conversation dribbled off. Lena looked over at Meri, gave her a wicked

smile, and jerked her head to fling her hair from her face, tucking it sensually behind her ear. "So," she said.

"What?" Meri said, with a too-naive laugh.

"You had some more questions about Fevr. Better ask, we're almost home."

Meri looked at her skirt and smoothed it out, shaking her head, about to deny the proposition with a firm, "I do not." But she rubbed her forehead instead.

"Okay," Meri said. "Uh, how do you, like... get started with that kind of thing? Like, what do you put? About yourself?"

Lena leaned close to her, phone in hand. "Here," she said. "This is my profile."

Meri read Lena's profile and raised her eyebrows. "Hotwife seeks bull," she said in a whisper. "What is...?"

Lena smiled. "I'm the hotwife, Marvin's the bull. Get it? I put some pictures up. And then..." she showed Meri the screen again, too fast for Meri to see, and brought it back to swiped with her long delicate fingers. "I just see what gets caught in my net. Sort of like fishing."

Meri cleared her throat. "But, I mean, aren't you worried that like, people will see your profile and be like: what the hell is Lena doing? She's married?"

Lena shook her head, wrinkling her brow. "I don't care. But also think about it for a second."

Meri waited, and when it became apparent that Lena wasn't going to explain any further, she did think about it for a second. She rubbed her forehead. "I'm too drunk," she admitted.

Lena grinned. "If someone sees your Fevr profile, what does that mean?"

"Oh," Meri said, after giving it some thought.

Of course. *They* were on Fevr, too. So that safely eliminated the possibility of her *married* friends being on Fevr.

But not her *unmarried* friends.

Or, possibly, anyone. If Lena was an example of what was really going on out there.

"Look," Lena said. "You can also set your settings, uh... here," she flipped her phone toward Meri, "and use "Hidden. That way, I guess, only people you swipe will see your profile."

"Oh," Meri said, wheels turning in her head. "Do you do that?"
Lena tsked. "Uh-uh. That's a hack for cheaters, and you miss out on a lot."

Meri was still thinking. "So you're just... upfront about it?"

"I'm a hotwife. There's a difference."

Meri shook her head. "This has been... really, I mean really, educational," she said. "I can't believe you just... do this."

Her voice sounded awed, and it was only when she heard herself that she realized that in many ways, she was. Awed. Perhaps even a bit of jealousy lurked inside of her: Lena was admirably sexy, too cool for school, and totally unafraid to just... do what Meri could barely even fantasize about fantasizing about.

Lena rolled her eyes. "Life's too short," she murmured. "And in like twenty years, this won't be fun anymore. Make hay while the sun shines, I say."

She looked over at Meri as the car rolled to a stop. "You should really give it some thought," she said, smiling.

"What? Getting a Fevr account?"

"For starters," Lena said quietly, and winked. She shrugged. "I think there are some couples who just set up an account and like, swipe together. Without even going on dates. I don't see what the fun is in *that*, but people do it."

Meri was shaking her head, and thinking, but not saying, *Oh God, oh no, Joel would never go for anything like that, and anyway, I would never go for anything like that* - because she wouldn't, right?

Lena opened the door, before Meri could think of anything to say, and then she leaned down to look at Meri before closing it. "I also have some good recommendations, if you need any advice."

And just like that, the door was closed, and Lena was gone.

*

Meri arrived home at ten-thirty, and she was relieved to see that Joel wasn't there yet. She stumbled into the house, also relieved that she had managed to make it home with all of her belongings, and without getting arrested or doing something she would regret with the incomparable Lena.

"Oh. My. God," she repeated, to the empty house, leaning heavily on an armchair to take off her shoes. Her head was spinning, and not just with alcohol. She laughed as she tipped forward and spilled out the contents of her purse.

She made her way to the kitchen, passing the fridge and realizing she hadn't eaten dinner. The idea was not pleasant. She opened the medicine cabinet instead and took some Ibuprofen, and then told herself to go to bed.

She found her phone in her re-packed purse, which she had evidently dragged in with her and tossed on the counter in the kitchen, without really remembering doing it.

She leaned on the counter and read Joel's messages.

Don't forget to pick up the mail, I think it's been like a week.

Probably going to be late if you just want to go to bed.

Yeah, looking like a drinkfest, sorry. Don't wait up.

It was not uncommon at TopperRep for client dinners, because they were usually with male sports figures of the "already arrived" type, to go on until four in the morning, and there wasn't much Joel could do about it. Meri also knew, because Joel had told her, that they more often than not ended up at a strip club, which wasn't something that had ever bothered her all that much.

Joel, after all, adored *her*.

Still, the idea that he was drunk at a strip club right then, looking at barely legal girls dancing almost naked, helped erase some of the vaguely guilty uneasiness she had been feeling all night.

She started to type him a message, but realized halfway through that she had nothing to say. And that it was probably best she said nothing at all, given the state she was in.

She turned and leaned on the counter, swiping at her screen.

And then, just for fun, she decided to look at Fevr.

*

It was underwhelming, she was planning to tell Joel - and she had been planning to tell him this the next day - to investigate Fevr without an account. She had talked to Lena about it, and she just wanted to *see* what was going on.

Meri was a pretty savvy internet user, so it didn't take her long - in a series of hidden searches, the history of which she erased meticulously, *just in case* - to find out how to set up a basically anonymous Fevr account.

By the time she had done this, it was twelve, and Joel still wasn't home. It wasn't a big surprise: it wasn't even unusual.

Her buzz, which was really more of a drunk, was fading - it was incredible, really, that she was even still up. So she had a little bit more to drink.

And then she spent about an hour taking photos of herself.

And then she spent about an hour thinking of her "About Me" blurb, which she wrote and rewrote about three times.

And somewhere, around three in the morning, while Joel was still not home, and because she was drunk, and buzzing on a high of unexpected excitement, because she was bursting with curiosity, because Lena's carefree attitude and blatant sexuality would not leave her mind - and because, in the end, she could always claim she had just done it out of curiosity, and at three am after that many drinks, that sort of explanation makes perfect sense - she went ahead and set up her account.

Just to *see*.

She would only - and she had researched this carefully - swipe left, so no one would ever see her anyway. But just in case, she had taken a picture of herself that she felt wouldn't reveal too much of anything about her.

She left her About Me as simple as possible, because she wasn't intending to *use* it. But she spent far too long, her head crooked against her hand, rewriting, second-guessing. Her hand fell asleep as she rewrote for what could have been an hour, her stomach twisting with cool excitement when she pictured men reading her profile, thinking about her words.

Finally, she decided to just be honest. After all, this was only a game.

"Probably just looking," she said aloud, while she typed. Because that was all she was doing.

Just having fun.

The first profiles that came to her were easy to swipe away: guys who were far too young, she told herself (even though she had an age filter that

allowed them in), or pictures of pure chest and abs (even if, she thought with a vague sense of hypocrisy, that was the real reason she had come on to Fevr in the first place).

But then *he* came up. A dark man, shirtless, wearing only jeans, only the stubble on his square jaw visible at the top of the page, with sensual lips in a smile that was reminiscent of Marvin's.

Meri went cold again: the sensation a mixture of shock, fear, excitement, and attraction. A little dose of illicitness, and guilt, thrown in for good measure. A sensation that radiated back and forth, like cool electricity, between her chest and her groin.

She stared at the screen, teetering on the edge of a strange abyss. She knew she didn't have to do anything at all. She knew this intellectually, but she couldn't compel herself to close the app, or swipe left, or even worse, swipe right. She stared, feeling almost like she had been caught.

And teetering on the edge of that abyss, she heard the door slam, and the stumble of her husband in the hallway, the tinkle of dropped keys. Joel muttered "damn."

It was as if she suddenly zoomed out of a very small picture and saw it for what it was, and so her fingers flew as she turned off her phone and slipped under the covers, her breath ragged and quick, her heart racing. She closed her eyes and tried to steady it, because she really wanted Joel to believe she was asleep.

Meri was drunk, and she had a tendency to tell on herself anyway.

And right now, having zoomed out to see herself for what she was - a married woman experimenting with a Fevr account because she secretly was attracted to black men and had a new slutty friend who she had not told her husband she was going out with - she felt like she couldn't face him.

Also, it was four in the morning.

And she had to collect her car tomorrow before work.

Which meant that she would need to wake up in two hours.

She listened for Joel, and when she didn't hear him in the hallway, but heard the distant thud of a cupboard in the kitchen, she slipped her hand out and pulled her phone under the covers with her.

She set her alarm for 5:45, then slipped the phone back onto the bedside table.

All of this would seem like a drunken, idiotic mistake tomorrow morning, and when she was sober, she could straighten it all out, cover her

tracks, tell Joel what she had done and be able to explain how it was all just curiosity, then go on with life like none of it had ever happened.

*

Joel didn't notice that Meri's car wasn't there, probably because he was seeing triple by the time his cab arrived at their house. He very nearly went up the driveway to the neighbor's house.

He stumbled into the kitchen looking for Tylenol, trying desperately to be quiet, and found Meri's purse, the contents scattered on the countertop. So, he knew she was home, and probably asleep, because Meri didn't usually wait up for him on nights like this.

It *was* odd she had never texted him back, but he just figured she'd gone to bed much earlier.

He started a quest for the Tylenol in the kitchen cupboards, trying, and probably failing, to be quiet. Nights like this one, thankfully, didn't have to happen very often, and he mostly drank as much as he did to keep up with his clients and make them feel comfortable. A lot of them were actually non- or very mild drinkers, because he rep'ed serious athletes.

But every now and then, he got a real live wire, and that's what tonight had been.

It was only when he had the Tylenol bottle in his hand that he gave it a second thought: drifting somewhere in the back of his mind was the memorable fact that Tylenol was very bad for your liver, and if you combined it with alcohol, even worse.

He was no spring chicken.

He patted himself down for his phone, the intention being to consult the internet for an answer he wanted to hear. He felt pretty sure that at least a thousand idiots like him had already typed in the question: "Will I die if I take a Tylenol after having ten drinks?" which is when he realized that his phone was lost. Or so terribly misplaced he wasn't going to find it in time to answer the question.

He was drunk, though, so his normally good judgment could not as much as pry into the part of his brain responsible for the actions he subsequently took: stumbling down the hall, trying to be quiet, believing that he had been successful because Meri didn't wake up even when he fell onto her side, stealing his wife's phone, and stumbling back to the kitchen

to ask Google his burning question, which by then, he had pretty much forgotten.

It wouldn't have mattered, though, if he had remembered it, because when he unlocked Meri's phone, his eyes and mind were dragged away by the notifications.

From Fevr.

You've got a new match! (heart-eyed emoticons).

Jay sent you a new message.

A wave of nausea overtook him, and he leaned too far forward almost falling face-first onto the floor, but caught himself on a stool, sent it teetering and eventually tipping over, with his weight on the edge of it, until stool, Joel, and phone were on the floor.

The phone spun on the wood floor in front of him, and Joel stared at it.

Fevr, Fevr?

Ideas percolated in his mind, and evaporated just as quickly: half-formed ideas about how there could be another explanation for what he had seen on Meri's phone other than the most obvious. It wasn't her phone; it wasn't Fevr he had seen but a similarly-named app. But as the phone spun slower, he could see plainly that it was in fact Fevr, and the messages were exactly what he had thought they had been, and anyway, there was no other explanation for a "match" than the first one he had thought of.

He was surprised by the cool feeling of betrayal that gripped him first: after all, had it not been a fantasy of his? This very scenario? It turned him on when he thought about it, even if he imagined the scenario as a nightmare like this one, where Meri was cheating on him. But with the evidence glaring at him from her slowly rotating screen on the floor, he felt a different kind of burn first.

Still.

It was still arousing, even through his drunken stupor.

His stomach felt like a block of ice and his heart was racing as he leaned over himself to reach for the phone.

It felt heavy in the palm of his hand, like the weight that was dragging him down from inside.

It was Meri's phone.

The pattern to unlock it had worked, after all.

And she *did* have a match and a message. On Fevr. From Jay.

He would later want to be able to say that he had given it more thought than he did, that he had agonized over the decision, but he didn't do much thinking or agonizing before tapping on the message icon.

Jay's profile picture was of a black man's sculpted chest. Joel was pretty sure that his heart stopped beating completely, and that he didn't breathe for a full minute, as he stared at the profile pic and ignored the words entirely.

But then he read them, and his cock sprang to life violently.

Hi. You're a pretty cute girl and I would love to get to know someone like you, who's maybe a little bit kinky, too. Tell me what you're into, and I can make it happen...

"What the fuck?" Joel said to the screen, in a horrified, loud whisper.

He sat like that for a long time.

It was a nightmarish thing, to have a fantasy spring suddenly to life. But it was almost as if it were a freakish version of his fantasy, as though he had sculpted a perfect woman but when she smiled you could see a black tooth somewhere in her molars. Something was just a little bit off, not the fantasy he wanted, not the feeling he had been seeking.

At all.

His gut hurt as though it had been put through an old-fashioned laundry wringer. He clumsily got to his feet, swept the phone up from the floor, and stared some more. And then he began digging, because he figured he was already in so deep that there was no way to hide this from Meri anyway. The discovery was too big, the pain too great, the perverse delight of it a little more bitter than he had expected.

Happily married. Looking for spice. Probably just browsing.

Joel wasn't a big reader, but he was a snob, and he had always reserved a special hatred for the expression "to have one's eyes bug out his head." Experiencing that very sensation, however, he made a mental note to go easy on authors who used the expression, because one really can have one's eyes bug nearly out of their head. Especially if they read something like this on their own wife's secret Fevr profile.

Being drunk, and not having the first clue how Fevr worked, Joel was unable to produce any more information, or any more messages, than the single message from Jay, and Meri's profile picture and About Me section.

He slid down the side of the kitchen island, where he had come to rest, and stared at the phone. He thought of masturbating, of the porn videos he had watched, of his personal fantasies, of betrayal, and a few other thoughts in the same vein, but in the end, he drifted off to sleep.

*

It seemed like only seconds later that the phone erupted in his hand. An alarm. It vibrated and tinkled: the vibration made its way into a sludgy dream he was having as a snake was swallowing his arm, and he dropped the phone with a clatter as he was ripped from sleep to his morning reality, and then had the memories of the night before come crashing through his mind like a bull in a china shop.

Meri.

Fevr.

Cheating.

Jay.

Black.

Phone still ringing.

The phone he had sneaked into the bedroom to get - why had he done that again? - and which he had broken into and perused. He stood up, staring at the phone, wondering why Meri would set her alarm so early and so loud, and how he was going to explain still standing in the kitchen with it in his hand, still dressed, so obviously recently returned home.

"Fuck," he muttered, swiping "Snooze" for the alarm, which mercifully shut up.

He was still drunk, that much he was sure of. He was unsteady on his feet, trying to wade through the hurricane in his mind, as he swayed down the hallway and pushed open the door to the bedroom.

Meri was exactly as he remembered having left her, on her side, asleep.

He tip-toed to the bedside table, and set the phone down gently, heart racing. Meri didn't stir, and he felt the rush of relief that comes after successfully doing something sneaky.

But now what?

He stared at Meri, who was sleeping right through all of this, which was unusual, to say the least.

And was this *really* something he was going to just let go? Not confront her about?

He was edging away from her side of the bed.

Should he pretend to be asleep? Or go out on the couch? What would he have done last night, if he hadn't been taken on this wild detour?

His heart sank again as he remembered the Fevr account.

Looking for spice.

His cock thickened.

Probably just browsing.

And her profile picture. *Hot*. Mysterious. Just the kind of profile that would draw in creeps like Jay, "looking for kinky."

Wasn't it what he had always imagined and fantasized about? They were dark fantasies, but fantasies that he returned to all the time.

It was just that... something was *off*. Unsettling.

He was easing himself into bed, slipping under the covers in his clothes, sensitive to any change in Meri. He didn't know what to do or how to act, how to even act like he had never seen the Fevr account, so he had decided to lie in bed and pretend to sleep until he figured it out.

Meri's phone started ringing its alarm again.

On, and on. No response from Meri.

Joel tried to ignore it, but it was pressing his buttons in the exact most annoying way he could think of: his heart rate was already high, his blood pressure making the blood in his ears sound like an intermittent waterfall, and the phone would not stop vibrating against the bed, delivering an electrical hum to his left ear, through the pillow.

"Fuck," he hissed, throwing off the covers and sitting bolt upright. "Meri, Jesus," he said, leaning over her body and slapping at the phone.

This woke her: her eyes sprung open, like a doll's, and Joel watched as a mounting horror, not entirely different from the one he had experienced in the kitchen only minutes ago, set in on her too-open eyes.

"Shit," she said, her hand wriggling out from under the covers to grab the phone. "Sorry. Sorry. I left my..." she sat up, pushing Joel's arm off her. "I have to get up, why is this ten minutes late? Shit."

She stared at the phone for a few moments too long, pushed her hair from her face, and then looked down at Joel. "I'm sorry," she said. "I left my car downtown. I have to get a cab and pick it up before work."

Joel stared at his wife.

She didn't waste any time looking back at him; instead, she threw the covers off and bustled into the bathroom, closing the door, as Meri tended to, only partway, so that a bright wedge of light caused Joel to squint and throw the covers back over his head.

There was no arguing the simple fact that, even as he sat there stewing about his wife's treachery, her Fevr account and her message from the kink-loving Jay, his cock was hard as stone. The feeling boiling in his lower abdomen was unpleasant and excruciating, but hot and infinitely pleasurable at the same time.

"Why's your car downtown?" he croaked from under the covers.

Meri turned on the water to the shower at the same time. "Huh? I'll tell you when I get out."

She was impatient, cranky. Had she gone out the night before, with another Fevr date? Was this something his wife had been doing for a long time, and he had never known or noticed the signs? His cock throbbed at the thought of it: Meri, with a dual personality, cheating on him every time he took out a client. Telling men like Jay that yes, she was kinky.

How kinky *was* the alter-ego of his sexually conservative wife? Was Kinky Meri, who liked black men evidently, into anal, or throat-fucking, or being tied up? Did she get on her knees and slurp up huge, thick black cocks?

His mind veered off into thoughts made of pure imagery, a land of pornography in which his wife was a filthy slut, letting huge, muscled black men manhandle her.

The door opened, the bright light filled the room. He heard the snap of the light.

"Why's your car downtown?" he repeated. His own throat was dry and his voice sounded sticky and hoarse. He had spent most of the night yelling over the strip club music and had smoked a cigar at some point.

"Oh God," Meri said hastily. "I don't even know... what got into me..." He heard a drawer creak open, then shut, then Meri curse under her breath. "You don't want to drive me to my car, do you?" she said. "I'm thinking I forgot about rush hour..."

Joel heard her slide her phone towards herself on the table. Then the duvet was pulled away from his head, and he squinted at Meri's silhouette on the edge of the bed. Behind her, the blue light of the early dawn was just beginning to creep into the black sky.

"Holy shit," she commented. "Never mind. You'd get a DUI. Wow. I thought I was bad." Meri waved her hand in front of her face.

Joel dropped his hand to her wrist. "Why were you downtown last night?"

He tried his best to sound casual, but his deep interest, his sexual fervor, came through in his voice.

At least, it did for him.

Meri looked at him, and he couldn't read her expression: did she hear something in his voice? Was she nervous, being asked about a trip downtown that she didn't have an explanation for.

"I sort of did something behind your back," she said.

His heart sank inward, becoming so dense and cold that he could barely feel anything but the piercing pain in his chest.

"I gave Lena a call," she said, rubbing her forehead. "She invited me for drinks at some place downtown."

"Lena," Joel repeated. He felt the coil around him unraveling. It still didn't explain Fevr, but it seemed honest as it came out of Meri's mouth.

Lena.

"I had like a billion drinks," Meri added. "If it makes you feel better, I feel terrible."

Joel smiled wanly. It didn't make him feel better, in fact, it made him feel *worse*.

"I have to go," Meri said quickly, leaning forward to kiss him on the forehead, popping up almost before she was done. "I'll tell you all about it later." Meri hopped to the door, and then turned around. "You should maybe take the day off. You look rougher than I do. And that's saying something."

CHAPTER 7

Sunlight stabbed at her eyes as she rode downtown in an Uber. Guilt stabbed at her as she directed her driver in circles around the area of The Foundry, trying to find the parking lot where she had left her car. When she finally located it, two parking tickets, at \$50 a pop, fluttered in the light morning breeze.

She managed to drive to work, not entirely sure she was legally sober enough to be doing it, and she arrived, thick-headed and slightly ill, just in time to crawl into her cubicle and hunker down with a cup of coffee.

From there, the day got busy fast, and she was tired, so the hours peeled away without much time to think about the evening before or what she had done. Still, the guilt nagged away at her as flashes of her Fevr adventure surfaced in her mind.

She would delete her account, of course. This evening, right away. Nothing had happened, she told herself.

The afternoon was sluggish: she had dedicated herself to her tasks with robotic efficiency and had more free time than she would have liked. No one she was contacting by phone had answered: there was nothing to do but wait for calls to come in, or a crisis to land on her desk; but neither of these things happened.

Which left her with time to contemplate what she had done.

She left her phone in her purse, not checking it for fear of being sucked into Fevr, of finding a message from Lena, of finding a message from Joel - whose troubled face had indicated that he suspected she had done something more than just go out with Lena.

She finally withdrew her phone in the afternoon and checked her texts: nothing from Lena, and nothing from Joel, which made her heart sink. If things were just normal between them, wouldn't he have written a message to see if she had made it to work okay?

By the same token, she thought guiltily, wouldn't *she* have sent a message to him, to let him know the same thing and ask how he was feeling?

She stared at the message text box for a few minutes, wishing she had sent him a message earlier. Now there was a definite tension between them,

something that needed explanation, and she had made it worse by ignoring it.

The Fevr icon burned through the back of her mind, creeping into her thoughts, but she decided to pretend like it had never happened. She would deal with it later and ignore it until then. The excitement she had felt the night before licked at her insides like a flame, but her guilty conscience - a nebulous, indefinable guilt - put a damper on the feeling.

Hey. How are you feeling? Want me to pick up some take-out?

She spent a lot of time composing her message, and her thumb hovered over the "send" icon as she re-read the words. Would it be obvious to Joel that she was hiding something? She had seen the suspicion in his eyes when she told him she had gone out with Lena - and wouldn't she have felt the same way? She tried to imagine the situation in reverse: what would she have been thinking if Joel had gone out with Chance while she had a work-related dinner?

And then, if he had made himself a Fevr account?

"Shit," she said quietly.

It was probably better to *not* tell him about that. It had seemed like innocent fun last night, and under the influence of that much alcohol, it had felt like something she could explain. Now that she was finally sober, and could put herself in Joel's shoes, it seemed ludicrous.

In fact, everything she had done last night seemed a little ludicrous, and vaguely like cheating.

She sent the message, and waited. All the while, the thumbnail for Fevr seemed to glow on the third page of her apps, calling to her.

She wanted to be disinterested: she was *so* disinterested, she told herself, that she was going to act like she had forgotten all about it. Then, maybe, she could think of some funny way to bring it up, at a later time, almost like she had forgotten about it entirely and then found the thumbnail on her screen one day, sparking her memory.

She rehearsed what she would say in the car as she drove home, with still no answer from Joel, which made her stomach twist in anxiety. "*Oh. Oh, wow,*" she practiced saying, with an artificial tone of surprise. "I forgot that I *did* this. Honey, check this out."

No.

Joel wasn't going to think that was fun, and laugh when she deleted it and told him she had just been really drunk and forgotten about it. If she showed it to him, he would want to see her profile picture, and her About Me section, and neither one of those painted a picture of casual, silly Fevring. Her cheeks burned as she thought about having to explain it to Joel.

"It's not what it looks like," she said, to no one, in the car.

But wasn't it? Wasn't it *exactly* what it looked like? Wasn't it something she had done out of curiosity, maybe more genuine curiosity than idle or academic curiosity? Wasn't the curiosity that drove her to make her account, that was nagging at her right now to look at her account and explore the possibilities around her - wasn't that what it looked like?

It looked like she was bored with her marriage, like she wanted to flirt with a new man, like she wanted to dip her toes in something outside of her marriage.

That's what it looked like.

"That's not what it is," she argued with herself.

Suddenly impatient, she picked up her phone and practically yelled into it. "Call Joel."

The phone rang for so long that a frustrated anger was already building up inside of her, when, on the sixth ring, Joel's voice filled the interior of the car.

"Hey."

"Hey," she sang cheerfully. Joel's tone was dry and emotionless. Did he sound like he was angry? Disappointed? Or was he just feeling terrible.

"I'm on my way home... did you get my text?" she continued. A note of irritation was present in her voice, and she hoped he didn't hear it, and that if he did, he realized it wasn't directed at him. The irritation was with herself, with her confused feelings, with the guilt she was wrestling with.

"I, uh... oh, sorry." There was a pause, and Meri continued smiling idiotically at her windshield. "Yeah... takeout, sure."

"Which kind?"

"What?"

"Which kind of takeout? Chinese? Sushi?"

A pause that seemed far longer than normal preceded Joel's reply. "You choose, sweetie."

Was this a loaded comment?

Meri closed her eyes briefly. She was imagining things now, and it was all because she had been so stupid. She sighed.

"Okay. I'm getting whatever seems fastest," she said. "So probably Chinese."

Another too-long pause. "Yeah. Okay."

"You don't care what I get?"

Joel sighed. "Yeah, it's fine, whatever. I... listen, I have some work to do from home, I'll try to be done by the time you get here."

"Okay."

"Love you," Joel said quickly.

"Love you, too," Meri said, but she knew the line had been cut before it reached his ears.

*

She waited for the Chinese in the restaurant. They told her fifteen minutes, but the time dragged on as she sat, staring at her phone.

Now would be as good of a time as any to delete Fevr from her phone, and act like none of this ever happened.

On the other hand, Joel already seemed to know something was up. Was she going to be able to live with herself if she didn't tell him about it?

She brought up the page of icons where Fevr was displayed, and stared at it.

The image of the last man she had seen popped up in her mind, almost clear enough to fill her whole field of vision. The nervous, savory excitement she had felt the night before slithered through her again, and her heart sped up.

What was the difference, really, between what she was doing, and what she knew Joel did? She wasn't foolish enough to think he never watched porn, for example. She just preferred not to think about it, or find it. He had been out at a strip club last night, and while she liked to believe that he had eyes only for her, she wasn't naive enough to think that he never looked at any of the dancers. Or never got turned on.

So she wasn't really doing anything different, she reassured herself. Browsing some guys on Fevr with a fake-ish account was just for fun. She wasn't going to actually go out with any of them, just like Joel wasn't going to actually sleep with a stripper.

She satisfied herself with these explanations as she waited for the food, but she knew that they all had one big hole in them: Joel *told* her when he went to a strip club.

Which meant, if she were being really fair, she'd have to tell him about Fevr.

She sat back in the booth and stared at a faded Chinese calendar, thinking of ways to tell him that would be honest, but somehow make him understand that she wasn't doing it to *actually* cheat on him.

She swiped her screen aimlessly.

The other alternative, of course, was to just delete her account and act like none of this had ever happened.

"Order one fifty-one!" the cashier shouted to the empty dining area, setting Meri's order on the table.

Her stomach lurched as she collected the bags.

She'd be home in five minutes, and it was decision time. If she didn't tell Joel tonight, then she was being really dishonest, and that was something she could probably get away with, but she could already feel the guilt eating away at her.

Because she didn't really want to just delete her account.

Not yet.

Not really.

*

"So," Meri ventured, as she set out the four dishes she'd ordered. "How was dinner last night?"

Joel sat uneasily on a bar stool, eyeing the huge amount of food. China Garden had two serving sizes: huge and family, and Meri had ordered family-sized everything.

"Good. I think Riker's happy, so that's all that matters," he recited.

"You go to a strip club?" Meri asked, before taking a bite of chow mien.

Joel looked at her. It was unusual for Meri to ask about that. Or was it? He no longer knew what to think about his wife. The cold, delicious fingers of jealousy he had felt on and off all day clawed through him anew. "You know it," he said.

His voice was cool. Maybe he was imagining things, but there was a strange tension in the air.

And whose fault was that? Meri's. Duplicitous, Fevr-profile Meri, who was slutting it up on Fevr behind his back.

Meri swallowed her noodles. Was it his imagination or did she seem flustered?

"What made you call Lena last night?" he asked, trying to sound casual.

Meri swallowed again. "Huh? Oh, you know, just... you were out, and I had her number. You remember, she gave it to you, to give to me? So I thought, you know, I would call... well, I mean, I texted. I didn't really think she'd want to go out, to tell you the truth. I was sort of just trying to make it look like I'd given her a call, and then we wouldn't be able to ever meet up, and the whole thing would sort of fizzle. You know how I don't like to be confrontational or like, rude with people? I don't know. I feel obligated."

Meri was babbling, which is what she did if she felt bad about something. Over-explaining.

And maybe she was just lying.

"What did you guys do?"

Meri paused, a forkful of food in mid-air. "Huh? I told you, met for a drink."

"Where?"

Meri put the food in her mouth and chewed thoughtfully. She was standing, eating straight from the plastic containers. "This place called The Foundry," she said, after swallowing. "It's..." she waved her hand dismissively. "It was Lena's idea."

"Mmm," Joel said. "That a bar? Or a club?"

Meri shrugged, not meeting his eyes. She seemed extremely focused on her Chinese food. "It's sort of both. But we just sat in the bar section."

Joel stared at her until she met his eyes.

"Why'd you have so many drinks?"

Meri set the fork down and sucked up some noodles. She was suddenly defensive, and she showed it by jutting her chin forward a little. "I don't know, Tee-totaling Sam. Why did you?"

"Must have been a lot of guys fluttering around the two of you," Joel pressed, ignoring Meri's comment.

"Almost as many as the girls fluttering around you. Ours were dressed, though," Meri shot back.

Joel narrowed his eyes. "You mad about something?"

"Are *you*?" Meri said, dishing some food onto a plate she hadn't used yet.

Joel didn't know what to say. Part of him wanted to confront Meri about Fevr and wring all the details of her "date" with Lena from her, up to the most sordid, which a good part of him hoped was there. Part of him even hoped that Meri hadn't gone out with Lena, but with some date from Fevr instead.

"I just think it's weird that you went out with Lena, is all," he said. "I mean, you barely know her."

Meri shrugged, looking at her food, and said nothing.

They ate in silence for a while.

"I mean, that's how you get to know people," Meri said out of nowhere.

Joel struggled momentarily to figure out what she was talking about. He stabbed at his food. Meri watched him for a moment, her jaw moving slightly from side to side. "You have a problem with me going out with Lena?" she said, unexpectedly hostile.

He set his fork down. Tension boiled in the air. "Not at all," he said, his voice quivering with emotions that stemmed from two places: he was angry, and he was turned on by the very thing that was making him angry. "I'm just asking what you did. Is all."

"I had too much to drink," Meri snapped. "Like *you* can really talk."

"Sure, but Lena's a little bit... you know."

"What?"

Joel shrugged. "I don't know. Libertine. Sexual."

Meri was frowning. "So?"

"So..." Joel shrugged. "I wanted to know what you guys did."

"What did you do?" Meri shot at him.

"Meri, what the hell?" Joel said. "You knew I was going out with Trey Riker, you knew he always drags me to a strip club. That's the name of the game."

"So it's fine if you ogle girls all night, and I just have to be cool about that, but if I go out with Lena, I get the third degree?"

Meri was working up a full head of steam. She put her hands on her hips.

Joel's self-control exploded, with a little pop. He could actually feel the change in his body and inside his head, like a bubble of something had burst, and jealousy and testosterone were inside of it, leaking through him like ice-cold fuel.

"I'm actually not giving you the third-degree about Lena, darling," he said icily.

"Seems like you are."

"I'm more interested in Jay."

A soundtrack for this conversation would have had a scratching record at that point, as clichéd as it would have been. Meri looked as if an invisible brick wall had suddenly smashed her in the face, just for a second: her blink was almost like a glitch, a little too sticky, and her head shook slightly, like she wanted to clear the event from her consciousness.

"Jay?" she said, her voice wobbling.

Joel stabbed at his plate. He wasn't sure of what he was doing. A big part of him wished he could take back what he had just said and go back to his original plan of just watching Meri and what she did from here on out.

But that part wasn't speaking for him. "Jay. Black guy, tight abs. You know. Jay."

Meri's complexion faded to a frightening white, and her mouth, half-open, appeared to freeze in position.

Joel stirred his food, looking at her.

He wondered, in the silence that ensued, if his wife would lie to him some more. The air between them seemed to be made of a thick gas, almost warped in the heat between them that could have been anger, or arousal, or some bizarre cross between the two. *He* was aroused: his cock was throbbing in his pants. Here was his wife, caught doing the very thing he had fantasized about her doing as both a nightmare and erotic material. Would she betray him further?

"What...?" Meri breathed. She shook her head. "What are you talking about? How did you...?"

She reached for her phone.

"There was a message from him," Joel said, enjoying her discomfort more than he thought he would. It was a permutation of his fantasy that had a nightmarish quality to it, an idea that he had never entertained: what if

Meri was the one to take control, to seek other men, and he didn't have any control over what she did? That wasn't how he envisioned it, and it wasn't, he realized, what he wanted.

Meri shook her head and swiped her fingers over her phone. "No, no that isn't possible," she said, tapping and reading. "What?" she whispered to her phone, fingers hovering over the screen.

She looked up at Joel. "I was going to tell you about this," she said.

"Were you," Joel commented.

"It isn't what it looks like," Meri said. "Lena told me that if I set things up right, I wouldn't even have a visible profile... I just... this was all just for fun, and because I was so drunk... I was going to... *shit*."

Tears welled up in her eyes and she stared at the phone. "This was so stupid," she said. "I really, I know what you're thinking, but it was just.... I don't know. For fun." Her eyes went wide and she set the phone down suddenly like it was a hot coal. "This is..." she said.

Joel let his eyes drift to the screen, where Jay's message filled a dialogue box. Meri's eyes guiltily followed. She let out an extended sigh. "I don't even know what happened," she said, her voice shaking.

Joel looked at his wife. She was hugging her own arms, and met his gaze with wet eyes. "I really just... I don't know. I was drunk, and Lena was talking about how she..." her voice trailed off, and she gave a shrug of exasperation. "I was never going to *do* anything."

Joel felt like he was getting torn apart by the conflicting feelings in his gut and groin. His hard-on was unmistakable, almost painful against his pants, but his chest felt like an elephant was sitting on it. "Is this what you're into?" he said shakily.

"Joel, no," Meri said. "Nothing like... that. I'm not even... into it at all."

Joel laughed derisively. "You're not into 'it,' but you have a Fevr account?"

Meri picked her phone up. "No. It's not... that's not why I did it. I don't even know how this guy sent me a message."

Joel pressed his lips together.

"Look," Meri said, and another enormous, shaky sigh left her mouth. She seemed to deflate a little. "I was just curious. You know? I went out with Lena, and she has this Fevr account, and she was telling me all about it, and then... we came back together in a cab, and she told me that..." Meri rubbed her face with one hand and looked at the ceiling. "That... some

people just use Fevr for fun. Like, couples. I don't know. I was really trashed and I just got on to see what it was like. It was a bad decision." She held the phone up and started to swipe at the screen. "I'll delete it. I was going to do that anyway -"

Joel stood up from the bar stool and reached across the counter to put his hand on the phone. Meri looked at him, surprised, and let him pull it from her fingers. Her expression was hard to read; she was surprised, but Joel thought maybe he saw a little glimmer in her eyes.

Was it possible that Meri - his sweet, sexually conservative Meri, the Meri who promised him that she was totally satisfied in her sex life - shared even a sliver of his own fantasy?

He set the phone down, and Meri watched his every movement, still confused, if the furrow in her brow was any guide. "Joel," she began.

"Meri," he said quietly, but he didn't know how to go forward from there.

There was an awkward silence. "So, tell me what Lena said," he ventured quietly.

Meri stared at him, her mouth open. "Uh," she said after a pause. "What?"

"You said Lena said some couples use Fevr for fun."

Meri was looking at him with uncertainty. His chest was tight, his erection rock-solid, and the blood was pounding in his ears. Never in his wildest dreams had he imagined he would be having a conversation like this one with Meri, and so he didn't know how to direct it. In many ways, he felt like his world was crashing down on him. But he also felt like he had stumbled onto a treasure, and that he needed to extract it carefully, watching for a booby trap.

"How?" he continued.

Meri looked stunned, but he could see a flicker of relief, and a vein of curiosity crawling through her expression.

"I want to know," he told her.

"Why?" she said in a whisper.

He shrugged, moving around the counter towards her, sliding the phone with him. "Curiosity," he said, approaching her, sliding Chinese takeout away so that the phone, and the Fevr screen, and all of the delicious possibilities that it contained, was between them. Meri's eyes darted down and then back up to Joel.

Meri gave a nervous laugh.

"I really want to know," Joel said. "Sincerely."

Meri picked up the phone, and he noticed that her hand was shaking slightly. Blood had returned to her face, and her cheeks were alive with a fresh flush. He was so turned on he felt like he was going to explode. But something was unfolding in Meri, and he was going to wait and watch it bloom, whatever it was.

"So," she said, with a shaky whisper. "She said that, uh, some couples have a profile, and just sort of... browse, I guess. Together."

Joel reached toward Meri and drew his finger from just below her ear to the collar of her blouse, pleased that the reaction it brought out in her was visceral: her flesh prickled with goosebumps and she inhaled sharply, parting her lips to catch her breath. "So you made your own account," he said, his fingers tugging at the top button of her blouse. His wife, *his wife*, was on Fevr, with her sexy picture and her to-the-point About Me. His cock throbbed. "That's sort of different than what Lena was talking about."

Meri stared at his fingers, which were undoing, with an agility that surprised even him, the buttons of her blouse, one by one. The cream-colored fabric fell open, revealing the lace edge of her bra, the full satin cups filled with her flesh, her rapidly rising and falling chest. Her hand drifted back to the table, setting the phone down with a clatter. "I didn't think you'd be into it," she said.

Joel moved to stand behind her, sliding the blouse from her shoulders with his hands. He drew the back of his fingers up along her arm, and pushed her hair from her neck to inhale the scent of her as he brushed his lips over her skin. He was sure that he felt a pleasurable shudder travel through her body. "No?" he asked. His left hand traveled down her arm, to her fingers, which were resting on the screen of the phone, as though she didn't want to let it go. "And what if I am?"

His cock throbbed violently as he whispered these words against her neck, and he knew that she could feel him against her ass, that there was no mistaking his level of arousal. He brought her hand up, turning her palm over to carry the phone with it, looking down at her screen over her shoulder. Meri was stiff against his body, shocked into silence, but he could feel that her skin was hot and she was as aroused as he was. He dropped his right hand to her skirt, and started to pull it up, while Meri breathed heavily

and stared at the phone cradled in their hands. "What if I told you that I actually think it's *really* hot?" he breathed into her neck.

His fingers moved along her inner thigh, traveling up, into the humid center of her legs, where he could feel before even reaching the soft fabric of her panties that she was wet. He hooked a finger under the material, and dipped blindly into the center of her. His cock throbbed again when he found that the sticky juices of her pussy were overflowing.

The sensation was almost orgasmic in and of itself, and his heart soared: Meri was aroused, just as much as he was, and she was looking at her phone with him, at the chiseled abs of a black man.

"You aren't serious," Meri said, but she didn't sound very convinced of it.

"Maybe I am," Joel said. "Maybe Lena is right. Maybe we can have some fun." His exploring fingers found her clit, and brushed over the swollen face of it, making Meri tremble and let out a little gasp.

"Would you like to have sex with a guy like that?" he breathed.

"Joel... no..."

"No?" he slipped his fingers into her pussy, and stroked the silky insides of her core, while she squirmed in his embrace.

Meri gasped and her hand dropped to the counter, taking the phone with her. It clattered on the marble, spun around, and Chinese takeout went sliding in all directions as Joel pushed her forward to get deeper inside of her and move his ring finger to her clit. "Something tells me you aren't telling me the whole truth, Meri."

"Joel..." she said, but her helplessness cracked her voice, and Joel felt a wave of arousal roll over him, even more intensely, as her body responded more than her mouth, and a thick gush of pussy juices squeezed from inside of her.

"You're very wet, Meri. I think maybe you're turned on thinking about fucking a guy like this. A guy with a huge, black cock -"

"Joel -"

"It's okay," he whispered. "Maybe I'm turned on by it, too."

Meri tried to turn her head to look at him, her mouth open as she gasped again as he pinched her clit from the inside out and started to direct his hands into a move that he knew, from men's magazines and the internet, was called the butterfly, but which he had never had the occasion to try. His thumb grazed her anus, sliding over the tiny eyelet in the slick wetness that

was gushing from her pussy. The position was awkward, killing his hand, but Meri was melting into a fleshy, liquid pool beneath his fingers, and he didn't care. His thumb stroked the rubbery eyelet of her ass, a place he only went in the drunkest of moments and only years ago, when things had been... well, newer. He hesitated, but Meri pushed against him, and it was almost as much from her movement that his thumb sank into her ass.

She gasped: for a moment, he thought everything would come apart and she would wiggle away. But then she remained there for him as he finger-fucked her, moaning in pleasure, but willing.

He made her come like that, and she fell forward on the counter as her pussy gushed around him. "Oh my..." she breathed, still recovering.

He spun her around and looked at her. His hands were gently pushing her shoulders down, but she was falling easily to her knees. Her hands unbuckled him, took his cock out, and brought it to her mouth. She teased him for a moment, rubbing his cock over her lower lip.

He seized her hair, pushed her forward. "Show me how you'd suck Jay's cock," he murmured. He wasn't sure if she heard him: he sucked his breath in loudly as she took him inside her mouth, all the way in to that hot, wet, orifice, his crown grazing the back of her throat.

He let her suck on him, but he was almost ready to come, and he wanted to *fuck* her. As good as her mouth felt, as much as he wanted to fill it with cum, he wanted to be deep inside her pussy and fuck his cum deep inside of her. The little slut.

He pushed her away, and then fell on top of her: how they got onto the floor and out of their underwear was a tangled mystery of jerky, adolescent fumbling and tearing at clothing. He thrust inside of her three times before arching his back and yelling at the ceiling.

He shuddered the last squirts into her, as she crimped her hand in his hair, her mouth open in disbelief. He rolled over to the side, collapsing on his back. He stared at the ceiling, almost unable to believe what had just taken place.

Meri put a hand up to her forehead. She was still slightly out of breath, which made Joel feel better.

Then she laughed, one of her escaping, cartoonish laughs, and she dropped her hand to her mouth. "Well," she said. "That was *not* how I was expecting that conversation to go."

Joel propped himself up on his arm and stroked Meri's body, from her thighs, which made her squeeze herself with a shudder, over the bunched-up skirt, to her bare stomach and the rumpled frame of her blouse and stretched bra.

Meri looked at him, and then dropped her hand to his wrist to stop him. "Joel," she said. "I swear, I was just playing around."

He brought her hand to his lips and kissed it. "Okay," he said. The words were right on the tip of his tongue: he was going to come out and say it, but now that the moment was perfect he felt like he was teetering on the edge of a cliff.

"What?" Meri said, looking concerned. "Okay, what?"

He rolled toward her and shifted so that he was on his stomach. "Meri," he said. Then he ruffled his hair. In the corner of his eye, he could see that Meri was giving him a concerned look. "Okay," he said, puffing out the last of the air in his lungs, taking a deep breath. "I'm just going to say this, and then... it can be whatever it is. I'm sort of... not playing around."

Meri didn't say anything. Joel continued to look at the floor, which was now getting very uncomfortable.

He rolled onto his back. "I've had this... I don't know. Fantasy, I guess. For a long time."

Meri looked at the ceiling, her eyes screwed up in thought. "That I would get a Fevr account?" she asked, bewildered.

"Well, not so much that, but just... I don't know. This fantasy. That you would... you know... Have sex with someone else."

Meri jerked her head toward him. She looked like she was about to scold him, or become offended, for just one delicious moment, and Joel was sure his "fantasy" was about to derail as he had always suspected it would.

But Meri said nothing, and her face softened, and she rolled her head to face the ceiling again. "That's... like. Wow."

"Wow-good, or wow-bad?"

"Wow, I don't know what to say," she said, sitting up, shrugging her blouse over her shoulders. She looked down to button it, but paused and then pushed her hair from her face as she turned toward Joel, who was still on his back. "You mean, you actually *like* the thought of that? Like, me doing what Lena does?"

Joel reached for her arm and stroked it through her blouse, propping himself up on his elbow. He shrugged. "Something like that," he said

quietly. He looked at her. "I never told you because I thought there was no way you'd ever... you know."

"I wouldn't," Meri said quickly. Then she turned to face the opposite wall. "You would want me to actually *do it*?"

A hint of offense was cracking through her voice. Joel sat up abruptly. "Look. No. Yes, but no. I mean, what I want is for you to do what you want to do." He sighed. "It's hard to explain."

"*Why* would you want me to sleep with another guy?"

Joel looked at her. "I don't know. Why would you want to get on Fevr?"

"That's so... I don't know. Weird."

She said "weird" without much conviction.

"You seem to be kind of into it," Joel suggested. "So... I don't know, I thought I'd just tell you, I'm kind of into it, too."

Meri blinked. Then she shook her head. "This is crazy," she said, and then she laughed another one of her out-of-control laughs and hopped to her feet, looking around for her underwear.

Joel folded his knees up to the crooks of his elbows and looked up at her. "Maybe it isn't," he said.

Meri paused, and then started buttoning her blouse. She gave him a strange smile, decided better of it midway through, broke the smile, and then started it again. "What are you saying?" she said, but she was already shaking her head. "Oh my God, this sounds like couples therapy gone really wrong."

Joel slid a hand along the back of her thigh. "It's not really that crazy," he said. "Lena and Chance do it."

"Yeah but they're... I mean, Lena's..." Meri sputtered.

"What if we just gave it a try? For fun. You're into it..." Joel said, sliding his fingers up the length of her leg. "I'm into it... let's just do what Lena said. You know? For fun. Browse."

Meri, he could see, wanted to say yes more than anything, but the slightly prudish side of her was having a fit. The battle raged on her face, which went through several off expressions before she laughed nervously again.

"Nooooo," she croaked, in a deliciously young vocal-fry.

Joel stood up.

Her phone was still on the counter, and he picked it up, sliding his fingers quickly over the screen to unlock it. The message screen was still up. He swiped it away. "Jay is a little too... porny," he said. He looked at Meri, who was staring at him in disbelief. "Where are all your other matches?"

Meri snatched the phone from him, smiling. "I don't even know how to use this thing," she said. "It's on, like, some kind of super-secret setting where my profile isn't visible to anyone but the guys I swipe right, or whatever. I don't... even know."

Joel moved behind her again and leaned his chin on her shoulder. "So what, you have to browse some guys, and then they can see you?"

"I guess," Meri said, incredulously.

"Let's try it," Joel said cheerfully, slipping the phone from her hand. He started to walk toward the bedroom.

Meri was dumbfounded, her hand still perched in midair as though the phone were still in it.

Joel took a gamble, and spun around, heading down the hallway. "Let's see... oh, here we go..."

"Joel," Meri said from the kitchen.

"Joel!" she called, when he didn't answer.

She came charging down the hall, and Joel was afraid for a moment he'd overshot, but a giggle escaped Meri's throat and she flailed her hands at the phone with no intention of taking it away. "You can't be serious."

"I'm not. Are you?"

Meri stopped in the doorway of the bedroom, and Joel turned to watch her. She was flushed, smiling nervously, looking like a flower about to bloom, still folded in tightly upon itself, but ready.

"Come on," he said. "It's just for fun."

Meri looked uncertain. "Joel," she said, her voice breathy in a way he had never heard before. She came toward the bed. Joel arranged himself against the headboard. Meri climbed onto the bed, sitting on her knees. "I don't think... I mean, you aren't serious. Are you?"

He shrugged, trying to stay calm. "Let's just do it for fun," he said, unable to keep his voice from shaking with excitement. "See where it takes us."

Meri bit her lower lip and crawled toward him. She pushed her loose hair from her face. "Just for fun," she repeated, her thoughts obviously

serious.

Joel trailed a finger along her body. Her skin was hot, damp with a faint sheen of sweat that had boiled up from inside of her. His cock was aching, but he didn't dare let himself get diverted from this tantalizing possibility to have sex, no matter how much he wanted to sink his cock back into his delectable wife. "Come on," he whispered, smiling invitingly. "Let's just see."

Meri planted herself next to him, and her desire to try something new was obvious to see. "Okay," she said, sending a rush of blood to his cock.

They looked at each other and laughed.

"So... here are the eligible men nearby," Joel said, having already delved into the unfamiliar app. "How about this guy?"

Meri leaned her head on his shoulder and looked at the picture on her phone. "Hmm," she said. The guy was in his thirties, white, and in pretty good shape if you went by the picture. Joel was fascinated as he watched Meri's eyes traveling over the screen, reading his profile, narrowing as she took in his physical appearance. What would she be attracted to? Men like him, or guys that were totally different?

"Not really my type," Meri said at last, reaching up to swipe left.

A new picture appeared. Meri looked at it, then at Joel, as though for approval. His cock pulsed, painfully and sweetly hard. It was obvious that something about this guy attracted Meri, but she didn't want to say so outright.

"I think you like him," Joel said, in a low voice.

Meri hesitated. "This is crazy," she commented.

Joel swiped right. Meri gasped, and looked at him before a smile erupted on her face. "Joel!" she said.

But another man's photo was already waiting for them. "What about this guy?" Joel asked. "Late twenties, into... hmm, tacos. You think there's some kind of hidden message there?"

"Oh my God," Meri said. "That just seems so... I don't know. Scandalous. No." She swiped left.

"What about this guy?"

Meri scanned the page. "I mean, he seems like he's into a legit relationship. I'd feel kind of bad, I don't know, messing with him."

"How does this work, anyway? They don't see you unless you swipe right on them?"

"I guess so. Lena told me to do it."

Joel pondered that for a moment. "Did you do that because you didn't want someone to accidentally find you on Fevr?"

It was so deliciously duplicitous.

Meri covered her face. "I don't know... look, I was drunk, okay? I just... wanted to check it out. I guess."

"But now that you've already been discovered..." Joel suggested.

Meri swiped left on the screen. "What are you saying?"

They stared at the next profile pic. He stroked her arm. "I don't know. It just seems like... since I already know about it, and it will take a long time to go through all these profiles, and then... you know, who knows? You say you're married right here... so how many of those guys will be into that?"

Meri held her fingers over the screen. "I have no idea," she said, giggling. "Just really... this is so crazy."

"What if you changed the settings?" he said. "I mean, you used a sort of fake name," Meri had called herself Mary Arthur, a not-very-sexy name that, combined with her sexy photo and "just browsing" blurb in her profile, combined - at least for Joel - into a wildly sexy confluence of vaguely Catholic, guilt-driven modesty and repressed sexuality that turned *him* on, and which he couldn't imagine not turning on any guy who was prowling around for... well, a specific kind of fling. "It's not like anyone is going to recognize you."

Meri looked at him with a similar look to the one she had given for the first guy she approved. "I don't know," she said timidly.

He could see that she wanted to do it. He lifted her chin and kissed her. "Let's just try it. I don't think this will be as much fun unless more guys can see you."

They kissed again. This time, Joel was on the verge of being overwhelmed by his desires; his hand traveled down her body, and even though he didn't want to interrupt the thought process that seemed to be driving her to take a chance on this, his ultimate fantasy... his body was not cooperating.

It was Meri who broke away, sitting up suddenly and taking the phone from his hands. "Okay, fine," she said. She looked back at him, and her eyes wandered down the length of his body, noticing, surely, that his cock was distorting the shape of his boxers. "If you really want to do this," she added.

He could tell that she was impressed by his erection, a second one, a complete rarity in their sex life at this point in their marriage. He couldn't, in fact, remember a time when they'd had sex twice in the same day. Let alone the same night, not for years.

He smiled.

Meri turned away from him, a deliciously mischievous smile on her lips, and began to swipe at her phone.

"Okay," she said. "There. It's done."

She set the phone down next to her. There was an eerie quiet. "What should we do now?" she whispered, as though they were hiding from someone.

Joel reached toward her, and tugged at her loosely adorned blouse. "I can think of a few things," he said.

But to his surprise, his wife was already climbing onto his lap, shedding the blouse she'd put on to stay warm. Her hand slipped into his boxers. "I guess we just wait," she purred, closing her hand around his cock. And then, her eyes on his disbelieving ones, she started to edge backwards, taking his boxers with her.

His cock sprang into the air, fully erect, and Meri smiled. Her mouth was close to his dick, her lips and her breath close enough to almost feel, teasing. "Would you really want me to do this to another man?" she asked.

Joel sucked in his breath. He had no words to give her as an answer: the cold, jealousy-fueled grip of his desire froze the words in his mouth. Meri seemed to be under a spell he didn't want to break, and he could hardly believe this was actually happening, let alone that Meri seemed to really be getting into it. It was unsettling, and delicious.

His cock answered for him, throbbing, bouncing in the air so that it grazed Meri's lips and she smiled, catching it in her hand at the base. A pearly drop of precum oozed from his slit, and Meri took her time bringing her mouth and tongue toward it, burning through him with her eyes. "You'd really want me to do this?" she said.

But she knew the answer: she could feel it pulsing in her hands. When her tongue touched the crown of his cock, he had to close his eyes to keep from bursting. He opened them quickly, to get rid of the image that sprang into his mind, of Meri holding a cock in her hand just like she was now, but looking not at him, rather, into the eyes of another man.

Meri took him into her mouth, the heat of her tongue wet and hungry as she sucked his precum from the tip and then licked around the crown, trailing her tongue along the ridge of his dick. Joel's abdomen was so tight it was giving him a mild cramp. Meri teased, looking at him, her pink tongue swirling around on his head, her lips promising to swallow him whole but not complying.

And then, eyes on his for as long as she could, she took him deep into her mouth.

Joel exhaled, and his hand drifted up to her head, his fingers entangling in her soft hair. She sucked him from base to tip, working her hand along his shaft, driving him quickly to the point of no return.

He said something - a curse, a nonsense exclamation. Meri's hot mouth enclosed the length of his cock, and he felt the back of her throat graze the tip of his dick, a small convulsion as she gagged slightly and then took him deeper, her lips reaching the mat of public hair at the base of his cock, a trickle of spit gathering and then sliding down his balls.

He gripped her head and pulled her hair into a ball. "Holy *fuck*," he yelled. "Meri -"

But it was too late, and his cum was exploding into her mouth, and the words were already coming from inside of him, filthy, vulgar, the kind of things he never said to his wife:

"Drink up all that cum, show me how you'll suck on his cock."

And to his surprise, just as her phone vibrated again, that's exactly what Meri did.

She rose up on her knees after releasing him from her mouth, and looked at him. She was exhilarated: if his dirty-talk had offended her, it didn't show. Joel could barely hear his own thoughts. His cock, depleted of cum, was still throbbing, mostly hard. Meri pushed her hair from her face. "Wow," she said.

Then she glanced at her phone. "Oh wow," she exclaimed breathily. She leaned to the side to pick it up, but came back to rest on Joel's thighs. He stared at the panties covering her mound: they were white, a dark cream color showing that between her legs, she was overflowing. He could smell her juices now, feel the wet patch between her legs as she rested on his thighs. She tossed her hair over her shoulder, and dropped a hand to Joel's cock.

He was still speechless, as much about what was happening as about Meri's surprising enthusiasm for it. Unease shifted around in his chest somewhere, but Meri's wet panties and her hand, lazily stroking his cock back to life, put up a barricade to prevent his unease getting the better of him.

Meri looked down at him, the phone in her hand. "Ok, here's another one," she said. "I guess that profile pic is doing the trick... Adam Gonzales," she said, arching an eyebrow. "Thirty, not bad-looking, says he's into motorcycles and game for anything." She flipped the phone around. "What do you think?"

Joel managed only to nod his head, as if he were half in a coma. What was happening? Meri had so suddenly become unlike herself, she was making his head spin. He watched her shrug, and, with her fingers hilariously splayed, swipe to her right.

And then, sitting on top of him, Meri became absorbed in what she was doing. One hand stroked him lazily, the screen glowed on her face, and her lips parted as she swiped and swiped.

She looked down at him at last, breaking into one of her characteristic giggles. "I really don't know what I'm doing," she laughed.

Joel reached down to her and stroked her clit through her damp panties. "It's okay," he said. "It turns me on." He hooked a finger under her panties, and his fingers confirmed what he already knew: it turned her on, too.

Meri sucked in her breath as Joel started stroking her with his thumb.

"Oh!" Meri said. "I got a match." She flipped the phone around. "What do you think of this guy?"

Joel reached down and pulled her up by her thighs, forcing her to scoot toward his head. Meri looked past her screen at him, surely knowing what he was planning, slightly suspicious, but without resisting his urging. She scooted forward on her knees. She was close to his head, he used both hands to pull her panties apart. Meri gasped, and Joel wrapped his hands around her, palms on her small butt, pushing her mound toward his face. "Just keep doing your thing," he said.

Her feathery hair, which she kept neatly trimmed because she swam and used the hot tub all the time, brushed against his lips as he sought the soaked interior of her pussy and found her clit, darting in the liquid honey that was gushing from her.

Meri moaned, and said his name, and he pushed his face deep into her softest part, tasting the tangy, sweet scent of her cunt. She gushed onto his chin, and he pressed the blade of his tongue against her clit to make her squirm. Then he pushed her up by her hips so that he could tease her, licking quickly and gently at her throbbing clit, pushing against her weight as she tried to mash herself against his mouth.

She was looking at him, and he met her eyes. "Keep going," he said.

"I can't... concentrate," Meri breathed. But he urged her with his eyes, and she took the hint, dropping her eyes to her screen. He rewarded her by changing his tongue lapping to a steady pace, pulsing against her clit. Her muscles hardened and her abdomen rolled with uncontrolled pleasure.

Her hand started to fall. Joel signaled his displeasure by pushing her away from his mouth, and she moaned with disappointment. But she understood the game, and brought her phone back up to look at it.

Joel teased her, bringing her to a boil again and then easing off.

Meri mewled. "Please Joel," she said. "Don't stop."

He flicked at her clit with his tongue. "Tell me more about your matches."

Meri whimpered and smiled, and pushed against his arms, but she couldn't manage to get her clit into his mouth for more of his attention. "Okay," she said breathlessly. She held up the phone. "Oh," she said. "This guy... this guy is hot."

He rewarded her by sucking on her clit. "Oh," Meri moaned. Joel began to flick at her clit, teasing.

"Okay," Meri breathed. "His name is James. He sent me a message already."

"Read it to me," Joel breathed against her clit.

Meri tipped her head back and pulled on Joel's hair with her free hand. "Oh, Joel, just don't stop..."

But he paused, moving his tongue more slowly. He was ready to go again, but he wanted to tease Meri, make her come all over his face, and then fuck her while she swiped through her Fevr matches and he could look over her shoulder.

"He says," Meri conceded, breathlessly, and Joel sucked her clit back into his mouth, holding it in place with a delicate bite from his teeth so that he could stroke the face of it with his tongue. "He says... 'Hi. I take it from your profile you're looking for a bull, and you're in luck, because I'm the

best there is. I can do things you won't - oh my God, Joel..." Meri's voice was lost to a dull growl that came from deep inside of her, and her thighs squeezed against his face. In his mouth, her pussy exploded in hot, wet, stickiness, and her clit throbbed as her body spasmed. She yelled and gripped his hair so hard he was sure she ripped some of it from his scalp. Her body rocked over his face, smashing her pussy against his mouth, juices dripping down to his neck. "Oh my..." she panted, releasing his head from between his thighs. "Oh my God."

He tried to lap at her clit some more, but she scooted backward, her limbs jerking with the waves of her orgasm. She had dropped the phone from her hand, and now she was looking at him, her hands on his thighs behind her, pushing her chest forward. Sweat had gathered on her upper lip, and her hair was wet next to her skin, strands pasted to her cheek and her neck.

Joel moved in one swift motion - probably the most graceful display of athleticism he had made in years - and lifted Meri from his body to place her on her knees beside him, incorporating and practically hopping behind her. He pressed his hard cock into the crack of her ass, so she could feel him, while his hands traveled over the damp front of her body, fondling her nipples, sinking into the soaked, soft flesh between her legs. She shuddered.

"Pick up the phone," he breathed into her neck. "And write back to him."

He pushed her forward, and she looked back at him when she came to a rest on her forearms, her butt in the air, Joel already guiding his cock to her pussy. She gave him a look of disbelief, but to his relief it melted into a smile of mischief. "What do I say?" she asked.

Joel was sliding into her pussy. She was almost too wet: his own cum had filled her already, he could taste its bitterness as a note in the sweet juices of her pussy that had gushed onto his face. In his filthy imagination, which was taking no time to savor the current moment, but instead forging ahead to even dirtier, wilder scenarios, he envisioned sinking into Meri's pussy, feeling it hot and overflowing with cum, already stretched... but by someone else.

He thrust inside of her and reached down to push her hair from her neck, also to get a better view of her screen. He moved slowly, trying to make the moment last, but he knew it would all be over quickly because Meri was driving him so wild.

Meri couldn't type, she was getting worked up again and dropped the phone. "Oh, Joel," she breathed. "Oh my God... oh, this is so *wrong*."

When she said "wrong," her pussy clenched around his cock, revealing the desires she wasn't ready to articulate. Joel leaned forward and pushed her head to the pillow. "That's right," he said. "Such a bad little girl. Tell me what you're going to let James do to you."

Meri's lips parted.

"Are you going to let him fuck you, just like this?" Joel said, pushing himself deep into Meri's pussy. "I bet he has a huge cock. Is that what you want?"

Meri mewled and pushed against him, grinding him into her cunt.

"You do, don't you? You want to see what it's like to fuck a black guy with a huge cock, like a little slut." He leaned close to her ear, his fingers playing over her damp back, her pussy squirming around him, heating up again. "I'd like that too, Meri," he whispered. "I'd like to see what James can do to you. Show me how you're going to come for him."

He pulled her up to her hands and knees with him and raised himself up to kneeling. Meri started to fuck him as soon as she was on her hands and knees and he released her to do so, grunting and sweating, rutting with an urgency she almost never displayed.

Joel leaned back on his calves, pulling her back with him, so that she was sitting on his lap. His fingers slipped between her legs, right into her messy gash, slipping in the juices until his fingertips bumped against his own shaft. "Show me how you're going to ride his cock," he said.

Meri bounced on top of him, almost as if she had anticipated the command. Her pussy rubbed and sloshed against his fingers, her juices dripping over his balls, her body squeezing him, her skin slapping wetly against his thighs.

While Meri pleased herself, Joel pictured her bouncing on the lap of another man - a man just like James - screaming, as she was now, but with even more pleasure, as his cock dumped another load of his dark cum into her folds, and she shuddered with the delight that his cock had brought her.

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Meri was staring at the ceiling, slightly out of breath. "Say something," she said at last. She looked over at Joel.

He shook his head but smiled. He couldn't think of anything to say. Meri rolled onto her side. "Okay, so... this is a serious question..." she said.

Joel nodded.

"How much of this is just a game, and how much are you, like... actually into it?"

Joel let out a big sigh. "Okay," he said. "I'm going to tell you the truth, and I don't want you to freak out."

Meri was looking at him, and he was almost sure that there was a hopeful gleam in her eyes.

He brought her hand to his lips. "I love you, so I know it seems weird, but... this is sort of a fantasy I've had for a long time."

Meri's eyes went wide.

"I was always afraid to tell you about it, because I was afraid of your reaction."

Meri flopped back onto the bed. "It's just so... I don't know. It's wrong, right? There's no way this is something married people should be doing." She turned her head toward him. He kissed her hand again. "Right?" she asked.

Joel reached for her phone, which had disappeared under the covers. "I don't know," he said. "It seems like there's a whole dating world here that doesn't think it's so wrong."

Meri had almost countless matches and messages on Fevr now. Joel swept through them, reading them, looking at profiles.

Meri took the phone from his hands. "I just don't know," she said, but she got caught up in looking at the photos of the men who had swiped right for her, the tidbits of messages from them. The distraction led her away from finishing her sentence.

Catching herself, she turned abruptly to him. "I just don't see how you could be for real about this. Doesn't it, I don't know, hurt your feelings?"

"It does. In a good way, though."

Meri's eyes went wide. "I don't get it," she admitted. "I don't - so this would not be cool with me, if the tables were turned."

Joel shrugged. "That's fine. That's not what I'm into."

"But what...?" Meri said in exasperation.

"Look," Joel said, leaning over to kiss her. "I don't know how to explain it. I just... want you to have a good time. The *best* time."

"But you would actually want me to like, go out on a date with one of these guys, and have sex with him?" She studied her phone and laughed, bringing her hand to her mouth again. She was doing her wide-mouthed laugh of embarrassment. She shook her head on the pillow. "I don't think I could *do it*," she said. "Not really."

Joel, now that he had come three times and brought out the wildest side of his wife he had ever seen, now that he felt a little fucked-out and blood flow could at least partially return to his brain, was in possession of enough sense to know when he had a good thing and stop.

He slipped the phone away from her. "It was just for fun," he said. "And it was fun. So don't worry about it. I'm so... I don't know, this sounds cheesy, but proud of you, just for doing something a little different." He set the phone down. "Now, I am starving."

There would be plenty of time to bring out the dark side of Meri, later.

CHAPTER 8

Joel was a wreck when he returned to work the next day, from lack of sleep and the repercussions of a hangover he had induced by having a few drinks after Meri fell asleep. He had them in the futile attempt to stop his mind from humming. Meri occupied as much of his mind as she had when he had first fallen in love with her, and there was no room for turning it off, or sleeping, or thinking about anything else.

After she fell asleep, he lay in bed and stroked her arm, tried to wake her up by nuzzling her, had given up on a fourth bout of intercourse, and finally risen to head for the kitchen and a whiskey. He had ended up in the office with the bottle close at hand, scouring the internet for forums and advice about hotwifing, which existed in incredibly large amounts, but nothing satisfied him. There were no clear answers, there was no magic pill, and every suggestion came with pros and cons, consequences and rewards. He had fallen down a rabbit hole, and before he knew it, it was dawn, and he was bleary-eyed and probably still slightly drunk.

Work consumed most of his day: he had a lot to make up for from the day before that he had missed after the boozy client dinner. But Lena, in a magnificently sexy blue dress that somehow still managed to be office casual, was floating around in the office, a reminder of lustful desire, a beacon of sexuality and liberation. He wanted to talk to her, and yet it filled him with a strange kind of fear he had never felt before.

But finally, there was no hiding from Lena, who strolled into his office at five for signatures, lightly perfumed, her eyes gleaming as though she knew a secret, her smile beckoning him to say something.

"Just need you to sign these, captain, and I am out of here."

Joel swallowed a lump in his throat, acted like an idiot and knocked over a thankfully empty coffee cup, and signed the papers with a hand that was shaking, which he hoped Lena didn't notice. She smiled like some kind of Amazonian, middle-school hottie, and swept the papers from his desk. She turned to leave, and Joel's chest went cold and then hot, as he urged himself to say something.

"Hey, uh," he cleared his throat. "Lena."

Lena paused, her hand on his door as if she had been expecting him to speak, to say exactly that in that exact tone of voice, and exactly at that

moment. She was stepping backward and closing the door before he said anything else. Turning her head, cocked to one side, her infuriating and infatuating smile on her lips, which shone with a recently applied gloss that made her lips jarringly trashy, in contrast to her elegant dress.

"Can I, uh, ask you something?"

Lena closed the door completely and plopped into one of the chairs in front of his desk. She looked down at the seat. "Ooh," she said, or rather, growled in a feral, panther-like voice. "These chairs are really nice."

Joel stared at her for a moment, disconcerted. "Uh... yeah, they are really nice," he managed to say. Lena's smile was freaking him out. It was as if she already knew where this was going.

Either that, or like she already knew where *she* was going to take it.

"So," Joel said, because Lena simply looked at him, her secretary-waiting-for-orders expression on the upper half of her face, some kind of slutty-stripper-about-to-rip-you-off look from the nose down. "You, uh, went out with Meri the other night, I hear?"

Lena looked up at the ceiling, as though her social calendar required an astrological connection to decipher, and then sleepily lowered her gaze, and with it, the bedroomy gauze of her eyelids. "Oh," she said. "Sure did." And then her lips parted, and she ran her tongue under her top teeth - the sort of gesture Joel wondered if he was supposed to see. "Why?"

A nervous laugh escaped Joel, who folded his hands over his desk. "Okay, well... maybe this isn't the most appropriate conversation for work, actually," he said.

"Is it about hotwifing?" Lena said.

Her directness was so blunt he was sure he could hear the sound of a dodgeball hitting him in the face, and he felt like that, too.

"I'm not the type to #MeToo you, Joel. But I have to get going in about ten, so it's now or... whenever I have time. Can't say when that will be."

Joel expelled a puff of air. Lena leaned in confidentially. "Is it about Fevr?" she whispered.

Joel was flustered. Not by the question, or any aspect of the information being exchanged - rather by Lena, who was just... too much. Of everything. His eyes could not be redirected from her lips, and his brain could not be stopped from imagining them doing very filthy things, and his cock could not be stopped from superimposing the whole dirty, glittery montage over his thoughts about Meri.

"Did she make an account?" Lena said, leaning closer, smiling.

Joel rubbed his forehead.

"Good for her," Lena purred, leaning back. "Good for *you*."

She crossed her legs, Joel thought of Sharon Stone and looked at his hands.

"Or do I have that wrong, Joel?" Lena said. Her foot, clad in blue stiletto-heeled pumps, moved in a delicious circle, and Joel could feel the ghostly sensation of Meri's tongue swirling around the crown of his cock.

He cleared his throat. "Uh... yeah, no, so, no, you don't have it wrong... and she, uh, she did make one, and then I found it, and then we uh... you know, looked at it. Together."

Lena rested her elbow on her knee, and her chin on her hand, and raised her eyebrows in what could only be interpreted as a tell-me-more expression.

Joel looked back at his hands. "So... she was like, really into it. And then, after, you know... she was sort of... not."

Lena waited. Then she smiled. "So...?"

"Well, I don't know," Joel admitted. "It's just that since you and, uh, Chance, have this thing going on..."

Lena pointed at him. "You were wondering if I have any tips or tricks for you?"

"Kind of."

Joel forced himself to look at her, and when he did, her expression surprised him. She looked a lot like a woman who was about to redecorate a living room with an unlimited budget.

"She's *into* it," Lena said. "She totally is."

Joel sat back.

"Are you?" Lena asked.

The cold feeling in his stomach would not go away. It started radiating to his limbs. *Was* he into it? Actually into it?

Lena stood up abruptly. "Tell you what I think you should do," she said, re-ordering the papers on his desk, so they were all properly aligned. "You should just have her go out on a date, with you there, and plan not to go ahead with anything, you know... no matter what. And then, if you're both okay with it, move on to the next step."

Joel shook his head. "I don't think... she sort of nixed that idea. Kind of."

Lena folded her arms across her abdomen, which had the effect of emphasizing the bounty of her breasts. "Is she sort of prude? Or what?"

Joel scratched his head. "I don't wanna.... say anything about... that."

Lena's smile twitched. "Look. I've met a lot of people in my life, and I get a pretty good read on them. Your wife is *into* it, she just needs some way to ease herself in. Like dipping a toe in the pool."

Joel shook his head with a sense of resignation. This conversation wasn't producing anything helpful, though he wasn't really sure what he had expected.

"How did you get into it?" he heard himself say.

Good question, he told himself.

Lena shrugged. "I just jumped in. But that's how I do everything."

Joel sighed. Lena looked at his clock. "Oops," she said. "It's Friday. I am out of here."

"Thanks," Joel said.

Lena was leaving. Disappointment started to burrow around inside of him, along with a deep sense of dissatisfaction.

Lena stopped and turned around when she reached the door. "I have an idea, actually," she said.

Joel imagined himself looking a lot like a dog, the way he perked up.

Lena returned and sat at the chair again. The door was open, and even though no one was outside in the common work area, it irked him: there were a lot of consultants in offices on the border of that area, and they were almost surely still there.

"What if... you just happen to be someplace where I'm meeting a Fevr date? And Chance is there, too? I know if she saw it in real life, she'd get hooked."

Joel shot forward in his chair and started to hiss at Lena to be quiet, but changed his mind. After all, she'd already said it out loud. "How do you know that?" he whispered.

"That she'd be into it?" Lena's voice was loud. A throaty laugh left her, and Joel cringed, scrambling to think who might be overhearing their conversation. "Trust me, I know these things."

Joel shook his head. "I dunno," he said.

"What's your number?" Lena said, producing her own phone from an unknown hiding place in her very fitted dress. She looked over the screen at Joel when he said nothing, and her eyes were demanding and unrelenting.

He gave her his number.

"Okay," Lena said, slipping the phone into her lap. She leaned forward, and the phone mysteriously disappeared. "I will text you where we'll be tonight. I'm pretty sure it'll be The Foundry, because that's the sort of place my dates like to hover around. You just get her there, and then I'll take care of the rest."

Joel moved his head in lack of comprehension. "Whuh... what?"

Lena rolled her eyes and stood up. The phone had mysteriously disappeared. "Come. To. Foundry. Bring. Wife," she said, in a mocking tone. "And then, I guarantee you, the path will be paved for your wife trying the same thing."

"You sound pretty sure of yourself," Joel said, though he wasn't sure why.

Lena once again tapped the papers in her hand into a neat pile. "I *am* sure of myself," she quipped. "But I am also sure of your wife." Joel had his mouth open to say something, but Lena was the kind of woman who left the room after saying things like that, and never gave you a chance to ask a practical question about it.

Sure about what? he wanted to ask.

He sat in silence for a few moments, gave a scan of his remaining work, dialed a client, left a message, and was, by then, almost able to convince himself that he was going to go home and do no such thing.

He dialed another number. As his voice rattled off his standard message - because nobody answered the phone at 5:15 on a Friday - his fingers and some reptilian part of his mind swept his screen and located The Foundry's website.

Before he had hung up the phone, and almost as if another person had done it, he was typing a message to Meri.

The plan took form within seconds.

Hey. Get dressed up. I have a surprise.

CHAPTER 9

A jolt of excitement traveled through Meri when she read Joel's message, and on its heels came indecision, doubt, insecurity, guilt, and then more thrills, all mixed together.

Joel, as a matter of course, didn't do surprises.

He also never told her to get dressed up. Not bluntly, not pleadingly, not... ever.

Joel's idea of a Friday night was Chinese take-out or walking to the decent but boring bar down the street from them, which was usually uninhabited on Friday nights because they lived in the suburbs.

But why a surprise all of the sudden?

She hesitated before writing him back, running through several iterations of messages, some asking him what the surprise was, why the surprise was, if it was a special occasion, if she should be worried.

Which were all things she was thinking... but she settled, instead, on sending a simple message:

Hmmm. Okay.

And to her further surprise, the act of pressing the "send" button sent a little jolt of arousal through her. It went straight to her pussy, making her body throb and reminding her of the slight soreness between her legs from the night before.

Going out? After staying up practically all night? It was unheard of from Joel.

Even though she desperately wanted to know why, there was something exciting about the danger of it, the unexpectedness.

So she went home, and dove into her closet.

The dress was easy to decide on. She'd been thinking of dragging it out long before Joel had proposed this "surprise." It fit her much the way dresses fit Lena, and she'd purchased it on an impulse and never worn it in public. Joel probably had never seen it.

And in her dresser, she found some lingerie: black, trimmed with lace, that had come to rest at the back of the drawer, for the same reasons,

without ever being worn. She and Joel never had the kind of sex anymore where he would *see* that kind of underwear, or savor it.

She pulled it on, turning side to side in front of the mirror. The thong was snug between her cheeks and then spread out in an intricate, partially-see-through web that rode over the crests of her asscheeks. The front was transparent except for the lace. Which reminded her... she needed to trim her pubic hair.

She gave a final, satisfied glance at the way the black bra cupped her breasts. She posed sexily for the mirror, and a thrill traveled through her, but the silliness of it all made her laugh at herself before hurrying to the bathroom to take a shower.

But under the hot water, as she carefully shaved her pussy into a neat landing strip and felt the silkiness of her bare skin as the soap slid over her newly smoothed lips, she pictured herself in the lingerie, and her dress, and she imagined herself as the kind of woman that Lena was: unafraid to be looked at, unafraid to flirt, unafraid to let another man peel her panties away.

She dressed quickly after spending a little too much time in the shower.

It was all just fun, she thought, running a hand along her inner thigh until she reached the center of her lingerie, where she felt her smooth skin through the gossamer fabric. She pulled the skirt down to its longest length, about midway up her thigh.

She paused, staring at herself.

And then, she reached forward and selected a tube from her makeup basket.

When she stood back, her lips were bright and red, and the outfit had changed. Her hand was halfway to her face to wipe the color away: it gave her a slutty look that was out-of-place for her.

But she stopped, and bunched up the tissue to toss it in the wastepaper basket.

Then she gave a half turn and sauntered toward the door, deciding that she would let Joel decide if it was too racy.

Knowing, deep down inside, he would say nothing at all, and she would never ask.

She felt high.

*

"Okay," Meri said, trying to hide the tightness in her chest and the way it strangled her voice. Nervousness, and maybe some guilt - though for what? - were building up in her body, as they drove into the downtown core and directly to the area where The Foundry was located. She could feel her heart beating faster, and her mind began working overtime on her actions of two nights before: had she *done* something other than the things she had told Joel about?

She had liked being at The Foundry. She knew that, deep down in her heart. She had liked being there with the sexually liberated goddess that was Lena, she had liked men flirting with her, she had liked all of the prospects and attention around her. She hadn't, specifically, said anything about that to Joel.

And last night, when they had talked, she had said things that weren't entirely true. That she couldn't imagine sleeping with another guy. It was somewhat true: part of her really couldn't.

But the daydreaming part of her mind, the place she kept locked up, was shaking the bars excitedly.

Meri felt a little ill as they turned down 18th Street, where The Foundry was.

Had she told Joel the name of the bar? She couldn't remember.

And what was he doing, anyway, if he was going there?

Her heart was beating so quickly, so noticeably, that she had to busy her hands digging in her purse just to get rid of some of her nervous energy. Joel looked over at her. "Lose something?"

"I just... uh, yeah. It's here." She waved her phone. "Thought maybe I'd left it. New purse," she babbled.

Joel turned on the next street, before passing The Foundry, and Meri exhaled carefully to avoid making it audible. They drove for several blocks, and when she finally felt comfortable that they were not headed to The Foundry, she said, brightly:

"So... you gonna tell me where we're going?"

"Not yet."

Meri made a sound, and smiled. She liked the way the smile fit her face: mysterious, interested. Flirtatious, even. How long had it been since she had felt this way? Like there was something about what she was

thinking, or what she was doing, that Joel couldn't be sure about? Or that *he* was doing something she couldn't entirely predict? It gave her a thrilling feeling, one she had been missing for years now, but hadn't realized until now. Somehow, after so many years of marriage, the thrill of the unexpected had faded away, like a heavy object sinking into the mud, so slowly that she hadn't noticed it as it had gradually disappeared, and she had essentially forgotten it ever existed. But now she could feel it again, and the excitement it brought with it set off a physical, palpable chain reaction inside of her.

She shifted in her seat, feeling the silkiness of her new underwear, the crisp outlines of the elaborate lace at the hems, grazing her skin beneath her dress. She was feeling more aware of her body, of the way it appeared to Joel, of the way it would appear to other men. All of these feelings had been ignored or forgotten, and now they were at the forefront of her mind again, and she liked it.

Joel parked in an expensive public lot, making no attempt to search for less expensive parking or even commenting, as he usually did on the rare occasions they made it downtown, on the outrageous price. When she opened the door to get out, he was already coming around the car to take her hand, and they linked arms together, Joel leading the way to whatever the surprise was.

Meri was turned around: she knew The Foundry was somewhere nearby, and that the back entrance to it had let her out onto a street she hadn't recognized. The slight wrongness of what she had done with Lena burned in her mind, her proximity to the location of her "misdeeds" made her stomach twist, but rather than disliking the feeling, she found herself reveling in it a little. In some strange way, the danger that Joel was actually taking her out as some kind of "gotcha" moment gave sharper edges, brighter colors, an acidic bite to the evening that she hadn't realized was missing, but now that she tasted it, it improved everything. She felt alive as they walked down the street, neither of them saying much, exchanging glances with each other like two people out on a third date who didn't know if tonight would be "the night."

"Here we are," Joel said, stopping abruptly, so much so that Meri continued walking a few paces and he had to tug her back by her arm.

She snuggled back close to him, smelling the clean scent of something he was wearing: aftershave, cologne, his soap, she didn't know. It wasn't a

new scent, and the light stubble on his jaw was nothing new either, but she felt like she was *experiencing* them newly. She was aroused, she realized, and the new underwear were soaking up the quiet dripping of her excitement, becoming damp, the liquid feeling between her thighs always at the back of her mind.

She looked up and read the sign on the restaurant: La Griglia, a restaurant she had heard mentioned, but never thought of going to: expensive, authentic Italian, supposedly romantic. There was a slight dip in her chest, as she realized that the fantasy she had been playing, like a reel of film in her subconscious, was not going to happen. At the same time, she was relieved: she liked the threat of The Foundry and whatever would have happened there, but she was also afraid to confront it.

"Wow," she said, in her husky voice, and she was happy to hear it particularly gravelly and throaty. "This is a fancy place."

Joel kissed her on the mouth, a full-lipped kiss, warm and insistent. Next to her lips, his mouth moved as he breathed. "I thought we'd try something different. Romantic." He swept his fingers over her cheek and tucked her hair behind her ear, and the building excitement in her body reacted with a shower of goosebumps that spread down her neck and to her shoulder blades.

Then he stepped toward the podium, where a stuffy maitre d' was glaring at the general world with the affected airs that the hosts of all "fancy" restaurants seemed to purchase in bulk. He spoke quietly, and the man shifted his eyes to Meri before answering with tight lips.

They exchanged a few words, the man shook his head, and Joel spun on his heel to return to Meri. "Our reservation is lost," he said, "but he can get us in in about an hour."

Joel usually looked crushed, or disappointed with himself, when something like this happened. Not that it usually did. But when Meri looked at him, he looked unbothered by the sudden change in plans, and he shrugged, looking at Meri with a smile that seemed coy. "Want to go grab a drink while we wait?" he asked her. He looked at the maitre d'. "We'll be back in an hour, then."

But they were already moving back toward the door before the disinterested maitre d' gave them a disaffected nod, and Joel had placed Meri's arm back in his. He turned right immediately when they exited, seemingly with a plan already in mind.

"Sorry about that," he said, though something in his voice said he was less sorry than unsurprised and amused. "I think there are a couple of bars this way," he said, taking out his phone. He was already walking, and Meri was following, unsure of what the evening would bring next.

"So," Joel said, stopping at the corner. "There's the place you went to with Lena, I think. Was it The Foundry?" He was still looking at his phone. "Or... something else called Cafe Berlin a few blocks down..." He looked up from his phone and smiled at Meri. "I'm kind of curious about The Foundry," he told her. "And it's right here."

Meri shrugged, trying to be noncommittal. "Well, it is right here," she said.

She wasn't sure if she wanted to go, or not to go, but she also wasn't sure if she should erect any obstacles to going.

It didn't matter, because Joel was already holding the door open for her.

*

They found a small, intimate table, on the other side of the building from where Meri had spent her time with Lena. It was such a tiny table that there wasn't much of a way to sit at it without grazing knees, and Meri propped her head on her chin and crossed her legs, imitating the sexy way she'd seen Lena sit and move the last time she had been there.

Around her, she could see that a lot of male eyes were taking in her appearance, but because she was sitting with Joel, they were doing it less obviously than before. Still, she knew that she looked hotter than the last time she had been there, and she liked the feeling of knowing that men were looking at her, thinking about her, and that all that kept them from coming over was the presence of Joel.

"So," Joel said. "What's so good here that you got so wild with Lena?"

Meri laughed. "I just ordered a gin and tonic," she said. "Lena had about thirty martinis, so those are probably good, too."

It felt strange, and good, and... slightly illicit... to be talking to Joel so openly about something that had *kind of* been offside. Once again, she could feel the breath of danger in it, and it excited her.

"Gin and tonic it is," Joel said, looking around for a waiter. "I think you have to go to the bar," he commented within seconds. And then he

stood up. "Don't run off with anyone while I'm gone," he told her, with a wink.

Meri laughed, as if what he said was silly, and he leaned down to kiss her on the neck. "There are like ten guys checking you out right now," he breathed into her ear.

Another chill traveled down her neck. Why did that excite her so much?

She thought of her phone, tucked in her purse, of the promises of Fevr that were hiding in her bag, waiting to be unlocked. Of the messages she hadn't discarded or responded to, of the many men that had swiped right on her profile and were now waiting for her to contact them.

Almost as if on cue, her phone vibrated. Again. And again.

She took it out, hoping it was Fevr and assuaging her guilt by saying to herself that it *could be* Joel, calling about her drink choice.

A glance at the screen made her heart skip erratically.

Lena: *Yoo hoo I see you.*

Meri opened the message, as if some clarity would be added to it by reading the entire thing, which she could already see from the preview, was only the very short message she had received.

She looked around, furtively at first, then, when she didn't see Lena, with her neck strained and her head lifted. Lena, with her bright red hair, should have been easy to spot. But she didn't see her -

A heavy plop on her table made her swing her head around suddenly, and there was Lena, the door behind her still closing, vaguely indicating she had just walked through it and crossed the small room toward Meri in only the time it took her to turn around. She was clad in a red dress, a similar color to her hair that somehow managed not to clash, and it was tight and made of a fabric that shifted in the light, from transparent to opaque, flashing full glimpses of her skin and her underwear as she moved.

And her full, enormous breasts, bare against the fabric, her nipples peeking through the gauzy substance and then, as she moved again, tucking away behind the suddenly opaque curtain. Lena plopped into Joel's chair and put her hand on her shoulder, which was when the dumbfounded Meri realized that Chance was standing next to Lena.

"What are the chances," said Lena with a smile. Her voice sounded like the purr of a leopard.

"Oh," Meri said quickly. "Oh, yeah... it's, so it's pretty crazy. Joel is, um... getting me a drink." She pointed behind her. "We were going to that Italian place, and there was a... problem with the reservation..." Meri could see that Lena wasn't interested in her explanation for being there, and she was losing interest in it herself. "What are you...?"

"I'm meeting a date," Lena said, her lips full and wet, a smile perched on them like an inquisitive bird that was going nowhere. She moved her fingers over her phone, which had yet again materialized from nowhere, and flipped it toward Meri. "John," Lena said, her voice sultry.

The man on the screen was a well-muscled black man, and, shockingly, one of the matches that Meri had received. She was sure of it. She was even halfway sure that she had a message from him, one of many profiles that she'd enjoyed with Joel but ultimately never responded to. Her mouth fell open slightly. "Oh," she said stupidly.

Then she recovered and allowed herself a shy smile, a little flush of embarrassment creeping onto her cheeks as she glanced at Chance. "So you're... like, meeting him here."

Lena flipped the phone back toward herself, and Meri saw that Chance dropped his eyes to the screen. Meri's own eyes wandered quickly around the scene, and even though she moved like a swallow, it was impossible for her not to catch the outline of Chance's manhood in the crotch of his jeans.

"Mmmhmm," Lena murmured. "In fact," her eyes fluttered up from the screen and dreamily took in the bar around her. "I should probably get going." She stood up. "Nice seeing you," she said.

And they walked past Meri toward the bar.

Meri was dumbfounded, and afraid to turn around for reasons she really couldn't put her finger on. She grabbed her phone and sent a message to Joel.

*You will never guess who is here. If you see her, don't say anything.
She's ON A DATE*

She then opened Fevr, looking through her matches as discretely as she could, ready to minimize the screen as soon as Joel returned. She cast a few

uneasy glances over her shoulder, but was sucked into her search and forgot to look back again, so that when Joel's voice broke over her shoulder:

"One gin and tonic, for you..."

She minimized the screen so quickly and clumsily that she sent the phone into a spin on the table and had to slap it with her hand in an additional too-large, too-hurried gesture, to keep it from falling off and clattering to the floor. Joel raised his eyebrows.

"Did you see Lena?" she hissed, not bothering to explain her phone antics. She didn't wait for any answer. She leaned in close to Joel once he was seated, and said, in the lowest voice she could manage, which was still fairly loud: "She's here."

And then she mouthed, without vocalizing: "On a *date*."

Joel smiled. "I saw her," he said. "I can, actually, see her right now."

Meri's back was to the direction of Joel's glance when he said this. His eyes were back on Meri's now, and he had a grin on his face. "Is she here with...?"

"She's meeting some guy off of Fevr," Meri whispered.

She watched as Joel took a sip of his drink and looked beyond Meri's shoulder. "She's just sitting by herself right now."

"Huh? Chance was here, too," Meri said. She really, really wanted to look behind her, but she didn't want to seem too obvious.

Joel's eyes shifted around the bar, and then came back to Meri's. "He's off to your left," he said, holding his drink up to his mouth and speaking into the glass. "If you turn just a little, you could see him."

Meri put her left hand up to her temple defiantly. She was *not* going to do that.

Joel smiled at her, and she smiled back. Then they hovered over their drinks, looking at each other, but both of them knowing that their attention was on Lena, and Chance, and what would happen next.

"Tell me when he gets here," Meri said. Then she reached for Joel's wrist. "By the way, this guy she's meeting, she showed me his profile? I think that guy is one of my matches."

She shrugged, and raised her eyebrows, and smiled, shaking her head slightly at the same time. What she meant by that montage of gestures was anybody's guess, even her own.

"He's here," Joel said. He was studiously examining his drink and looking up furtively. Meri's heart was beating wildly.

"I wish I could see," she admitted.

"Come over here," Joel said, with a grin.

Meri was about to calculate how that could be done, without looking obvious, or like a panel of judges from American Idol, but Joel already had her wrist between his fingertips and was pulling her toward him. "Come sit on my lap," he was saying. "We'll just look like too much PDA."

"Joel -"

But Joel was pulling, and she was letting herself be pulled, and then she had to stand, and she had to give a half turn, and then she had to do something to make it look natural, so she collapsed on his lap and leaned down to kiss him on the mouth. Joel took advantage of the moment to rub his thumb over her dress and her left nipple beneath, a light touch that brought her nipple to life, tingling with the sensation of his touch long after his hand dropped to her knee and she pivoted, with her arms around his shoulders, to catch a glimpse of Lena.

They began, almost as effortlessly as if it had been choreographed and practiced hundreds of time, to make a big show of being a flirtatious couple that couldn't keep their hands off each other, a couple who were flirting outrageously, the kind of couple everyone must have expected to have just met each other, and not even had sex yet, getting ready for it, tonight. But they both had their attention - their real attention - diverted elsewhere, to the red bob of Lena's hair, and the ebony man who had seated himself at her table.

At first Lena and John were merely talking. He was a well-dressed black man with a well-trimmed beard, closely-cropped hair, and a long-limbed, svelte, but solid figure beneath his shiny, costly suit. Lena was leaning forward at the table, her fingers tracing the edge of a martini glass while her other hand supported her chin, her lips poised in the pouty sultriness she had perfected as an expression.

Meri glanced at Chance, who was seated about five tables away, his stool backed against the wall, his eyes unflinchingly taking in the entire scene.

Meri and Joel's pretend make-out session slowly evaporated, as they were drawn into watching Lena and John's conversation growing more intimate by the second. Lena extended her long fingers from her glass and touched John's hand, snaking her fingernail down the back of his hand and

to the tips of his fingers, while her sensual lips murmured something and she fluttered her eyes at him.

Even from where they were sitting, both Meri and Joel felt as though Lena's fingers had raked gently across their own bodies. A shudder traveled through Meri, and her mouth was getting dry as she watched John's hand slip to Lena's knee, caressing the inside of her thigh. His hand was large, and strength moved obviously beneath his dark skin like the muscles of a panther.

Meri's panties were getting wet, the tension in her body beginning to scream at high pitch she almost couldn't stand. She wanted to ask Joel what he thought Lena was going to do next, but her voice was caught in her pressure-filled chest and she could only watch, as John grinned, and Lena spoke, and their gestures became increasingly heated. John's hand moved further up Lena's leg, and Lena's was making lazy circles on his hand, their eyes locked.

Meri could feel the pulse of her husband's cock against her bottom, and his hands rolling over her thigh and inward, stroking the sensitive inside of her right thigh, close to the knee, but with intentions of going further. How did Lena feel right now, with that tower of muscle sitting in front of her, his hand on her thigh, his cock undoubtedly as hard as Joel's, ready for her if she wanted it to be? What did it feel like to know that your husband was so close, watching?

The idea of it turned her on, and beneath her skin her blood boiled.

The show went on, and it was hard to know how long Meri and Joel were there, breathlessly watching. It could have been half an hour, or only two minutes.

Meri leaned close to Joel's ear. "I really, really have to pee," she said, which made Joel smile, because she'd begun her approach in such a seductive way. It was so like Meri to have to pee at the most awkward times, and so like Meri to say it that way.

"You serious?" he asked her, his eyes still on Lena and John.

Meri made a complaining, whining sound and squirmed. "God," she said, laughing at herself. "I do. I really do."

She hopped off Joel's lap and pulled her skirt down, and gave him a backwards glance and a smile as she skittered through the packed bar toward the hallway leading to the bathrooms.

Joel remained fixated on Lena and her "date;" the way they touched, the obviousness of what was going to happen between them. Chance was visible in his peripheral vision and Joel wondered what it must be like to be him, to have a wife so willing to indulge in his fantasies. So willing to throw herself enthusiastically into them.

His own wife was not Lena, he reminded himself, unsure of why he was giving himself such a reminder. Was he disappointed that she was not? Was the burning jealousy he was feeling a jealousy of what Chance had, or did he feel within it a curl of fear?

Lena unexpectedly stood up and lazily picked up her drink. She sauntered, her hips suggestive, a smile on her lips, her eyes on her husband's, to Chance's table, where she set the drink down and said something to him as he ran his hand up her leg and under her dress.

Lena lingered there, and gave Joel a quick glance.

Was it over? Was she blowing off John?

He watched, and then stared, as Lena spun on her heel and walked toward the bathroom hallway. When she reached the steps, she gave a backwards glance at Chance, and then the spheres of her sculpted ass, the skin peeking through the shimmering material, rolled away, taking her long legs and red bob with them.

Joel's eyes drifted accidentally toward Chance, who was smiling at him, and lifted his glass in his direction with a wink.

John rose from his seat, a pleased expression on his face. He didn't look over at Chance, though it occurred to Joel that he must have, when Lena walked over there just moments before. For a dizzying second, Joel thought he might be leaving.

He walked, instead, toward the bathroom hallway.

And it was only after he had disappeared into it, while time was moving like a thick syrup, that Joel realized his phone had vibrated against his leg, and was doing it again.

*

The bathrooms at The Foundry were confoundingly, hipster-y unisex bathrooms, so Meri spent a few moments deliberating in front of three doors with inadequate signage, which seemed to be bathrooms... but were they? After seeing a guy leave a bathroom and a girl enter the same one and

then exit, giving her a strange look, she decided that maybe things had changed on at the bar scene far more than she ever could have imagined and now all the bathrooms were unisex. Which was weird, but didn't seem all that unlikely. Half the people in here were millennials with lumbersexual beards, she thought: it was fitting that the bathroom was just for everyone, right? Weird, but she was dying, and it wasn't as if she'd never used the guys' bathroom before to short-circuit the line.

Once inside, she was confronted with the befuddling spectacle of an old-timey single urinal and a single stall. There was a wooden bench at one side of the room, giving things the appearance of a waiting room.

What the hell did it all mean?

But, since she had to pee *really badly* by then, she headed toward the stall and locked herself in. She was mid-stream before it occurred to her that this was a single bathroom, and that she should have locked the outside door.

"Oh well," she whispered, laughing to herself a little, and hurrying to get back to the action. She was standing, arranging her skirt to leave, the door partly open, when she saw the main door swing open, filled suddenly with Lena's figure.

Lena's eyes were on her phone as she closed the door with her backside and lifted a hand behind her to lock it. Meri had only part of a second to think, and she wasn't a quick-thinker at the best of times. Her mouth fell open, and she was about to say something, but some other instinct inside of her took over, and lifted her leg, taking her one quiet step back into the stall. She waited, trying to complete a thought about what she was doing, but all of her brainpower was being taken up by what she thought Lena was doing. By the suggestive smile on Lena's lips, by the way she locked the door, the anticipation that was evident on her face.

She was frozen, deliberating about what to do, and couldn't think a single thought or take a single action. How long was she there? She had no idea. But a knock at the door startled her into action, and she peered out the stall door, planning to tell on herself and make her excuses.

Lena was facing the door, and John was coming in. There was no mistaking his black skin, his bulky shoulders, his towering height. His eyes were on Lena, and he was pushing her into the bathroom.

Another foreign instinct took over Meri. She couldn't even believe her own body was doing what it was doing as she reached for the stall door and

pulled it quietly shut behind her, stealthily locking it. She was holding her breath, she realized, and her skin was hot and damp with the excitement as she stood utterly still and tried to inhale without making any sound.

But Lena and John were so absorbed in what they were doing, she realized, that they never would have noticed her.

"That your man out there?" a male voice said, as their bodies moved dangerously deeper into the bathroom, to right about where the little bench was. Meri could see their shadows through the slats but no more, and she was too afraid to move.

The sounds of them kissing were the only the only answer given, and things started to get heated fast from there: moans, a mewl from Lena, and a growl from deep in John's chest. The furniture skidded against the tile floor.

Meri stuck a hand into her purse, suddenly terrified that her phone would ring. Trembling, she pulled it out and changed the settings, and then, holding it like an antique vase, typing slowly to make no sound, sweaty with the fear of being caught, she typed a message to Joel.

OMFG I am trapped in the bathroom with Lena and John.

She read her text, and the couple on the other side of the door made a deeply sexual sound together, and Meri was suddenly overcome by her usual embarrassing tendency to want to laugh hysterically. She covered her mouth with her hand and bit the meat of her palm.

*They are going to have sex. Right here.
There's no way out.*

She was typing to keep herself from freaking out, but finally decided just to let her phone drop into her purse, because her hands were trembling so much she was certain she was going to drop her phone.

"Wow," Lena's voice said, from the other side of the door.

Heart racing, pounding hard against her chest, the smile fading from her lips, Meri leaned forward, bending a little to get a view through the slatted wood.

"Mmmhmm," John said. "I told you."

Meri's eyes locked on the scene between the slats. It was incomplete, and she had to shift her head up and down to get a full picture, but there

was no denying what she saw.

Lena was seated on the bench, her legs askew almost as though the lower half of her body was posing for a fashion shoot. Her eyes were on what she was holding in her hand: a thick, long, black cock.

And then, as Meri stared, Lena opened her mouth and fed it to herself.

Meri's eyes went wide, and her body froze with fear. But even as the adrenaline that turned her cold with the fear of getting caught worked its way through her, she could feel her panties soaking through, her excitement building to an impossible ache.

She had never seen someone give someone else a blowjob - not this explicitly, clearly - in real life. And she had also never actually seen a black cock in her life either.

She couldn't tear her eyes away as Lena took him deep into her throat, and then began to suck him off. Meri could hear the faint gagging, sucking sound as he drove himself into the back of her throat, and far from shocking Meri, it turned her on. Her clit was throbbing, her juices making the inside of her thighs slippery now.

Lena released John's cock and guided it over her lips before pulling away. The fat bulb of his crown seemed to have doubled in size, and glistened with her spit. "I want to feel you inside of me," she purred, standing up, turning around, and putting a knee on the bench with the sort of practiced ease that indicated she'd done this before, in this very room.

"Holy shit," Meri mouthed, mostly for herself.

John pushed Lena's dress up and over her hips, made a noise of approval when he found that nothing stood between him and Lena's bare pussy, dripping wet and visibly engorged. Meri watched as his cock, which looked almost too big to fit inside of her, was slurped up by Lena's wet, quivering cunt with a sloppy wet smack.

"Oh, fuck," Lena said. "That feels so good, you're so big, oh, baby, you're gonna make me come, fuck me nice and hard," Lena murmured, placing her hands against the wall to steady herself.

"Whatever you say," John growled, and he slid his thick black fingers around Lena's stretched neck to hold her in place as he gave her a firm thrust that made her squeak.

They fucked like Meri had never imagined anyone fucking in real life; like porn stars, thighs smacking against Lena's ass as the long column of dark purple meat plunged into her again and again. Lena started to scream,

and John moved his hand to her mouth and muffled the sound of her ecstasy, just before he thrust violently into her three more times and groaned loudly.

They remained as they were, for a moment, panting. Meri couldn't tear her eyes away, watching Lena turn and give John a sexy, contented smile.

"That do it for you?" John said, his hips jerking one last time deep into Lena.

Lena bit her lip and gave her hair a quick toss. "That was so good," she purred. "That was just what I needed."

John stood back and upright. Meri watched in fascination as his cock, only slightly flaccid, slipped from Lena's pussy. She stared at it as he tucked it away and into his pants. Lena was already standing up, letting her dress slip down as she shook her body to get it to fall. She turned and gave him a kiss, then started to head toward the door.

Meri's heart stopped.

"You gonna clean up before you go back out there?"

Lena was by the door. She must have shaken her head; Meri couldn't see her. She only saw John's smile, as he gave a slow shake of his own head. "Dirty girl," he murmured.

The door unlocked with a click and the sounds of the bar filled the room and then faded. A new fear gripped Meri as she waited to see what John would do. It seemed like an eternity, but then she heard his footsteps on the tile, and the door opened again, and closed out the sound.

Meri let a nervous laugh escape her. She felt dizzy. Her hands trembled as she fumbled with the lock.

A guy pushed the door open just as she stepped out of the stall. He looked her up and down, inhaled through his nose, looked behind him, as if recounting the bodies that had recently exited, and raised his eyebrows.

Meri's face went red - or at least, it felt like it did - but she managed a sensual smile as she scurried past him, daring, though she could hardly believe it as she did it, to wink at him.

*

Meri practically stumbled out of the bathroom hallway, looking dazed. Joel met her eyes. His phone was in his hand, his mouth open, the words from her messages burnt into his vision like subtitles on a movie.

Meri's legs almost seemed to be limp and weak, the way they seemed after sex, and Joel had a terrible, terrible, wonderful thought, but it flitted through him and he discarded it as impossible.

She sat down unsteadily, a strange expression on her face, and put an elbow on the table. She met Joel's eyes, chewing on the tip of her pinky finger and staring at him. The look was so intense, the air between them simmered like a molten liquid. They said nothing as they stared at each other, waiting to see what would happen next, but it was as if they were sharing their thoughts. Or maybe they weren't thoughts as much as they were feelings.

"Where did they go?" Meri mouthed, after a while.

Joel made a gesture with his head, and Meri knew that something was happening behind her. She pushed her purse to the floor and bent down to pick it up, looking behind her as she did.

Meri turned to face Joel, raising her eyebrows.

"Smooth move," Joel commented, looking at the purse, and Meri smiled.

"Chance is getting up," Joel said, in a low voice.

Meri waited, and then turned around, just in time to see Chance disappearing into the hallway.

Meri turned back to Joel sharply, her mouth open wide. Then she covered it, doing her silent expression of shock, her eyes twinkling. "Where is Lena?"

"She went back there," Joel said, his voice shaking a little.

"And the guy?" Meri asked.

Joel shook his head. He was gone, just like that. Lena had ordered herself another drink and stared at her husband as she kissed John goodbye at the bar, and then, after a steamy exchange that Joel saw in the background of his wife's own inexplicable simmering, Lena had headed back to the bathroom hall.

Meri shook her head like she wanted to shake off water. "I am not doing *that*," she said.

For a moment, she didn't understand the sudden shift in Joel's eyes, a seriousness and a hunger that consumed all the lighthearted fun that had been glimmering there.

"You wouldn't do *that*," he said.

And there it was, lying on the table as if it had an actual physical presence: the subtext. She wouldn't do *that*, but in the weight she had added to "that" she had pulled back on the curtain of her thoughts: that there was something else that she *would* do.

And Joel very much liked the idea; she could see it in his eyes.

"What should we do?" Meri asked, in a low whisper. They were close to their new reservation at La Griglia, but also she wondered what they should *do*. She had a weird obsession with the evening, with whatever Chance and Lena were doing, and she didn't really feel like leaving. At the same time, she was so excited that she didn't feel like staying.

Joel looked like he felt the same, so he didn't answer her question, but instead they sat there, burning up, waiting.

Joel reached across the table and took her hand suddenly. He jerked his head toward the door, and she grinned. She knew, without him saying anything, that he wasn't taking her to dinner.

But she couldn't have expected what happened. They practically ran together, hand in hand, out of the bar, and Joel pulled her along, toward the parking lot and the car. By then, it was almost dark out: the sun had slipped below the horizon, and the inky blue of sunset was staining the sky from east to west.

She didn't ask where they were going, but she assumed he would take her to the car. Instead, he darted to the right unexpectedly; so much so that she kept trotting and shot past him. He had to tug on her arm to pull her into one of the wide alleys that ran between the clusters of buildings.

"What are you...?" she said, but didn't finish her sentence. When they passed a dumpster and were about halfway down the alley, blocked from view on either end by the dumpster and a parked (and thankfully, empty) white delivery van, Joel pushed her into the wall and kissed her fervently, both hands on the sides of her face.

The brick of the building scratched her back as Joel pushed her upward by her thighs, to leverage her weight against the wall and pull her legs around him. The ache between her legs was so strong that she abandoned all the thoughts she would have normally had: that this was a public alley, that there were doors to buildings up and down the length of it that someone could pop out of at any moment, that delivery vans almost never remained empty and parked for as long as it took to screw someone in an alleyway.

She didn't even know how he pulled away her panties, pushing them to one side, or how, in the passionate fumbling with clothing and skin, he got himself freed from his pants and inside of her. His cock glided into her incredibly slick pussy and she moaned, leaning forward to bite his shoulder through his shirt. He felt so good inside of her, and she was so aroused, that within only three hard thrusts, her back scraping against the wall, she felt herself tipping over the edge.

"Tell me what happened," he growled.

The images Meri had just seen swam in front of her eyes. "Lena... Lena sucked his cock," she said. "And. Then... oh, God." She was going to come, and she couldn't keep her thoughts straight to finish her sentence.

"Mer," he breathed, and leaned his head back to look at her. By then, she could feel her abdomen spasming, a husky squeal leaving her throat, and she was digging her fingernails into his back. "Oh God," she said, and then tipped her head back, almost too hard, as her body went stiff and convulsed with an orgasm that made her ears ring.

She could feel Joel thrusting inside of her, hear his grunts and then, vaguely, through the pulsing, liquid heat of her own pussy, feel the violent stiffening of his cock as he exploded inside of her.

He thrust three more times, his hands now on either side of her, her legs flapping like rags on either side of him. The shoe of her left foot dropped to the ground, and Joel leaned in to the left of her to press his forehead to the brick wall, panting. He dropped a hand to cup her buttocks, and his fingers worked their way into the soaked, sweaty, center of her legs, where juices and semen coated her pulsing, swollen flesh. She jerked when a finger, gripping her by the ass possessively, dipped into her asshole - she was so slippery that it slid in easily and made her gasp in pleasure.

She knew that Joel had meant to do this as just a final, physical display of possession: it wasn't their usual thing, but none of this was. Still, he liked to grab handfuls of her body after he came. What *was* unusual was that her body reacted the way that it did, and that when Joel felt her stiffen and squirm, he tipped his head back, gave her a burning look, and then began to push his finger deeper inside of her.

His cock had slipped out of her, partially flaccid, but she could feel him pulsing to life again, already. She was about to give him a smile, tell him that they should get out of public view, continue this at home, and the words were just starting to form shape in her mouth, when he began to fuck

her with his finger. He plunged deep inside of her and stroked the insides of her ass, and her mouth stopped in the shape of the first sound she had intended to make, the breath stolen from her lungs by a gasp.

Joel had dropped his other hand to her buttocks, and he was pushing against her to help hold her up against the wall. Both his hands were slipping in the wetness that had oozed from her pussy and down to the crack of her ass. He lifted her thighs further up, his finger still working inside of her, the damp, strained mess of her panties slipping into the folds of her pussy and cutting into her skin. The fabric got tighter and pressed on her clit, and she felt her ass squeeze Joel's finger.

"You like that?" he breathed, finger-fucking her and making her feet bounce like a rag doll's on either side of his body. "Would you let a guy like John fuck you in the ass?"

As he asked, he slipped another finger into her ass. She closed her eyes: there was a sharp pain as her eyelet stretched to accommodate him, but it was strangely pleasant, and the sharpness subsided almost immediately to a dull ache. She wanted him to push deeper inside of her; to her own astonishment she craved it.

And as she was thinking about the physical desire to feel his fingers deeper inside of her ass, the words he had breathed onto her lips worked their way into her mind. She imagined what it would be like to feel the ache that was now consuming her, but because of a man's cock. Another man's cock, while Joel, with his hungry eyes, watched her.

"You like that," Joel told her. "Don't you? Would you let another man put his big, thick cock in your ass for me? Let me watch him fuck you full of cum?"

She trembled before she shuddered, and her mouth fell open. She wasn't a dirty-talker, and she wanted to say something but couldn't think straight. The only thing she could think about was the man Lena had just fucked, about the cock he had, about it being where Joel's fingers were now, deeper, fuller, fucking her just like this while Joel watched them.

She mewled, and her ass contracted around his fingers. The tightness brought a measure of sweet pain to his fucking. Just then, she could feel his cock, hard as a rock again, moving as he gyrated his hips and sought the entrance of her pussy. She slipped a hand down to guide him in, and his fingers started to slip out of her ass.

"Don't," she breathed sharply, leaning toward his shoulder as her head swirled. "Keep fucking my ass."

This time they lasted longer. Meri forgot where she was. She could only feel the pressure of Joel's fingers stretching her ass out, his cock inside of her cunt, rubbing against the tender membrane between her holes, the fullness of being thoroughly fucked. And she imagined, instead of her husband, a dark and faceless man, fucking her until she turned into a puddle.

She came again, and she felt like her entire body turned to water and slipped out from inside of her. Her ass was throbbing around Joel's fingers, and her pussy moved in spasms that didn't match, as if she had been set to a rolling boil. She didn't even make a sound, because she knew if she did she would actually scream.

Joel took longer to come, and her pussy ached, and she squirmed from too much intense pleasure as he continued to fuck her until finally he groaned and emptied himself a second time into her sopping pussy.

They were both so sweaty their clothing was totally soaked. She dropped her legs, and pushed down her skirt, staring at Joel, who stared back. Neither one of them seemed able to believe what they had just done, and if Joel felt anything like she did, he felt like he was watching his own body from another planet. Her ears were ringing, she felt far drunker than she should have been from the single drink she'd had at The Foundry.

They seemed to become aware of it at the same time: the scent of cigarette smoke as it wafted toward them. But as soon as she recognized it, she realized it had been there for quite some time. When they turned, at the same time, to see that a man in the blue pants and white shirt of Every Delivery Man, was smoking a cigarette, squeezed in between the van and the wall, Meri was not even particularly surprised.

The man was smoking and looking up at the sky, pretending to pretend he hadn't noticed a thing. He had, of course: now that the passion of fucking had evaporated with an orgasm, the obviousness of what they had been doing was glaring at them.

Meri turned to face her husband. Oddly enough, she didn't feel the need to freak out about it. She looked down at the ground, her hands on his shoulder, and stepped into her fallen shoe. "I guess we better get out of here," she said calmly.

Joel glared in the direction of the man, but turned with Meri, and they scurried down the alley, not laughing until they turned the corner.

They didn't say anything as they walked back toward the car. They passed La Griglia on the other side of the street, looked over at it, then at each other, and without saying anything, came to what was probably the same conclusion: they looked like two people who had just fucked in an alley, and probably shouldn't go sit in a high-end restaurant at the moment.

They dropped into the car and Joel started it up, turning on the air conditioning. Meri let out a sigh, and then giggled.

Suddenly serious, she rolled her head to look at him. "What was *that*?"

"Hot," Joel said, without hesitation. He searched Meri's expression for the things he would have expected to find there: shame, embarrassment, guilt, and his heart soared with - oddly - conflicting feelings when he realized that none of those things appeared in her eyes or her face. She was smiling, a little impishly if he were to give a name to the way she was doing it.

And that was great, what he'd always fantasized about, something he had never dreamed would happen. Bashful, slightly conservative Meri, Meri who he had worried was bored with her sex life with him, but too straight-laced to ever do *anything* he fantasized about, had just let him finger-fuck her ass and blow two loads into her pussy in an alley, and didn't even care that a delivery truck driver had watched part or all of it.

And she had done all of this after watching Lena fuck a black man in the bathroom of a downtown club.

This was all good news for his sexual demons, who were rubbing their hands together in devilish delight.

But something inside of him was also shocked, destabilized, knocked off balance. He hadn't anticipated it because... well, he hadn't anticipated *any* of this. But now that Meri, his young, pretty, inexperienced, unadventurous wife was sitting in the seat of the car with cum running down her legs and her ass stretched out from his finger-fucking, dirty and beautiful and a little bit trampled, he was *thrilled* (his cock was even pulsing to life a little, again, as unbelievable as it seemed), but a part of him was also terrified.

Meri leaned her head back on the headrest. "I can't believe that *guy*," she said, though with considerably less disbelief than Joel would have expected.

She rolled her head toward him. "Well. What now?"

"I guess we missed our dinner reservation," he said. He gave Meri a smile, to reassure her, but she didn't seem to need it.

Which felt like a punch to the gut.

"That guy doesn't seem like he'd appreciate us going back there late. Looking like this."

"True enough," Joel said, his mind wandering somewhere else, somewhere uncomfortable.

"I'm pretty hungry, though," Meri said. She put her hand on his thigh, walked her fingers along his leg. "Want to take me to dinner somewhere else?" She then jerked abruptly toward the back of the car, straining to see what was in the back. Without telling him why, she shifted in her seat and climbed practically into the back. "I think I left... ha! I did."

She plopped back into the seat, pulling a small duffel bag with her. "I never took this out of here... jeez, how often do you clean your car out?" She was digging into the bag and pulled out a pair of jeans, holding them up for him to see and grinning. "How lucky is that?" she said.

Joel didn't know what to say. Was Meri seriously going to put on jeans and have him take her to dinner? Now? After what they'd just done? Like nothing happened?

She had started digging in the bag again. "No... underwear," she said. She zipped up the bag and tossed it in the back, then opened the door, and stepped out, then opened the back door, all in such quick succession that Joel could do nothing but stare at her, heart pounding.

She plopped into the back seat and shimmied out of her underwear. Joel looked back at her, dumbfounded. She discarded the underwear on the floor, used a hand towel from the duffel bag to wipe up the still-shining wetness between her legs, and then shimmied into the jeans.

Joel raised his eyebrows. "Commando?" he asked.

Meri shrugged. "I *guess*. It's pretty uncomfortable, but..." She was back digging through the bag again. "Hmm," she concluded, after rifling through the contents. "All I have is a white shirt."

She held it up.

Joel watched her, feeling his control over things slipping, not really sure why he felt that way, and not sure how he felt about it. "What are you doing?" he asked, as Meri pulled her black dress over her head.

In her bra, and designer jeans with towering heels on, with her ruffled hair and her disheveled look, the scent of sex pouring off her skin, she

looked as slutty as he had ever seen her look, and his cock got hard at the same time his chest went cold as ice. "Changing," she said. "So you can take me out to dinner."

She pulled the white shirt over her head and pulled it down to her waist, looking at her torso after it was on. The black and lace of her bra came through the thin white material of the shirt, a tight-fitting nylon shirt with spaghetti straps that she usually wore under something else. "Hmm," she said.

She leaned forward and did a contortionist's move to unhook her bra and pull it through the right sleeve of the white shirt.

She looked at Joel, who was still staring at her, as though she were someone else he didn't know.

"Is that okay?" she asked. She looked down at her torso.

The paleness of her skin, and the natural soft pink-caramel of her nipples and aureole, worked in her favor: the shirt was semi-transparent, but her breasts didn't glare through the fabric the way Lena's white skin had broadcast itself through the red dress. But the shape of Meri's breasts - the exact shape of them, the contours of her rounded nipples, the half-sphere cups that bounced very little when she walked, even without a bra, was visible right through the shirt.

"It's... a little..." Joel said. "I mean, it's hot," he added. He didn't really know what was going on any more, or whether he wanted his wife to walk around looking like that or not. Meri raised herself up and peered into the rearview mirror.

She cocked her head. "It's pretty risqué," she said, and Joel was relieved that he thought he heard a trace of doubt in her voice. On the heels of the relief came disappointment, but then both were quashed when Meri shrugged and scooted back toward the door. "It's better than the bra, I think. Anyway, I'll wear the shrug if we're in some weird lights."

She opened the door, got out of the car, and then leaned down to look at him, one hand on the door and the other on the frame. "Well?" she said. "You coming? I'm pretty sure I saw a restaurant or two back there."

Joel stared.

"I could eat a steak," Meri declared, before shutting the door.

CHAPTER 10

What happened next seemed to happen to someone else entirely.

Meri walked hand in hand with him to the doors of the restaurant, and then, uncharacteristically, walked in front of him, opened the door for herself, pushed it back so that he could follow her, and marched in first.

It was unsettling when she did that, though Joel couldn't exactly put his finger on why. It wasn't as if Meri had never, ever, walked through a door first in their marriage, so it wasn't *that*. It wasn't even so much that she flung it open carelessly and let him put a hand out to catch it as she walked in; he could recall with ease hundreds of times she had done that. So what was it?

It seeped up from the corners of his mind, like water leaking into a boat, through the cracks, until it was suddenly there and overwhelming, bitterly cold, somehow irreversible: it wasn't so much that she had done all of that, it was the *way* she had done it. Head high, hair sexily messy, see-through shirt taut over straight shoulders and thrust-forward breasts, as if she were looking for something.

And all of that "something" was looking back at her. Maybe this was the most unsettling thing: not so much Meri but the way men were drawn to the change in Meri. She had always been pretty, attractive, attention-grabbing. But men looked at Meri with a sideways glance, furtively, for seconds. Now men were looking at Meri the way they looked at Lena. Longer, more openly, as if they sensed a change in Meri and knew that they could look at her.

And his proximity to her, for some reason, seemed to mean nothing.

It was hot, but it was terrifying, and Joel could feel the scratchy rope of control slipping through his fingers even more readily.

Meri chose the restaurant: a Mexican place with famed margaritas that seemed to be made entirely of tequila. Meri made one of her hilarious faces when she tasted it, and then scooted over to his side of the table to read from his phone as he looked up the ingredients for her (the internet confirmed that, in fact, there wasn't much in those margaritas besides booze). Her hand was on his thigh, and he could smell the scent of sex lingering all around her. She had gathered her hair loosely at her neck, strands of it falling over her shoulders, and the blouse in the light of the

restaurant almost looked classy, even if her nipples were hard under the silky fabric and there was no way to avoid seeing that.

And plenty of men were doing nothing to avoid seeing that.

And Meri was doing nothing to avoid them seeing it either. Ordinarily, Joel would have thought she was clueless, but he could see that she definitely was not. Not now. It was like someone had flipped a switch in his wife - and he supposed that someone was him.

He watched her, telling himself he should be happy with this change in Meri. Meri who let him fuck her into a sopping mess in an alley, Meri who was playing along with some of his darkest fantasies, Meri who had tired his cock out but was still somehow inspiring him to an erection again. So what if it came at the cost of a slow-rolling nausea and the feeling that his chest was being crushed? It was, after all, what he had wanted... wasn't it?

Meri finished her margarita and ordered a second, flirtatiously, from the waiter, who was young and attractive, unable to look away from Meri's shirt, and intelligent enough to sense that he should at least try to do so. He glanced nervously at Joel, as if to check on the second drink.

But Joel was not going to tell *this* Meri what to do.

She consumed an entire basket of chips and guacamole before the second drink arrived, ordered fajitas, and started drinking again, while Joel looked on, marveled and perplexed.

Meri looked at him across the table. "Want to have some more fun?" she said, after they stared at each other in another simmering silence.

There were a lot of responses that occurred to Joel, but he didn't manage to say any of them before Meri was holding her phone up, swiping her fingers over the screen. He didn't quite believe she was up to what he thought she was up to, and he also didn't quite believe that the woman across from him was Meri. His stomach was cold again as Meri smiled, lifting her eyes from the screen to look at him.

He wasn't necessarily himself, either: he could have put a stop to it, if he had tried. He could have reached for her hand, pushed it down to the table, said to Meri in a quiet voice: "I think that's enough for tonight." He even envisioned himself doing just that, in a micro-daydream.

But he didn't. He just looked back at Meri, the way he had let her walk through the door with her saucy blouse and her tits drawing every man's eyes toward her.

Meri's lips moved against each other, the top to the left and the lower to the right, a gesture he had never seen her make, and his implicit approval, he could see, was absorbed. Meri swiped, and swiped, and then her eyes got big, and she turned the phone toward him. "How about this guy?"

He could have said something else, or done something else, but how was he to know how serious Meri was being? He smiled, and he knew that the smile might have been a little false beneath his face, but Meri wasn't looking at him for approval anymore, anyway. He swiped right with his own finger, and Meri's tongue danced on the bottoms of her top teeth as she grinned. She was squirming a little in her seat.

She closed her lips around the straw, and sucked up more of her pure tequila margarita. Joel pegged the first drink at four or five units of alcohol, which was a lot for Meri, and so he could have stopped her.

But he didn't.

"This guy sent me a message," she said, after a while. She got up and moved to his side of the table again, sitting close to him, her body touching him everywhere it would have been reasonable to touch him.

He looked down at the screen. His erection was robbing his head of mindpower; the world was coming at him like a slow-moving sludge. His stomach was so cold he was beginning not to feel it, and he didn't feel quite capable of speaking.

Meri's fingers swiped away at the screens, like she was some kind of old pro: also unsettling. Her breath was hot on his neck when she turned toward him, and somewhere on his face her fingers were dancing, feather-weighted, sending chills down his neck and making his cock swell against the hard seams of his pants. "Should I get in touch with him? He's right down the street."

Meri's voice sounded like her voice: mildly hoarse, nasal like she had a mild cold though she did not, throaty and sexy, a little bit like it could tip into uproarious laughter at any moment. And also it did not: it sounded like the voice of another woman, distilled only to sexiness, deadly serious and sensual.

Was it still just a game?

Did he want it to be just a game?

He stared at the screen, at the dark profile picture, and said nothing. It was the kind of moment where he needed more time, and he didn't have it:

he had to make a call, and he didn't know which one to make. His fantasy was licking at him, tantalizingly within his reach, and yet...

Meri's breath smelled like citrus and tequila as she put her mouth very near his. One of her hands was resting on his cock, the fingertips tapping lightly, as if sounding for an answer as she said: "Let's just try it." Her other hand took the phone from him, her fingers had found the answer. And then she had the phone in both hands, and she was typing a message.

Joel watched it materialize on the screen, one letter at a time:

Hi. I'm at El Catrin on 19th if you want to meet for a drink.

And then Meri was standing up, returning to her side of the table, her mouth closing on her straw, tequila rising to her mouth, slippery and sweet. She opened her eyes wide when she looked at him, as though she had done something hilariously clumsy and had no explanation for it, shoulders shrugging.

The phone was face down on the table between them. Meri's slender fingers played with the straw as she sat up straight, and she smiled at him. Beneath the table, her foot was playing with his leg. Another long, silent look simmered between them.

And then the phone vibrated against the table. Their eyes dropped to look at it. Meri waited, burning through Joel's body with her gaze, before lifting her hand and placing it on the phone without turning it over. Her chin was forward, her smile enticing, her eyes daring him: but it was clear that she had put the ball back in his court.

He could stop her, he knew. He could put his hand out and slip the phone away, turn it off, put the brakes on this ride, which was going faster than he had imagined it ever could. His heart was beating fast, and for a moment he felt sure that he was about to have a heart attack.

But then, some gland in his body must have squeezed out just the right amount of adrenaline, because the frame wobbled in his vision and became clear, just as he sat back against the booth. "You going to get that?" he heard himself say.

Meri picked the phone up and turned it toward her face. She smiled, she typed, she looked over the top of the phone at him and sent a dagger of heat through his chest. The phone went into her purse. She said nothing and placed her fingers on the straw to guide it back to her lips.

He became aware of his breathing, which was almost a pant, and his blood, filling his arteries until it muffled the sound coming through him from the background to a dull roar. Meri's eyes glittered. She sat back. Now the light had somehow changed, and he could see her breasts through her shirt again. "He'll be here in fifteen," she said, and for a second the veneer of her sexily confident new style cracked, and she looked lost.

But only for a second.

"Are we doing this?"

Maybe if she had said something else, maybe if there hadn't been a droplet of tequila glistening on her lower lip, maybe if her hair hadn't fallen forward to graze her cheek, or the scent of her pussy wasn't still lingering on his side of the table, maybe if his fingers hadn't smelled like her, maybe if any single component had changed, he might have backed out.

Instead, he twisted his own straw in his first margarita, nearly empty. The ice cracked, and his hand was steady. "It's your show," he told her.

Meri lifted the straw to her lips, one finger over the end of it, and sucked a mouthful of the drink into her mouth. She looked behind her, toward the bar tucked away in the back, as if there would be an answer there. Then she turned back to him. "How far do I go?"

The words of her question might have been reassuring, had they not been delivered in the tone that she painted them with. It wasn't a question for *him*, a question expecting an answer. It was a rhetorical, teasing question: *how far do you think I'll go?* A question for placing bets.

Joel exhaled with a shudder.

Meri was already standing, and then she lifted her drink, and Joel could hear the fajitas she'd ordered sizzling and coming their direction. But his wife was taking her purse, and her drink, and walking away to the bar in her tight jeans with no underwear on underneath them.

And suddenly, he was sitting there alone, steak fajitas sizzling away among plates and tortilla baskets.

*

The next sequence took place like a dream.

The man, whose name, Joel dredged from his hazy memory, was Andre, arrived when the fajitas were cool, and Meri had been sitting at the bar long enough to get another margarita - but thankfully (or not, he had no

way of knowing), she had only sipped at it. Meri's blouse was short, it left a crescent of her skin exposed between her jeans and the hem, and Joel knew her body well enough to know that if she had been wearing underwear, they would have been peeking out just at the edge of her jeans, two silky lace straps clinging to the soft curve of her hips, melding in the center, pointing to the valley between her asscheeks. But there were no panties, and so the crescent of skin lured with an undelivered promise, and the top slipped upward when she leaned forward but the jeans never slipped down. She was sitting with her legs crossed, her foot kissing the arched shape of her black high heels, her ankle exposed. The outfit looked as if she had planned it, and when he had that thought, it sank through him weighty and pleasurable, another swirling fantasy in his own mind. What if she *had* planned it all?

She let her hair down just before he arrived, and then swept it over one shoulder as he approached her. Joel was too far away to hear anything they were saying, but it was easy enough to imagine it. "Mary?" he was saying, his black paw resting on her almost bare shoulder. A large grin revealed the insanely white teeth behind his full, dark lips. Meri turned to him, a hand on her head, her elbow on the bar. She didn't touch him, but she didn't need to: her body was flirtatious enough, and his hand lingered on her skin for far longer than a casual touch to get someone's attention.

He was so tall that his legs reached the floor even after he sat on the barstool, so he put only one foot on the footrest. They were facing the bar now, talking, looking at the bottles behind them. Meri had her fingers near her lips, one hand playing with the straw.

That was all that happened for what seemed like an eternity. The waiter returned at some point, took in the scene, and perhaps Joel's maniacal look. He glanced at the bar, where he surely must have seen Meri and recognized her as the woman who had formerly been sitting at that table, so he said only: "I'll get you another drink?" but didn't wait for Joel's reply.

Andre's large hand was on the back of Meri's chair now, turning her towards him. Meri's mouth was open in one of her sensual smiles, wide and inviting. The black fingers, like onyx against her pale skin, moved from the chair back to her arm, down the length of her forearm to her hand, which he placed on the upturned palm of his free hand while his fingers did something to the top of Meri's hand.

Joel watched as his wife melted to it, whatever it was that he was doing or saying, and it was like someone had shoveled coal into the furnace of his jealousy and desire. For a second he couldn't - or didn't - breathe, and something happened between Andre and his wife. The black fingers were moving over the top of her hand, which rested on his black paw like a limp doll on a platter for him, but Meri's foot, the one crossed over her leg, twisted with pleasure or discomfort, or both, and her shoe dropped cleanly from it.

Unnoticed.

By either of them.

And then, Meri leaned forward and close to Andre, stranger from the internet, so close that her face almost touched his. He would be looking at her lips, Joel knew: her pretty little doll mouth that could suddenly become huge, wildly sexual, an advertisement inviting dirty thoughts about huge cocks filling it.

But Meri didn't smile: her lips moved, and Andre watched, and the animal inside of him flexed, his jaw shifting. Whatever she'd said, he leaned back, pressing his lips together, and looked at her almost in disbelief. Joel's body went from cold to sun-surface hot in flashes that were almost too much to bear, as the dark mouth on the dark man - exactly the kind of man he had always fantasized about shoving a huge cock into his wife's pussy - turned up in a serious, deadly hungry smile.

And then Andre leaned toward Meri, just as some mariachi music erupted loudly from a corner of the room where a stage lit up at the same time and drowned everything out. Everyone in the restaurant but Joel, Meri, and Andre turned toward the sound in some way: a dazzling band, replete with velvet hats and gold tassels and trumpets that cut off all conversation, was glittering in too-bright stage lights and preparing to descend into the restaurant.

Andre didn't look: he put a hand up to Meri's head, his black fingers in her hair, and pulled her toward him, turning his face slightly to say something into her ear as he held her head in his large hand.

But it wasn't so much that: his free hand was moving from her throat, between her breasts, down the silky white of her shirt, and down. The mariachi band passed in front of his view, and stopped, and Joel thought his head might explode. Instead, he simmered, staring at the

elaborate coat of the trumpeter in front of him, his heart banging against his chest, praying for him to move.

The precipice he was on was as high as it could be: the possibility that when the band moved, his wife would be gone, yawned in front of him like an abyss. Paralyzed, he stared, until the black velvet and gold tasseled cloud of noise drifted to his right.

Meri was still there, but she was standing. Her shoe was back on her foot, and Andre's hand was on her waist, dark fingers lazily stroking her skin. His thumb slipped lower with each stroke, dipping into her jeans, exploring further than was casual. Joel burned, and Meri slowly turned her head to look back at him, as if she had read his thoughts - or not even thoughts, because he had no more of those, so better stated, his feelings and mashup of filthy images - and looked him in the eye.

The woman who was looking at him had his wife's red-tinted hair, her lips, her eyes, and the shape of her body resembled Meri's to perfection, but the woman who met his eyes with a sultry, devastating gaze, who was letting Andre's fingers slip further and further below the waist of her jeans, was *not* his wife.

The band blared until the entire restaurant rattled. Cheers erupted drunkenly around him. Andre was using his free hand to put a credit card away. Meri had turned back toward him with a smile.

The band blocked the view again, this time closer to the bar, and all Joel got to see as he stared, still paralyzed, was Andre's hulking shoulders as they moved toward an exit he hadn't even realized was there, to the left of the bar.

The sound went away completely, replaced by the ringing of his own blood, pushing against the confines of his blood vessels until he was pressurized into deafness. Only his heart managed to transcend the eerie silence, thumping wildly, kicking at his chest.

Moments passed, the waiter appeared, Joel stared at the exit a moment longer and then lifted his eyes to him.

The waiter looked unsure whether to be confused, or sorry for Joel, or maybe even if it was warranted to jeer him. One thing was clear: the guy knew that the woman who had been shimmering in a see-through blouse at Joel's table had just walked out the door with a large black man whose hands were all over her.

"You want, uh... boxes?" the guy finally said.

"Yeah," Joel said, although as soon as the waiter left he would have been unable to tell anyone what his answer had been for a million dollars. He fished two hundred dollars out of his wallet because he only had hundreds and he felt like Meri's drinks alone were fifty bucks. He let the bills drop on the table, stared at the exit, and paused for a moment longer, not knowing what to do.

It was almost as if someone had slapped him when it hit him:

BAM. Your wife just gave you a look and left with her black Fevr date. Fucking follow her.

His thigh sideswiped a chair as he stumbled toward the exit, but the pain only peripherally reached him, and he said nothing to the seated occupant. He scrambled toward the door, throwing it open as if he expected them to be right there in front of him.

But the sidewalk was empty of people for the full block. He turned left and then right, and now he was panting.

A man could ask himself what to do, but he had spun off into a panic mode that was not allowing the question to even rise to the top of his consciousness. The only thing he could think of was the black fingers beneath the waist of Meri's jeans, the look on her face, over her shoulder.

Without a plan, lost, he looked left and right and left again. No one walking along the sidewalk in either direction was tall and black. "Meri, what the fuck?" he breathed. His hand was fumbling for his phone. He patted at himself and found nothing, and panic began to set in: yes, the phone was the right answer, the phone was the key to finding where Meri had gone, the phone was the key to recalling her, or escaping this nightmare, or drawing himself into the fantasy, whatever he decided to do, but the phone was...

Not in his pocket.

He slapped himself again and moved out of the way as a couple exited behind him. He looked around, frantic, and they gave him a strange look before turning to the right, huddling together, and laughing.

He threw open the door and had to worm his way back to the table where he had been sitting. The bar seemed to have doubled in capacity: it was louder and he had to push toward his booth.

His heart stopped for a moment: the booth was cleared.

"Hey!" a voice yelled in his ear. "You want your change?!"

It was the waiter, who had materialized somehow behind him. He was holding a trayful of food over his shoulder, and people pushed against him, but he was like a reed in the wind, and the tray and its contents sailed like a boat on the sea, never spilling.

"I need my phone!" Joel screamed.

The waiter shrugged and moved past him, toward the booth, but didn't stop there. A new couple was seating themselves at the table.

"You guys see a phone?" Joel asked, aware that he was frantic. Meri... where could Meri be now?

They ignored him.

"My phone!" he yelled loudly, and they looked up at him. "You see my phone down there?"

The man patted at his booth, and so did the woman, and their faces said they weren't finding anything, nor did they care. Joel dropped to a crouch and looked under the table. He heard the woman squeak something: she was wearing a dress, but he had zero interest in looking up it, he wanted to explain. He needed his phone so he could find his wife.

His fingers found it for him, black on the black floor. The screen was cracked: he scarcely noted it in his mind. He stood up and turned it on, right in front of the table, but the looks from the couple were so venomous that they burned him, and the man was saying something that he could only hear the tone of.

But he sounded angry.

Joel squirmed away.

Outside again, swiping at the phone, ready to call Meri -

There were two messages from her, from ten minutes ago.

What do I do

Do I go dancing or do I just hook up with him?

It was just a text message, so there was no tone to it, but Joel could hear it the same way Meri had asked: "How far do I go?"

It wasn't a real question, it was a tease. His stomach turned.

But where? Where *was* Meri?

He typed, his fingers shaking enough that he spelled something so unrelated to what he wanted that his phone had no suggestions in English

for him. Impatiently, heat building at the nape of neck, he typed again, more slowly:

Where are you?

And then, in the cooling evening and the dark, aware that he looked like a drunk bastard pervert, he waited for Meri's reply. In his head, over and over again, the images of Andre's fingers playing with the delicate skin on the back of her hand, working their way under the waist of her jeans, played in his head. Two forces, opposing and nauseating in their battle against each other, tugged him inside: one a sinking, cold weight, the other a flammable heat that lifted him up.

*

He made his way back to the car, because he had no idea where else to go. The streets were filling up with Friday-night clubbers and bar-hoppers, most of them much younger than him, better-dressed, and sexy. He was drunk, he felt disoriented. He turned the wrong way on 18th and walked for a block before he realized his mistake: the grid of the downtown core was at about a forty-five degree angle to the grid of the surrounding suburbs, forty-five degrees off of the cardinal directions. It was easy, on a southwest-running street, to believe you were going south and end up going west, or so Meri often claimed. But he was a lifelong resident and had never made the mistake before. When he finally re-oriented himself he felt like the entire world had spun out of control, including the globe.

He checked his phone frequently: to him it felt like every minute but it was likely more often than that. It looked up at him with the same blank, alert-free stare. No Meri. No anything.

When he found the car, he concluded he shouldn't drive, so he leaned against it for a while and stared at his phone, wondering if he should call Meri, or if he should leave things alone. He had, after all, set all of this in motion himself. The first half of it anyway.

Meri had gathered momentum, but he was the one who had taken off the brakes. His fingers hovered over the phone: calling her would seem clingy or controlling or schizophrenic, he feared. And there was a part of

him that didn't want to interrupt her. But this wasn't how he had envisioned things happening.

He dropped into the car and turned it on to get some cold air on his face.

Where was she now? What was she doing? A protective feeling had ignited in him: this Andre guy was the kind of guy he wanted to see his wife hook up with. But he was a stranger, an unknown. Meri was half his size, drunk, doing something totally unlike herself. What if she tried to back out, or he went too far? What kind of husband was he, letting his wife run off with a total stranger?

The minutes ticked by, agonizing him.

And then the phone rang.

"Meri," he blurted, seeing her name and feeling a tide of relief wash over him.

There was muffled music in the bathroom, a tinny echo to her voice. She seemed out of breath, and she was half-whispering, in the way that only Meri could yell and whisper at the same time. He didn't hear what she said, because a cackle in the background drowned her voice out.

"Where are you?" he shouted.

The din died down, a little. "I'm at this club," Meri said, breathlessly. "Where are *you*?"

"Why didn't you answer me?"

There was no answer, just a peal of laughter, the sound of bathroom door being banged upon: the sounds of a restroom in a much-too-young, much-too-hip club. "Why didn't you follow us?" she said. "I don't... really even know where I am. Hey!" she said, away from her phone. "What's the name of this place?"

The sound was muffled suddenly, and all Joel could hear was the chatter of women's voices and drunken laughter for a few moments. "It's called Pelucho or something."

"Peludo," somebody yelled.

"Joel," Meri said. "I don't really know what to do."

Joel was silent. He was so drawn into his imagination: the inside of the women's bathroom, lipstick smeared and music blaring, drunk women laughing and fixing their makeup, Meri standing in the middle of it all, that he felt like he was actually there. And outside the door he imagined, was Andre. Waiting to put his hands all over his wife...

"Are you there?" Meri demanded. "Joel?"

He snapped back into place. "Uh, yeah," he said quickly. "What do you mean, you don't know what to do?"

"I mean... I don't know what to do. This guy is... definitely into hooking up."

Joel said nothing for a moment. "Definitely into hooking up," he repeated.

"His hands are everywhere. I've already -"

A peal of laughter swallowed her words for a second, and so he only caught the breathy finish of her sentence: " - everywhere. He knows I don't have any underwear on."

Fuck. It was so hot. So incredibly hot. He could almost see the black hands snaking down the front of his wife's abdomen, working their way into the sloppy gash of her pussy.

But this wasn't what he had wanted: what he had wanted was to see it for himself. How could he say that, bring it back under control.

"Look," Meri said. "I've been in here... a long time. I need to know what to do."

"What do you want to do?" he found himself saying.

There was no answer for a moment.

Meri could have said hundreds of things, anything at all. *I don't know, I'm too drunk. Whatever you want me to do* - which even the thought of her saying made his cock pulse. *I'll do whatever I want* - also appealing.

"I can't believe I'm saying this," Meri said, after a lengthy pause. "I think... I think I want to try it."

Joel had begun speaking before she had even finished her sentence. "I want to watch," he said bluntly.

There was another, noise-filled pause, while the rowdy girls in the bathroom with Meri squealed through the phone, their voices ricocheting on the tiles.

"I want to watch," Joel repeated. He had found an authoritative tone to his voice. That was what he wanted, and now he couldn't back down from it. He didn't want to.

Meri didn't say anything immediately. Then she let out a bit of a huff, one that was impossible to read. "Oh you do," she said, in an equally unreadable tone. It was flirtatious, if he chose to read it that way, but

challenging if he chose to read it another way. "I don't really know how to make that happen, Joel."

Joel's head spun wildly, searching for an answer to a question like that, but he was in a void. Stupidly, he said: "I don't even know where you are."

As if that solved problems or had anything to do with anything.

"Where do I go?"

"Just tell him you're married, and you'll have sex with him, but only if your husband can watch," Joel said, regaining his confident tone.

"I don't... know..." Meri said. Her voice was wavering. Maybe she wanted a way out, maybe she was fishing for it. What didn't she know?

"Meri," Joel said, and in the moment he pronounced her name, he didn't know what he was going to say afterward. It came to him in a wave, a flood of things he'd read and fantasized about on hotwife forums, never believing he would be speaking these words to anyone, let alone his own wife. "You can do this. Just set the rules. Tell him, you're a hotwife. You'll have sex with him, but tell him you have to do it..." Joel fished around in his totally blank mind for a location, a place, a landmark... "at a hotel. I'll go get a room, and text you the place."

As soon as he said all of this, the sensation of freefalling consumed him. Meri - the Meri he had always kept as a prototype in his mind, Meri of the large, smiling mouth, the guffawing and the silliness, the slightly prude and too-young-for-him wife - would never go tell some black guy she barely knew that she would have sex with him if her husband could watch.

The ladies' room of the club clattered with laughter. Meri's laugh joined the tail-end of it. A laugh Joel had never heard before.

"Okay," Meri said. Her voice was much less hesitant than he would have imagined. "I guess I can try that."

If it's really what you want, Joel was waiting for her to say.

"Text me the place, I guess," Meri said. "And then... I guess I'll either see you there..."

Joel was falling, falling and falling wildly for what seemed like eternities.

"...or I won't."

And just like that, the bathroom clatter was gone, and his connection to Meri was severed. He was in a parking lot, in his car, and his wife was at a club, leaving the bathroom, finding a black man in a throng of hot, young, probably sweating people. And she was going to tell him...?

*

He was in the corridor to the bathrooms, hands in pockets, foot propped up against the wall. He was the first thing she saw, his eyes on her like an animal, dark and intent. A smile played beneath the serious curve of his lips, like he knew something she didn't. It sent a stab of unfamiliar desire through her, the kind of guilt-ridden, unnameable pleasure that bordered so closely on fear it was almost indistinguishable. If she hadn't been so drunk, she knew, she'd be shaking.

He pushed away from the wall and was next to her in a second. "I thought you'd tried to pull a runner on me," he said.

Meri's confidence, temporarily bruised, caught a second wind. She pushed a strand of hair out of her face and looked up at him. His fingers had already found their way to her body again, down the center of her chest, a thumb brushing over her nipple. He hooked his fingertips in her jeans and tugged, pulling her toward him. His fingers went into her pants: they'd already been there before, already discovered that she wasn't wearing any underwear, already he had smiled about that discovery, and he smiled again now.

She felt the button of her jeans pop open, and his hand dipped further into her pants, finding the wetness between her legs. His fingers were hot, big, insistent. They slid through the engorged lips of her pussy and right to their target, pressing on her clit. Her mouth fell open. She could feel his cock against her lower abdomen, pulsing.

"So," he said.

She was looking at his mouth. He'd kissed her already: though it was less like a kiss and more like a dirty mouth-fucking, and he'd promised he was just as good with his tongue in other places as he was with mouths.

"I have to," Meri said, and she closed her eyes because he stroked the face of her clit at that moment, and she lost her train of thought.

She opened them. "I have to tell you something," she said.

"I already know you're married," he said, his lips very close to hers. She couldn't even be sure that's what he said: it was loud, she more or less guessed at it. Most of what he was saying was going in one ear and out the other, while she let him explore further and further, under her shirt, into her pantiless jeans, inside of her.

That she was in a corridor, in public, didn't even occur to her.

"You're not a guy," he purred, biting gently into her lower lip and gushing his knuckle against her clit as his thumb slipped inside of her. "And you're definitely *into* guys. So what is it?"

Meri's head was swimming. This was it: she'd already crossed the line but not *exactly*. Andre seemed dangerous, a bit like he'd do whatever he wanted to do whether she okayed it or not, and this might be her last chance, in a public place, to put the brakes on him.

On herself.

What would she do if he said "no way," to her proposal? His fingers were thick, promising something more, and he was good at what he was doing. She *wanted* him to do it. She wanted it bad enough, she could feel, that she was afraid to say the next thing she was going to say, because if he didn't like it... well.

She didn't know what she would do.

One hand was at her throat, his thumb rubbing seductively against the shallow dip of her neck, closing firmly around her in a display of arousing, tender dominance. She could almost feel how sore she would be after letting him fuck her. She sensed the size of his cock against her body, could feel his weight on top of her, behind her, beneath her, almost as if she'd already done the things she wanted so badly to do.

"You want to tell me what, little girl? That you're a dirty little slut who already fucked somebody tonight?" He smiled. He already knew that.

Meri smiled, too. She didn't know why she liked that, why it turned her on, why it made her feel suddenly more powerful than just a moment before.

"Not that," she said, and now she was the one teasing him, running her tongue over his large, full upper lip. He had hours-old stubble on his jaw, and it grazed her skin whenever they kissed, and she actually could not wait to feel it on her inner thigh. She shuddered at just the thought of it.

She felt like she was acting, as if she were outside of her own body. It felt good, almost like it wasn't her. It made her wilder, more seductive, more confident than she felt. As if she did this all the time.

She put her lips close to his ear. "I want to fuck you," she said, and the words leaving her mouth were almost orgasmic. "But I have a few conditions."

CHAPTER 11

The room was preposterously small, too much like an average, regular hotel room for his liking. The door shut behind him, and he stared at the poorly lit space. The reality of what was happening washed over him: was this it? The place where his wife was going to enact his fantasies?

He fumbled for his phone. There was no message from Meri, no call from the world beyond his own mind to tell him, or reassure him, or somehow confirm that he wouldn't be waiting here forever. Because he really didn't have any guarantee from Meri - not a guarantee about coming here, or a guarantee about doing what he fantasized about, or a guarantee about what happened afterward, or during, or before. When he allowed himself to think about these facts, he was as dizzy as if he were actually clinging to the edge of a building and looking down, where there was no safety net.

He paced across the room and back.

How does a man wait for his wife to - maybe - come to a hotel with her stranger, a black lover, and have sex in front of him? In a chair? On the bed?

He snorted, a comical vision of himself entering his head, even though the tension that filled his mind: he pictured himself in a bathrobe, propped up on one elbow, with champagne...

No.

He shoved a chair to the corner of the room. He had asked for their best suite, and this was... well, *a suite*. Perhaps an extra six square feet had been added to the room, and the bathroom was considerably nicer, but the anteroom that made it qualify as a suite was useless.

Fucking Hilton. Maybe he should have gone somewhere else.

It was too late, he realized. He had sent his message half an hour ago. The room was already paid for. His wife hadn't answered him, but if he changed the room suddenly, what if she was already on her way here? Already in the lobby? If she got here and he wasn't here, then what? One of the least realistic things he could imagine was a man like Andre waiting patiently for Meri to contact her husband, and travel to another hotel.

No. They would just stay here, and go on without him.

He settled into the chair, but couldn't figure out how to sit, or where to put his hands.

He sat up and fixed himself a drink from the mini-bar, hurriedly, barely paying attention to what he was preparing, because he wanted to be seated when they came in -

He stood up, again abruptly, knocking over the drink, cursing. He crossed the room and opened the door, flipping the lock to the outside so that it closed almost all the way but caught on the metal security lock. Meri had the room number, but no key. He didn't want to open the door for the two of them.

He wanted it, almost, to be like he wasn't there.

When he turned around, he saw that the chair was unacceptable: too much light flooded the corner of the room where he had pushed it. He turned the light off, stood back, moved the chair again, and then adjusted the lighting of the room once more.

He made another drink, and then sat in the chair.

The room seemed suddenly so silent that it was loud. The minutes began to creep by. He flipped continually to his phone.

Forty minutes since his text to Meri.

He sipped his first drink as four more excruciating minutes went by. He made another, and then took a few of the bottles with him to the table so he wouldn't have to get up. Five more minutes went by. Outside, in the hallway, he heard a clicking door, the ding of an elevator, and his heart raced. He checked his phone again: he had given her the right room number, hadn't he?

Another ding, and footsteps, his blood pressure became so high he had to stand up and shake his arms out when they passed his door without knocking and he heard a woman's voice that was not his wife's.

Two more minutes.

Meri had abandoned the idea, he thought. That wouldn't be surprising. In a way, not even disappointing. Well, disappointing, but maybe not the worst thing.

In the silence of the room, his heart racing wildly, he began to think of terrible scenarios: what if Andre went too far? And what *was* too far? Too far for Meri, or too far for him?

She *would* come here, wouldn't she?

Or had Meri decided to go home with Andre, to his house? She was going to call him and tell him she was sorry while she rode his cock in the dark of his bachelor apartment somewhere. "Sorry," he could almost hear her saying. "*He didn't want to go to the hotel, so I'm at his place, riding his cock, and it feels so good.*"

This entire plan, he realized with a blunt jolt, rested on Meri telling Andre to come to a hotel and fuck her while her husband was watching. Which wasn't really Meri's style.

Of course, he never would have thought Meri would do any of the things she'd done this evening, or in the past few weeks. So did he really know what his wife's style was now?

He oscillated between elation and despair; hope and dismal pessimism, as he sat, and drank. At least his drinking was not making a dent on the erection he had sustained for nearly an hour. He felt as good - and as bad - as he had when he was a teenager.

And then, without him hearing anything preceding it, at last - what seemed like hours of torment later - there was a knock on the door.

*

Meri was drunk, that was for sure. She had a reddish tint to her lips, like she had applied some lipstick and it had been worn off unevenly. It was smeared and trashy-looking, and it didn't take long for Joel's mind to imagine all the filthy ways it could have been removed: in fact, his attention was drawn to it, fixated on it. Her hair was wild: loose, the band she had tied it up with nowhere to be seen, not even on her wrist like she often wore it when she let it down. It had turned wavy and messy, like she had gotten out of a shower, or a steamy bath, without washing it. Once, on their honeymoon, it had looked like that after sitting on the beach all day.

She had her shoes in one hand and she let them fall. Andre was behind her like a hulking shadow, but he was detained at the door, in the anteroom, pushing the metal catch back into place so that the door could close with the familiar hard click of a hotel room. The finality of the sound felt like a kick to Joel's chest and groin. It seemed, and it probably was, the point of no return. Whatever they had gotten themselves into, they were *in it*.

And he was not driving this car. Meri was, and Andre was. But not him, he was now just a passenger along for the ride.

Meri looked at Joel, a peculiar expression on her face: a mixture of accomplishment, insecurity, sexual prowess, horniness, sluttiness, guilt... a filthy and beautiful mix.

"Sorry that took so long," she said quietly, turning at the same time, so it was unclear who she was speaking to. "We got lost."

Andre was walking in, a man who did not seem in the least uncomfortable doing what he was doing, and this last comment from Meri made him smile. Joel's chest went cold again as Meri turned around, the remnants of a smile she had shared with Andre on her partially shellacked lips. Joel stared at the smudge of red above her upper lip, noticed the way her mascara had bled underneath her eyes.

Andre looked at Joel, briefly, almost in a nod of professional courtesy. His expression was partially disbelieving, partially haughty. Like this wasn't his first rodeo. For a moment, it felt like time had stopped, and Joel had disappeared behind a veil. They couldn't see him, they were just two people entering a hotel room, unsure of where to start.

But the scene accelerated suddenly, and Andre was behind Meri, slipping his hands around her narrow waist. At the same time she lifted her arms and put her hands behind his head, and her blouse lifted with the movement. The black hands traveled with the blouse, then further, beneath the material, to precisely where her breasts were. Meri tilted her head back, and made a pleased sound. The embrace seemed almost choreographed.

It hit Joel before the blouse traveled over Meri's head and went sailing behind them, before he saw the evidence of it with his own eyes: their movements were not the first clumsy fumbblings of brand-new lovers. There was a familiarity to what they were doing. Not much, but enough for him to know that Andre and Meri had done more than hold hands on their way here.

Meri's puffy, reddened nipples only confirmed it. Her skin was blotchy, red marks that resembled hickies dotted her chest.

When Andre lifted the blouse over her head, her hair went with it and then came tumbling down at her shoulders, only to be pushed away by Andre's huge paw as he tilted her head to the side and devoured her neck. Meri opened her eyes to look at Joel, who felt like he was being cooked from the inside out, and then she closed them with a gasp as Andre's hands traveled along her ribs, to her nipples, and squeezed the bite-sized nubs with the huge digits of his dark hands. He rolled them between his thumbs

and pointer fingers while Meri's mouth fell open, her eyes closed, her face contorted in a physical pleasure bordering on torment.

He gave her a light shove towards the bed, and Meri fell onto it, cat-like. She flipped onto her back, pushed herself up onto her wrists, and stretched her legs out, watching Andre. He was unbuttoning his shirt and began on his pants before peeling the shirt away. The opened shirt revealed a tight undershirt beneath it, hard muscle pressing against the fabric.

Meri twisted her feet underneath her, suddenly impatient. On her knees, she moved closer to him, and placed her hands on his abdomen, working her fingers underneath the shirt. The shape of her mouth morphed into a different kind of smile as her fingers explored the shape of his abdomen, then his chest, underneath the undershirt. Andre's slacks slipped down, and he gave his legs a loose shake to free them to fall to his ankles.

His cock, still contained by an expensive-looking pair of boxers, was hard and pointed in front of him, straining against the thin material. Meri's hands traveled down his torso to the waist of the boxers, where she hesitated for a moment, Joel sucked in his breath. Andre shrugged off his shirt and pulled the undershirt up and over his head by reaching behind him with one arm and grasping the back of it. His left hand dropped to Meri's jaw, and his thumb hooked in her mouth, gently pulling it open.

Meri's eyes fluttered up to meet Andre's, while Joel prayed for her to look a little more uncertain, or to glance his way for a final look of approval, but she met Andre's eyes instead and looked at him in submission as he stroked her lip with his thumb and tilted her head even more. "Take it out," he said, in a low voice.

Meri's eyes dropped as her hands pulled at the boxers. Andre's cock sprang from beneath the elastic waist and bounced heavily in front of him, erect but too heavy to point straight out. Meri's white hand closed around it, but not before Joel saw it clearly: purple, veined, pulsing with virility and desire like a distinct living creature. The crown glistened with precum. Meri's hand could barely close completely around it, and two dark, taut orbs swung below it as she adjusted it to point upward at her mouth.

It was only then, as her mouth was opening, and the purple-black dick was just in front of her lips, that Meri's downward gaze fluttered open, and she looked at Joel. Just in time for her eyes to meet his, as she grasped Andre's cock and rubbed it against her red tongue.

Joel couldn't be sure if she was asking for permission for what she was doing, seeking his approval from his expression. Or if she was already well beyond that point, and now just trying to burn him alive with jealousy. It didn't matter: he could only stare at her as she moved the cock around on the flat of her tongue, and Andre's right hand floated to the back of her head.

And then, unmistakably, Andre's voice. Low, almost too low to hear:

"Get it all in there, baby. I know you can do it."

Meri's mouth opened, and the fat purple meat slid through her lips, her eyes grew wide and wet as her jaw stretched open.

"You can do it," Andre said, his right hand exerting a gentle but obvious pressure on the back of her head. "Get it all, yeah, like that. You can do it," he murmured.

And then, he said something, but Joel could not be sure of what it was. Or if it was, as he believed: "This time."

Meri's nostrils flared and she closed her eyes. The cock disappeared into her throat until Andre's tight black curls of pubic hair, and bulging balls bumped against her chin. Meri's eyes opened, tears glistening at the corners at the effort of accommodating his size, his thickness, but this time she was looking up at Andre. Her hand had shifted to his muscular thigh, and her fingers dug into his flesh as he pushed her head closer to his groin, until her face was squished into his flesh and the entire length of his cock was stuffed in her mouth.

Joel's cock felt like it would burst right then. Meri had never sucked his cock like that before, if that's even what it was. But before he could even feel the sting of it, Andre let his hand drop slightly to cup Meri's head like a goblet, and he began to pull her away. She breathed heavily through her nose, and the slick black cock slid between her lips as her cheeks deflated. But Andre pushed her back down the length of his cock, and then began to push and pull her face along the fullness of his shaft relentlessly. The only sounds were Meri's struggled breathing through her nose, Andre's hungry panting, and the sticky slurp of Meri's mouth and throat as she swallowed Andre's cock again and again.

She gasped for air when he pushed her head back and let his cock fall from her lips. His fingers were entwined in her hair, and he tugged at it to tilt her face up to him. He pinched his cock in his left hand to wipe the

crown over Meri's lips. "Give me a smile, baby, show your hubby there how much you like that cock."

Meri looked at Joel, her eyes rolling to the side beneath her eyelids: Andre held her head back at such an angle that her eyes were nearly closed. His mouth was hanging open, he heard a puff of air escape his lips. Meri was panting a little, still getting her breath, and Andre's fat cock blocked the view of her mouth as it melted into a smile. A filthy smile, one that Joel had never seen her wear before.

Andre pulled her by the head to rise up on her knees. His free hand found the sly of her jeans, and deftly unbuttoned them, shoving his hand promptly into them. His wrist turned so that his hand was cupping her pussy, rubbing her, the sounds of her sticky juices reaching Joel just before the scent of her did.

She moaned as Andre began to stroke her quickly, and she would have squirmed, if she had been able to, but he had her head in such a fierce grip, and his other hand so deep inside of her, that she could do little more than moan and sway her hips as he made her come. She squealed and grabbed his forearm to grip it fiercely. "Oh, oh, oh God," she gasped. Her body jerked, and her eyes squeezed shut.

Andre didn't stop fingering her as her orgasm died down. The sounds of her gushing cunt were louder than her mewling, and her limbs jerked with his intense touch, but she was unable to do anything but spasm and sway, a limp rag doll impaled on his hand and held upright by his grasp of her hair.

At last, Andre let go of her head and let her fall backward, pulling his hand from inside her jeans and scooping her feet out from under her as he did. Meri pushed at the jeans, but Andrew finished them off, jerking them down and peeling them inside-out off her body. The crotch of her jeans was soaked through by her juices, and they landed with sopping plop on the floor.

Andre was already pushing her legs open, spreading them wide so that her gushing pussy smacked and slobbered, yawning open, a wide red mouth beneath the feathery landing strip of her pubic hair. It did not go unnoticed to Joel that she had trimmed herself up very nicely, and that her lips were bare and swollen, pink but hairless.

He stared at his wife's cunt as Andre held her right thigh to the bed and gave his own appraisal. Juices oozed from her cunt, dribbling between her

asscheeks, and the scent of her tangy pussy was everywhere.

Andre had climbed onto the bed on his knees. "Hold those legs open for me," he said, rising up to a kneel. He took his cock in his hand, stroking it almost absent-mindedly. Meri obeyed, spreading her legs wide, and as Andre's cock hovered over her pussy Joel realized how big it was, how much Meri's cunt would stretch when he sank inside of her.

"You ready for a great big black cock? Hmm?" Andre murmured.

Meri just gasped, staring at his dick. Perhaps the same thought as Joel's was now floating through her mind, and she hesitated as she lifted her head to look at it. She seemed to have forgotten that Joel was even there, and gave him no glance to seek his approval. Not that it mattered: Andre was already leaning over her, his right arm supporting his immense bulk so that Joel could watch in detail as his purple cock pressed against Meri's pussy. The crown of his dick was enormous, and for a brief second Joel thought he was going to have to stand up and pull the man back from his wife, whose dripping cunt seemed too small to accommodate him.

As he sank into Meri's gash, the wet and swollen flesh around her hole stretched out and seemed to disappear into a thin pink line to accommodate the girth of Andre's cock. Her pussy slurped at the tip of his dick, and there was a squelch as he sank into her, but as he drove in slowly, only a faint stickiness could be heard.

Meri's eyes were wide, and she had lifted her head to watch him disappear inside of her. A wail was leaving her mouth: it began as a mewl, grew in loudness and intensity until it was a low scream. Her right leg shook in her hand and she threw her head back, arching her spine. "Oh," she yelled, like she was going to scream "Oh, God," but her voice seemed to catch in her throat.

Andre scooped his hands underneath her ass and pulled her hips toward him. Meri's legs went limp and floppy as he jerked her onto him and thrust deep inside of her in one well-practiced motion.

Then Andre covered Meri's body, grasping both hands in a loose hold and pulling them up above her head. He fucked her slowly, staring at her face as he closed his other hand gently over her throat, where he could feel the moans that Joel could only hear. "Come for me again, baby. That's good. Just let me fuck you with that big black cock until you come like a good girl."

Meri was pinned down so completely that her writhing barely moved her. She was trying to buck against him, but he fucked her methodically and slowly until her moans turned to frantic squeals and she kicked at the bed. As a second orgasm shuddered through her, her legs twitched and Andre pushed his fingers into her throat, mangling her cries. Her legs went limp, and Andre continued to fuck her as she sobbed in ecstasy, saying over and over again, "Stop, it's too much."

But it wasn't. Andre pushed himself up and Meri lay limp beneath him, legs spread, trembling slightly. "That's good," he said. "Now you're ready. Now we can get dirty."

He pushed himself up and sat on his knees again. His cock was glistening with Meri's cum. Joel could tell that he was ready to explode, avoiding touching his dick, which bobbed in the air. "You the kind of girl who gets *real* dirty for her husband? You the kind of white girl who lets a black man put his cock in her ass and fill her up with cum? Hmm?"

Andre looked over his shoulder with a grin. "That what kind of wife you have? Or should I just fuck my cum all over her face?"

Joel was unable to speak for a second. Andre had turned back to Meri before he heard his own voice saying, "It's up to her," but he couldn't tell if Andre had heard him.

"Hmm, you little slut? You want to bend over and take it, don't you?"

A pang of fear clawed at Joel's insides: Meri didn't do anal, and the sheer size of Andre's cock made it an obvious no-go. What would he do if things got out of control now? A man whose balls were as ready to explode as Andre's were now, who had already sloshed around in a woman's pussy and had her swallow his cock, was not going to just politely leave if he really wanted to fuck her ass full of cum.

But this fear dissolved, replaced by something even more terrible almost immediately, as Meri rolled over onto her stomach, pushed up on her hands and knees, and tossed her hair over her shoulder when she looked back at Andre. "I don't know if I can get it in," she said, her voice dripping with a slutty tone she had never - ever - used. Her face was blotchy and covered in sweat and spit, the lipstick and mascara even more smeared than before. Between her legs, her pussy throbbed, red and swollen, underneath her pink eyelet. Her ass was ever-so-slightly distended, Joel couldn't be sure if it was from his finger-fucking in the alley, earlier, or something Andre had done later.

She arched her back and pushed her ass toward Andre. "Be gentle, and you can try."

Andre was already sliding his fingers from the gushing maw of her pussy, up to her already wet ass, his thumb playing with her hole for a few seconds before dipping in. Meri watched him until his thumb plunged into her ass, and then she threw her head back and faced the headboard, moaning.

Joel stared as Andre fucked her with his thumb, and then dipped two fingers into her, and then a third. Andre jerked her spread legs together, and pushed her down to the mattress, where her hair splayed out and she tipped her face so that her eyes were on Joel's as Andre fucked her ass with his three big fingers and Meri mewled, but left her ass in the air for him obediently.

"That's good, you got it," Andre said, in a low voice. "You can take it all, just a little bit more, I'm gonna get my cock nice and wet first, and then I'm gonna slide it in. Yeah, you're ready for it," he said.

Andre slid into her pussy and fucked her, with his hand still in her ass, as Meri's eyes went wide and her mouth opened in an expression of disbelief, a silent howl slipping between her lips. She started to push up, but Andre caught her by the upper back and pushed her down again, pulling his dick from her pussy and then sliding his fingers from her ass slowly. He pressed the crown of his cock against her gaping hole, and it still seemed far too big to ever fit, even though she was stretched out.

"It's too big," Meri said, into the sheets.

"Just relax, you can take it," Andre said. "Do it for your hubby there, he wants to see you get fucked full of cum." Andre pushed closer and Meri howled, but the rubbery lip of Andre's dick edged forward and then sank inside of her, and Meri went quiet again, her eyes wide open, as the thick inches of Andre's cock gradually disappeared into her ass.

"That's good," Andre said. "Yeah, just get used to it." He put his hands on her ass. "Oh fuck, that feels good, your ass is so tight, just hold still, baby, you're gonna make me come before I get to fuck you."

Meri's ankles twisted between Andre's legs, and she balled up the duvet cover in her fists, looking at Joel again. "It's so big," she said vacantly, to no one in particular.

Then Andre started to fuck her, and her breath seemed to be stolen from her throat with a gasp. "Mmm," Andre commented, rocking back and

forth as his meat plunged stickily in and out of Meri's ass. "Just relax, baby, you can take it, daddy's gonna give you a big load of cum if you're good."

Meri looked at Joel as Andre sawed in and out of her, bringing her fingers to her mouth and pulling lightly on her lower lip. Andre started to thrust into her hard, and her torso and head dragged back and then pushed forward on the bed. Andre's thighs started to slap against her ass, and Joel could hear a groan from deep inside of him as he slapped harder and harder, until finally he grabbed her hips and pushed in deep, yelling loudly as Meri squealed and Andre's load burst inside of her.

Andre thrust a few more times, and the sound of his cock in Meri's ass was a fleshy slurp each time as the final spurts of his cum filled her. "Fuck yeah," he growled. "There you go. Mmm," he said, a big hand landing on her right ass-cheek with a damp slap.

Andre was breathing hard as he straightened up, his hands still on Meri's ass, kneading her butt absently. He slowly withdrew from inside of her, and his cock slipped out and slapped against his inner thigh. Joel tore his eyes away from Meri's face, to the gaping hole above her gash. The stretched red mouth of her ass dribbled a creamy glob of cum, and her legs trembled, before she rolled to the side and fell onto her back, legs still between Andre's. She drew her arm over her chest, and looked up at Andre, who was kneeling over her, panting from the exertion.

Joel's cock was so hard he wasn't sure if he could get out the chair. Andre walked himself back on the bed and then stood at the end of it, taking his cock in his hand and stroking it lightly. "Damn," he commented.

Then he turned and cast an eye around the room, settling on a bottle of water, which he opened and gulped, as Meri pushed herself up to sitting on one hip, looking thoroughly used and slightly dazed. Andre turned to Joel. "So... what y'all do now?" he asked, wiping the water from his mouth. He looked down at Joel's erection quickly, and then set the water down. "No offense, but I'm not really into hanging around a whole lot afterward."

Meri brought her hand to her mouth and chewed on her thumbnail, looking sheepishly at Joel. Her shoulder hunched in a small shrug. She didn't know what to do.

Andre looked from Joel to Meri, and then scooped up his clothes. "Right," he said, standing up and pulling on his undershirt. Looking at Meri, he grinned. "You know where to find me. If y'all don't mind, I'm gonna bounce, though."

He looked at Joel, shook his head a little, and walked into the bathroom.

Meri looked at Joel, a little scared now. They listened as Andre's slacks clinked against something in the bathroom, the toilet flushed, and the door opened. "Later," he said casually. Joel stared at Meri, saw Andre in the periphery of his vision as the door clicked and then swung slowly closed. When the second click broke through the tense silence, he exhaled.

Meri was still looking at him. "Oh my God," she whispered. "I can't believe..." she looked around her, as if she were just waking up from a dream. "Joel, I can't believe I just... did that."

Her eyes met his again. He was standing up, taking off his clothes. His cock ached so much that he grimaced as he pulled his boxers over his swollen member. Meri's eyes dropped to look at him, then fluttered back to his face.

He was approaching the bed. Meri looked uncertain for a moment, but as he climbed onto the edge of it, cock in hand, she seemed to gather some confidence. "I can't believe I did it," she said. "Are you... okay?"

Joel reached for her leg and pulled it open, then grabbed both of her ankles and pulled her toward him. The scent of her pussy, and the acrid scent of Andre's cum, mingled in the air and drove him wild. "You let him fuck you in the ass," he said quietly, his hand traveling down her sticky thigh to her swollen pussy. She shuddered when he touched her clit, and inhaled sharply.

"I thought you... wanted that..." she murmured, watching his fingers as he played with her soaked pussy.

"Did you like it?" he said.

Meri looked hesitant.

"Tell the truth," Joel breathed.

"Yes," Meri said, almost too quickly.

Joel sat down on his heels, playing with her sopping cunt. She was stretched out, filthily wet, and cum dripped from her ass and soaked into the sheets. "Is your ass sore?" he said. "Too sore to go again?"

Meri bit her lip and nodded.

"Get up here," Joel said, pulling her toward him. "Get on my cock and ride it."

Meri twisted and climbed onto him. Her pussy dripped onto his cock before it even touched her hole, and then she swallowed him up in her

almost too-wet cunt. The weight of her body rested on his lap, and he pulled her legs around him.

"Meri," he breathed into her neck. He looked down to play with her nipples, again a stab of pleasurable pain ricocheting through him when he saw their swollen redness. "What did you do with Andre before you got here?" His cock pulsed inside of her, and she arched her back against his fingers, her long neck stretching before his eyes, displaying the blotchy traces of Andre's affections.

"Joel," she mewled, and leaned forward to put her mouth on his shoulder. "I..."

He pushed deep into her body, making her wet pussy ooze her juices onto his balls. His hand traveled down to her ass, where he navigated the wet crevice to find her sore and gaping hole, still ripe for pillaging with his fingers. Inside her ass, he could feel the pressure of his cock against her cavities, as his fingers were drenched with Andre's cum.

"Tell me what you did," he breathed. Meri was rocking on top of him, and he wasn't going to be able to hold out much longer, but he wanted to feel her come again before he was finished with her. He drove his fingers into her ass and gripped her left buttock to hold her still as she squirmed on top of him. She let out an anguished cry of disappointment. "Tell me," he repeated.

Meri's fingers dug into his back, and she squirmed on top of him, but the pain of her nails was good; it steadied him enough to wait her out.

"I just... I made out with him," she howled, in a hoarse whisper. "I thought, I thought, I thought it was what you wanted, Joel, please..." she pulled her body closer to him, grinding her sloppy mess against his pubic bone and crushing him between her crossed ankles and her pussy. His cock throbbed again inside of her, he could feel it with his fingers.

"It's good, Meri," he breathed. "It's good, you did so good. Tell me what you did, and then I'll let you come."

Meri moaned again and tried to move side to side, rubbing her pussy against him. "Joel, please," she said. She had dropped her head back again, and her mouth was open. The image of her smeared lipstick filtered through his mind, snippets of what Andre had said to her when she sucked his cock...

"Did you suck his cock? Before you got here?" With the hand he was using to support her back, he slid up and tilted her head back toward him, so

that her forehead touched his and their eyes were locked. "You can tell me, it's what I want, tell me what you did."

Another mewl vibrated on Meri's lips, and she twisted against him, but he gripped her hard and stopped her with his controlling hand in her ass.

"Joel..." she moaned. "Okay, okay, I did it, before we got here, I told him what you wanted, I told him you wanted to watch, and he... just... pushed my hand down and told me to get a feel for it... he said it would be a better show if he... if I... so I did it, I sucked his cock...oh, Joel..."

"Did you get on your knees for him?"

Meri moaned and whimpered as she tried to squirm again. "I'm so close, Joel," she said.

Joel massaged his fingers against the hard lump of his cock, through her canal, and she shuddered. "My ass," she complained, breathless, "it's so sore..."

"Tell me," he growled, but he didn't know how much longer he could hold out.

"I sucked his cock," she panted, "I got on my knees and sucked his cock."

Joel gripped her hair. "Did he come in your mouth?"

Meri's eyes were wide, and she tilted her head towards him, reading something in his face. Her lips trembled, and a smile flickered at the corner of her lips. "He came in my mouth... please, Joel..."

He thrust hard against her, pulling her down violently on his cock and pushing up to bury his dick in her as far as he could get, just as he exploded inside of her. She bounced against him, making herself come as his fingers slipped from inside her ass and the cum from another man sloshed out of her. Joel held himself up with his left hand as she rode him hard to wring every ounce of pleasure that she could from her own orgasm. His whole body had seized up violently as he dumped his load into her, and Meri was like another person, a wild animal, as she bounced until her own body went stiff and her pussy spasmed around his dick. The wail that left her mouth was a sound a wild animal would make, and she dug her fingers into his back.

Her body went limp almost as suddenly, and she leaned forward to rest her forehead against his again. They were both covered in a slippery sheen of sweat. His dick was still pulsing wildly inside of her.

They panted silently, heads touching, until at last Meri lifted her eyes to meet his. "Joel," she whispered. "Oh God."

He kissed her, trying to explain with his mouth when words would fail, that it was okay, everything she had done was okay. He rose up to push her down to the bed and cover her body with his, without leaving the sopping channel of her cunt. He was still hard inside of her, his orgasm having shaken him violently but not drained him: maybe so much time building up and watching his wife fuck like a slut couldn't be rid from his body or mind with a single orgasm.

Once she was on her back, he pushed away her hair, strands of it sticking to her face. He touched her lips, her cheeks, her neck, and her body reacted to every touch with a wild sensitivity, sending shudders he could feel through her body and squeezing his reinvigorating cock. When he was fully hard again, Meri's eyes went wide with amazement.

He began to fuck her, and she whined, shaking her head from side to side. "Oh, Joel," she panted. "I'm so... I'm so sore.." Her legs were limp and spread below him, her body unable to respond except to lie there.

"I'll go slow," he said, and he would, and he did. He fucked her gently until her body began to activate again, her pussy gripping him, her hips coming up to meet his, her lips searching for his mouth hungrily.

They came at the same time, again, many minutes later, Meri's face frozen in a silent scream as she folded herself up and toward him, her thighs shaking next to his hips. His seed filled her overflowing pussy yet again, and his head fell forward onto her shoulder.

He wasn't sure how long he lay there, Meri beneath him. Eventually he rolled away, his cock finally slipping from inside of her with a squelch. Meri's eyes were heavy and she barely opened them. He touched her lips and kissed her on the forehead. "That was beautiful, Meri," he murmured. "I love you, I'm so proud of you."

"I love you," Meri said, but she seemed almost asleep by the time "you" left her lips.

CHAPTER 12

Meri was in the shower when he woke up, and he was groggy, slightly hungover, and took a few minutes to piece together the evening from his hazy, disbelieving memory. He lay with his face staring up at the ceiling, an erection growing again, his gut twisting with cool pain, jealousy, and delight. Meri had actually done this: his fantasy had actually *happened*.

What was nagging at him, then? Hadn't it been just what he had desired, and more? He had vague remnants of dreams that left him unsettled: Meri telling him she was meeting Andre for breakfast, Meri leaving before she fucked him, Meri ignoring him while he fucked her. And there was probably more, and yet none of that had happened.

The shower turned off with a loud water hammer, and he pushed himself up on his elbows to wait for Meri to emerge. When she did, she was wrapped in a white towel, her wet hair down around her shoulders as she toweled it with another. Her skin was pink with heat. Nothing unusual there, Meri loved her showers hot enough to cook a lobster.

She met his eyes with a shy smile. "Hi," she said.

He folded his knees and hooked his elbows around them, in part to hide his erection, in part to look more casual than he felt. "You okay?" he asked.

Meri paused the toweling of her hair for a moment, then shrugged sheepishly as she began again, her eyes diverted. "Just... well, sore," she said. She hung the towel on the back of a chair and turned to face him, chewing on her lip. "I can't... believe I did... we did that," she said.

He extended his hands and clapped his fingers against his palms to encourage her to come to him. She did, looking down at the bed, running her fingers on the edge of it. "Is everything okay?" she said in a whisper. She put a knee on the edge of the bed.

"Come here," he said.

She edged toward him on her knees, and he rolled onto his knees to embrace her. "That was... incredibly hot. I promise. It's what I wanted."

He touched her chest, playing his fingers across her skin above the towel line for a few strokes, before tugging at the center of it to pull it down. "I promise," he said.

The towel fell away, and her bright pink skin let off a faint, humid, flowery scent. A drop of water rolled down her right breast and paused on her nipple. The redness of her skin had melted into the freshly scrubbed, hot pink of her skin, but her nipples were still used, swollen. Andre must have manhandled her a little. His cock pulsed. "Are you okay with everything?"

"I guess... yeah... if you are," she said.

He guided her hand to his cock, and she closed her fingers around it, feeling for herself whether he was, or wasn't. "It's good," he told her. "Promise."

"I have to tell you something," Meri said, uncertainly.

Joel felt his equilibrium lurch again, and his breath caught in his throat.

"I didn't actually, you know... suck Andre's cock last night," she said. "I mean - before." She brought her hand up to her mouth to suppress an awkward smile. "Obviously..." she looked to the side. "Later."

Joel wasn't sure why, but the debris left by his dreams fluttered away. After all, he had wanted her to have done that, wanted her to tell him that she had. "Really?" he said. "Then why...?"

Meri shook her head. "I made out with him," she said. "But then... you seemed to want me to have done it and, I don't know, in the heat of the moment, I said it. But, it wasn't true."

Joel adjusted her so that she was on top of him.

"Would you want it to be true?" she asked, settling onto his lap, her pussy wet on the top of his shaft.

"I just want you to tell me the truth," he said. His cock pulsed against her pussy, and she shifted on top of him.

She grinned, jutting her jaw a little, and looked like she was going to say something, but instead slipped her hand between them to guide his cock inside of her.

They made love again, this time without reference to Andre or the night before, without dirty talk or wild positions, but it was incredibly hot in a way that kind of straightforward sex had never been. They came at the same time, eyes locked, and Joel pushed her hair away from her face to watch her as she shuddered beneath him and around him.

Joel rolled over on his side, and they faced each other, fingers entwined. A knock at the door was the only reason they didn't remain like that forever.

"Shit," Joel said, after sending housekeeping away. "It's almost ten-thirty."

Meri sat up. "When's checkout?"

He reached over her to grab the leather guidebook. He flipped through it. "Yikes," he said. "Eleven."

Meri started to climb out of bed, but he held her by the arm. "Let's..." he said, releasing her to grab the phone. "See if we can extend our stay," he finished. "I'm not quite ready to get back to the real world."

As he listened to the phone ringing, and Meri grinned at him sheepishly, running her hands through her hair, they felt a vibration at the foot of the bed.

The front desk answered, and Joel spoke to them as Meri fell forward onto her stomach, showing her lovely round ass, and a glimpse of her pussy and the neat pink eyelet of her asshole, returned to normal as though she had never taken a huge black cock inside of it just a few hours before. She fished her phone from the purse she had dropped on the floor next to the bed, and hung over the end of it, swiping, while Joel booked the room for a second night.

She looked back at him when he hung up, with a sheepish grin. "Fevr," she said, dropping her phone.

Joel leaned back, pulling the sheets away, showing her that he was ready to go again. Meri shook her head. "Maybe you want to send a few messages."

She propped her head up on her hand, and smiled at him. "Andre was just thanking me for the lovely time," she told him. "He says he can be my bull any time."

"Mmm," Joel said.

"But, I think..." Meri said, pushing herself up to her knees and climbing toward him. "I have enough on my hands..." She closed her hand around Joel's cock, and lowered herself down to place her lips close to his crown.

When she finished her sentence, her breath was hot, cooling on the smeared precum that covered his dick.

"...for now."

END

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